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INDIA AIRLIFTS MORE AID, LOOKS AT BAILEY BRIDGES TO HELP RELIEF EFFORTS

Nepal races against time to look for survivors, 290 Indians still missing

Death toll now 392, hundreds missing; China alerts Nepal about threat from new barrier lake

Yubraj Ghimire, Divya A & Shubhjit Roy
Kathmandu, New Delhi, August 27

WITH HUNDREDS still missing in Nepal a day after a flash flood ravaged several districts in the country's north, rescuers searched mud-filled valleys and hills for survivors as the official death count climbed to 392 Thursday night.

In New Delhi, the Ministry of External Affairs said at least 290 Indians were still missing and around 200 others were stranded on the Chinese side of the Sino-Nepal border. It said India was in contact with authorities in Nepal and China to coordinate their rescue.

As the Nepal Army and security personnel stepped up search and rescue operations, the flood forecasting division of the Meteorology Department, quoting Chinese officials, warned about the formation of "a significant barrier lake" on



Schoolchildren at an Army rescue camp in Nepal's Nuwakot district, Thursday. P11

Relief for some, anxious wait for many: 'Tell us how they are, where they are...'

Arun Janardhanan & Sujit Bisoiy
Chennai, Bhubaneswar, August 27

THREE PILGRIMS from Tamil Nadu's Hosur, an Australia-based couple from Odisha, and the wife of a former MLA from Bengal were among scores of tourists from India who are still missing in the aftermath of the devastating flash flood that



Missing: Sandeep Mohapatra, wife Siddharthi Kumari Sahu

struck Nepal on Wednesday. Anxious family members, dealing with unreachable networks and mobile phones switched off, are knocking at every possible door to get word on the whereabouts of their loved ones.

According to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), 290 Indian nationals are still out of contact in Nepal.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Hydel plant in Nepal feeding power to India among several units hit

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, August 27

A HYDROPOWER plant that supplies electricity to India was among the power plants hit by Wednesday's flash flood in Nepal. Authorities were assessing the extent of damage to scores of power plants which cater to the bulk of Nepal's electricity needs.

A senior Indian government official told *The Indian Express*

THE EDITORIAL PAGE
HIMALAYA NEEDS SHARED SYSTEM FOR EARLY WARNING P 10

Thursday that Nepal slashed its power supply to India by half, from around 800 megawatts (MW) to at least 400 MW. The 14-MW Devighat hydropower plant that supplies power to

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Hanging glacier collapse in focus, NDMA for hard look to reduce future risks

Nikhil Ghanekar & Amitabh Sinha
New Delhi, August 27

WITH THE spotlight now on the collapse of a hanging glacier as the likely trigger for the devastating flash flood in Nepal, the incident is being closely monitored by the disaster management establishment in India where similar disasters have

happened in the recent past.

The National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) said Thursday it was planning to initiate a comprehensive study on the Nepal event.

"Many areas in India are vulnerable to the kind of

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Thread and butter!



Penguin India won't publish Sonia's book, had asked for 'changes' which author rejected

Ritu Sarin
New Delhi, August 27

PENGUIN RANDOM House India (PRHI), expected to publish 'Belonging: A Journey of Love', the much-anticipated memoirs of Congress leader Sonia Gandhi, in India, will not do so, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Sources said this was precipitated by certain "editorial changes and deletions" that Penguin Random House India wanted in "a part of the

manuscript" which was turned down by the author.

With Penguin India out, several Indian publishers are now in the fray and Harper Collins is reported to be close to finalising the agreement to publish and distribute the book in India.

The release, scheduled for November 10, was first announced by US-based Alfred A Knopf, a division of Penguin Random House. Knopf had added

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

INSIDE

NEPAL DISASTER
'TWO BUSES AHEAD SWEEP AWAY' MAN RECOUNTS ESCAPE P 6

EXPLAINED
ECHOES OF THE PAST AND WARNING FOR FUTURE P 12

THE WORLD
'CAN'T EXPLAIN HOW BIG WAVES WERE' P 14

Nadda meets anti-quota protesters: 'Talks cordial, will meet again soon'

Lalmani Verma, Liz Mathew & Jatin Anand
Lucknow, New Delhi, August 27

UNION MINISTER J P Nadda on Thursday met members of the "Reservation Hatao Andolan (RHA)", days after hundreds gathered at Jantar Mantar demanding that affirmative ac-

tion be based on economic criteria rather than caste.

In a post on X, Nadda said "cordial discussions" took place with the RHA's Harsh Dubey, Ran Bahadur Singh Chauhan, and Mrityunjay Pathak. The meeting came days after a delegation led by Dubey met Uttar Pradesh Deputy Chief Minister

Brajesh Pathak, who assured them he would take up their demands with the BJP brass and arrange their meeting with a Union Minister. Pathak and the delegation also addressed a press conference.

Following the movement that took place at Jantar Mantar

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

6-month plot, 3 states, iCloud use: CBI joins the dots on Adhikari aide killing

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, August 27

THE KILLING in May of Chandranath Rath, personal assistant to Suwendu Adhikari, days before he took charge as West Bengal Chief Minister, was the culmination of an alleged conspiracy hatched over six months. The CBI uncovered



Chandranath Rath was shot dead in his car on May 6. FILE

the plot using digital evidence, including a photo on iCloud, and by joining the dots between CCTV footage, road tolls and multiple phones, including one at the bottom of the Hooghly river, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The CBI filed a chargesheet before the Additional Chief

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Business as Usual

By EP UNNYY



Happening today

● UNION FINANCE Minister Nir-mala Sitharaman will visit the US where she will lead an Indian delegation at the G20 Finance Ministers and Central Bank Governors meet under the US Presidency of the G20 and participate in an Investor Roundtable.

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● 'HAVE TO MAKE INDIA AN ATTRACTIVE CASE ON ITS OWN MERIT AND NOT JUST BECAUSE IT'S CHINA PLUS ONE'

Goyal: Ready to act on feedback, expect Japanese investments to pick up pace

PAGE 1 anchor

Sandeep Singh
Osaka, August 27

New Delhi is not only seeking higher investments from Japan but is keen to deepen its economic partnership with Tokyo. In an interview to *The Indian Express*, Commerce and Indus-

try Minister Piyush Goyal said after his four-day visit to Tokyo, Nagoya and Osaka, he hoped that the pace of investment will pick up further. To increase its presence in Japan, he said India must strive to become its global sourcing partner, and that businesses need to be more outward-looking. Edited excerpts:

How far do you think review of trade deals



PIYUSH GOYAL
UNION COMMERCE AND INDUSTRY MINISTER

signed with Japan will yield benefits for India?

It took us so many years to get them to the table to talk. As of now, even terms of reference have not been discussed. We have just done a macro level opening.

But we will enter the Japanese market for our goods and bring them more and more to India so that they naturally

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

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[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Nepal

The Tibetan side which posed a new threat. This prompted anti-ethnic to alert residents on either side of the Trishuli river to take safety measures and exercise extreme caution.

The warning, which was reported by China Central Television, stated: "A significant barrier lake has formed near the confluence of the Chhochen and Purepu Tsangpo rivers across the border in Tibet with its current water volume estimated at 2 million cubic metres as of Thursday morning with the lake already overflowing. Another 3 million cubic metres of water is expected to flow into the lake over the next three days, posing a high risk of a breach."

So far, over 1,000 people have been moved to safety, 60 per

cent of them from the worst-hit Rasuwa district alone. Government officials have been checking with travel agents about pilgrims who had arrived in Nepal for the journey to Kailash Mansarovar.

In New Delhi, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar held a meeting with top officials and India's envoys to Kathmandu and Beijing. He said India was making "urgent efforts" to ascertain the status and well-being of Indians stuck in flood-hit areas.

Since Wednesday night, India had sent a total of 47.5 tonnes of emergency supplies to Nepal in two military transport aircraft and was in the process of sending more relief material. India was also looking to send Bailey bridges to help with the rescue and relief efforts in Nepal — many bridges there have been swept away in the flash flood.

Randhir Jaiswal, spokesperson

for the Ministry of External Affairs, said the rising Indians in Nepal included those working on hydroproject projects and tourist groups from different states including Tamil Nadu and West Bengal.

"There are 288 Indian nationals who remain uncontactable. These include 73 Indian nationals who are working on the Trishuli Central Hydropower project. Our embassy in Kathmandu is in touch with the project head to get more details about these people," he said.

The Ministry later revised the number of missing Indians from 288 to 290.

"We have rescued 21 Indian nationals who are from Tamil Nadu... We have received information that a number of Indian nationals who had gone on the Mansarovar Yatra are stranded on the Chinese side," he said, adding that around 200

Indian nationals have sought assistance for evacuation.

After chairing the relief effort meeting, Jaishankar said: "Urgent efforts are underway to ascertain the status and well-being of all Indians in the flood-affected areas." He said his ministry was coordinating with various ministries, state governments, tour operators and other relevant authorities.

"We are working closely with the Nepali side, both on this aspect and on the relief efforts," he said. India sent a second supply of 37.5 tonnes of relief supplies in a military transport aircraft to Nepal Thursday, a day after it dispatched 10 tonnes of HADR materials, Assistance and Disaster Relief materials.

"A second flight has just taken off, carrying 37.5 tonnes of HADR material, medicines and food packets for Nepal," Jaishankar said.

Goyal

start making India's global source portfolio. Whether the export to Japan or export anywhere else in the world, I don't mind as long as jobs come to India and import substitution ends in India.

In all the FTAs we have put some unique element, and we have negotiated from a position of strength. Like, we have done with the European Free Trade Association (EFTA) that includes Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway, and Switzerland and they have committed \$100 billion investment. If they don't bring, then I can clawback concessions. Similarly, New Zealand has committed \$20 billion investment.

What is the progress on investment promises of \$70 billion by Japan?

It was announced last year, and in 10 months it has already reached \$10 billion. After this visit, it will pick up further. They are looking for projects. I met the chairman of a large textile retailer here and he said that he wants to come to India in a big way. "India is my only horizon," he said. They have 1,000 stores in China and 4,000 stores worldwide. As they come, the quality consciousness will improve and even exports will improve as they look for projects. In one of my meetings with regard to the semiconductor industry, we took a decision quickly and I have already instructed lawyers, and instructed my ministry to prepare a framework.

Has there been any discussion with Japan on job creation?

We have discussed with companies across industries including shipping, chemicals, hi-tech and different types of services sectors and they will train around 3 lakh Indian youths in Japan.

You have made references to China in your address, including a comment that seemed to be a reference to Jack Ma. What is your view on China?

It was on a lighter note. We support enterprises, entrepreneurs. We protect them, we protect technology, we protect data. I have never said that they should move their investments from China. India on its own should be an attractive destination. See, they want to diversify their supply chains but for that India is not the only place, they can go anywhere. We have to make India an attractive case on its own merit and not just because

it's China plus one.

Are there opportunities that India sees vis-a-vis Japan-China ties?

What is happening between them and another country is not something for us to interfere in. We are focussing on our own strengths. Automobiles have become a strength area; so are textile, footwear, leather, precision engineering, aerospace and defence. We have done well on mobile phones and so we are moving forward on areas where our strength lies.

We have to stand on our own feet and become an international player. We have done FTA covering 38 countries (all rich countries) and we have opened up two-thirds of global trade for India.

What are some of the challenges that Japanese firms are pointing out, which are hindering investment?

They have indicated they are having challenges, particularly at the local body level and in some states, but it's a mix of factors. Some of them have had such wonderful experiences. They come and share that your government has transformed investments in India.

Everybody has some thoughts and suggestions that you may amend this to make it easier. We take this feedback very seriously. In one of my meetings with regard to the semiconductor industry, we took a decision quickly and I have already instructed lawyers, and instructed my ministry to prepare a framework.

Can you elaborate on the case?

Tokyo Electron is a semiconductor company that is planning to come to India. They raised concerns with me over BIS certification. They need over 13,000 parts. As they source it from all around the world, it was a herculean task to get BIS certification for each of them. They make high quality semiconductor so they can take care of that themselves.

On that basis, for specific industries, which are hi-tech industries, we said we will make a new rule or a new regulation. They want to create a new rule or regulation by which we can give either a company-wide exemption or exemption to make semiconductors.

In another case, somebody wanted approval for SEZ in Dholera. I talked to Mr Harsh Sanghvi about it. He said he was waiting for a large group to cer-

tify as to what is the ecosystem, how much land they want and he would immediately apply for SEZ approval and my ministry will immediately process it. So we ourselves are excited and want companies to come that can resolve issues they face so that we can rescue them.

You spoke about the \$100 billion EFTA investment commitment. What are your expectations from there?

We are still working on which specific areas. Pharmaceutical is one major area that they are working on, where they think that clinical trials and innovation in India can be done in a big way and large amounts can be invested.

We also are very keen to shift their high precision and middle SMEs to India. They don't have labour there as it's too expensive. At best, what they will produce, they will use locally because they can afford high prices. So they are all looking for Indian partnerships. Now, the Indians have to go and make connections and partnerships, bring technology.

You said Indian businesses are complacent. Can you elaborate?

I am doing it all the time. I am talking to Indian businesses, telling them to be more outward looking, to go and explore the world. Hon'ble Prime Minister has directed all our missions to focus on technology, trade and tourism.

I mean geopolitics has now become economics geopolitics or economic diplomacy. Earlier our embassies used to stay away from business, now they are changing. We are saying we will market our business companies, not one particular company. We are encouraging Indian industry and we are willing to stand by Indian industry. We have to stand up for our investors.

India, US ties have recently shown some stability. The first set of Section 301 tariffs have not been extremely harsh like they were last year. Some companies are also getting back their tariffs refunds and RBI on Monday said that India is better prepared to handle Section 301 tariffs. Is the year-long negotiations yielding fruits?

Section 301 is a mechanism that they have found to try and put duties on everybody in the world because the earlier tariffs got stuck down by the (US)/Su-

preme Court. So they are now attempting different ways to put tariffs. Our deal is kind of done, we have to now formalise it. We have to make sure that our tariff is lower than our competition, which is an assurance the US has given us. So Indonesia, Vietnam, all these countries are our neighbours and competitors, they have to make sure that we get a lower rate than them, which is a part of our agreement. After all, what is a free trade agreement? It's a preference you have over your competitor.

In the USA, we just want to make sure we get a better rate than the competition, then we can sign the deal.

But are things better with the US?

There is never had, it was just a small phase when the oil duty was imposed. Otherwise we have a very strong partnership. Trade is just one element, they are the largest investors. We have strategic defence tie-up, we have technology tie-up, we have a critical minerals tie-up. We are members of various groups, of Quad, and a lot of our interests align in WTO. So, America is very important and special.

We learn that India is looking to partner with countries to jointly explore opportunities in Africa.

Yes, we are having very active discussions. The concern is that India has manpower, skill and scale and the UAE has financial power. Together, if we go and invest in a third country, we can become a force multiplier. The UAE on its own cannot do it, because who will set up the infrastructure? Who will run the factories there? India has a requirement of capital to support this. The UAE has a lot of relationships in Africa, other countries, which gives them confidence when they are investing. We also have very good relations, but we need the capital. So together, we complement each other. Africa, gold and diamonds, both for services, for infrastructure projects, and for setting up factories.

With Japan, is India looking at securing rare earth and critical minerals?

We have been talking to them and there is already a serious dialogue with them. We are jointly developing technologies or exchange and transfer technology to help us become self-reliant in rare earth and critical minerals.

The correspondent is in Tokyo at the invitation of FICCI

Nadda

on 21 August, cordial discussions were held, as per the pre-determined schedule, with Harsh Dubey, Ran Bahadur Singh Chauhan, and Mrityunjay Patil, members of the team. In this connection, we had met again soon," Nadda wrote on X.

Dubey said the group held talks with the minister Wednesday. "Discussions took place over two days, Wednesday and Thursday. There will be a press conference on September 7, where our decision will be announced," he told The Indian Express. Dubey, a NEEET aspirant, and businessman Abhishek Agnihotri, his relative, were at the forefront of the Jantar Mantar demonstration.

"We presented the demand that reservation should be based on economic status. The minister assured that the government would consider our demands. We trust him and we are hopeful that the government will act on our demands. We had a discussion with the minister today for two hours and for three hours on Wednesday," said Chauhan, a retired Army officer from 3rd Kanakpur district. "But if the demands are not met, we will protest again at Jantar Mantar and with a bigger

crowd," Chauhan said.

The activist said anti-quota movement does not intend to encroach upon rights of SCs, STs, and OBCs. "They are our brothers. Reservation should depend on economic status. Creamy layer should be abolished," he said. Asked about alleged differences in the RFA, Dubey said, "(Some) people are just concerned with the politics of it, but I believe it would be better if they remain with the movement. If they deviate from it and only politicise it, it will be wrong."

In the BJP, the decision to engage with the anti-quota activists is seen as an attempt to placate the upper castes. These communities have been upset with the party of late, especially over the now-stayed UGC equity regulations aimed at preventing caste discrimination in higher education institutions.

The upper castes, a core constituency of the party since 1989, were unhappy with the regulations over their potential "misuse". BJP leaders said the upper castes had deeply antagonised the party and recent disaffection on caste census had intensified their unease.

The meetings — first with Patil and now Nadda — were an attempt to "pacify" them, assure them that the party would listen to them and to give them confidence that the party would ad-

dress their concerns," said a BJP insider.

"In the past, BJP's top leaders have made assurances that there will not be any change in the quota regime and it is impossible to go back on them. The voice of this (anti-reservation) group, which is getting traction among a significant section, is getting louder in many parts of the country, especially in UP, Uttarakhand, and Bihar. The party has to placate them," said a BJP leader from UP.

He said holding meetings would not satisfy them. "You can buy peace for a while with just a meeting. But you will have to answer their questions. Leaders want to know data-based information on the quota policy and its implications," the leaders said. BJP sources said addressing the concerns raised would be the party's "utmost priority" because "if a small section, even if 2-3%, sits at home during the next election, it will damage party's prospects in UP". According to estimates of BJP leaders, upper-caste communities such as Brahmins and Kshatriyas constitute over 20% of the electorate in the poll-bound state.

"They may have more leverage than Gen Z because they are not just a generation, they are a community," said a BJP leader in Purvanchal (eastern) and western UP," a party leader said.

Hydel

India was among the plants affected by the floods, the official said. India imports electricity from multiple hydroelectric power plants in Nepal.

According to data from Grid India, the power plant in Nepal from Nepal at the day's peak on August 26 when the flash flood struck. Two other hydroelectric plants, Chhillime and Trisuli, which supply electricity to Bangladesh, have also been affected.

Nepal's Energy Ministry, in a statement, said that around 13 hydroelectric power plants and a solar plant were affected. Floods affected nearly 359 MW of capacity, mostly hydro power, Energy Ministry's statement said.

Queries sent to the Ministry of Power and Grid India did not elicit a response. According to Nepal government, operational capacity of 226 MW and three under-construction major hydroproject plants with capacity of 342.42 MW have been affected in Rasuwa district. The affected projects include Uppatrisuli-I (216 MW), Rasuwagadhi (111 MW), Rasuwa Bhotokoshi (120 MW), Sanien Khola (78 MW), Uppatrisuli-II (64.2 MW), Maitling Khola (6 MW), Laikang Khola (20 MW) & Chhillime (22 MW).

from Anand, who were travelling to Kailash Mansarovar via Nepal. They were heading to the immigration office for their visas to cross into Tibet. They had an 8.30 am appointment... We have not been able to reach them since," said Nilesh, Bimalkumar's brother-in-law.

In Mehana, the family of 43-year-old Australian resident Bhavinkumar Rai is awaiting an update.

One identified as missing from Gujarat include Kinnari Patel, Mihir Patel, and Ashok Kapadi from Ahmedabad; US residents Paresh Patel and Jyoti Patel hailing from Surat; Jay Kotecha from Rajkot, and Roma Intwala from Valsad.

From Bengal, Sarishmita Kumar Singh (from Bihar) have been apprehended. The arrested include Sagar and his brother Saheb Sonkar (both from Kolkata); Uttar Pradesh residents Vikash Mishra, Vinay Rai, Sanjay Rai, Gyanendra Singh, Raj Kumar Singh, Golu Singh and Naveen Kumar Singh; and Bihar's Mayank Raj Mishra and Vikash Kumar Singh. Sonkar, Rath's 29-year-old assistant.

Rath was shot inside his vehicle in Madhyamgram in Kolkata around 10 pm on May 6. His associate Buddhadev Bera was injured in the attack.

The chargesheet names 12 people, of whom all but Krishna Kumar Singh (from Bihar) have been apprehended. The arrested include Sagar and his brother Saheb Sonkar (both from Kolkata); Uttar Pradesh residents Vikash Mishra, Vinay Rai, Sanjay Rai, Gyanendra Singh, Raj Kumar Singh, Golu Singh and Naveen Kumar Singh; and Bihar's Mayank Raj Mishra and Vikash Kumar Singh. Sonkar, Rath's 29-year-old assistant.

more than two months after CBI held 11 people, including four alleged shooters.

According to CBI probe, Sagar had allegedly come to re-

Adhikari

Judicial Magistrate's court in Barasat on August 7. The probe, it is learnt, states that the man who allegedly pulled the strings in the case was Rath, 29-year-old assistant.

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more than two months after CBI held 11 people, including four alleged shooters.

According to CBI probe, Sagar had allegedly come to re-

sent Rath as he saw himself as his equal and believed that getting him out of the way was the only way he could get close to Adhikari. Sometime in November 2025, the probe found, he allegedly "toped in his brother Saheb to procure phones and SIM cards in the names of other persons".

Next, Sagar allegedly brought in Vikash Mishra, a school friend, who in turn knew Vinay Rai. The CBI claims WhatsApp call records show Sagar and Mishra, a resident of Salempur in Deoria, were in constant touch from January 20, 2026, onwards, allegedly "with the intent to hire contract killers".

On January 30 this year, Vikash Mishra called Vinay Rai on WhatsApp, the probe found. There were more calls between Sagar, Mishra and Rai, investigators said, alleging that on February 6, "in order to arrange the shooters... Vinay Rai contacted his associate Buddhadev Bera, who was at Surat... and asked him to come to Dhanbad".

According to CBI, after Sanjay Rai came to Dhanbad, Mishra arranged a meeting between him, Vinay Rai and Sagar, where

"the modalities for committing the murder were allegedly discussed". Investigators say this was followed by trips between Dhanbad, Kolkata, Ballia, Ghazipur and other locations.

Not long after his meeting with Sagar, Sanjay Rai allegedly arrived in Kolkata and checked into a hotel under the name "Pankaj Singh". On February 18, says the agency, Sagar allegedly told Sanjay Rai on a record of Madhyamgram, and of Rath's office, the Assembly and HC areas. An Uber driver allegedly identified the two. Sanjay Rai went back to Dhanbad on February 18, but reportedly came back for reconnaissance in March and April.

On April 7, Sanjay Rai, Gyanendra Singh and Raj Kumar Singh visited a vehicle dealer in Patuli (Kolkata) and examined a Maruti Swift, as per CCTV footage procured by CBI. On April 18, the vehicle was bought for Rs 3.80 lakh, with CCTV footage and road toll records allegedly showing trips made in it to Dhanbad. CBI says the accused also acquired a Nissan Micra and a Hero Super Splendor motorcycle, with the engine and chas-

sis numbers of both obliterated. All vehicles were fitted with fake registration plates, as per CBI.

On May 3, CCTV footage and FASTag records purportedly show accused travelling from Dhanbad to Kolkata, and then going back via Birat. Next two days, Sanjay Rai and Gyanendra Singh allegedly made, including preparation of another number plate for Nissan Micra. The shooters allegedly travelled to Kolkata from Dhanbad the same day, i.e. May 6. CBI claims that Sagar informed Sanjay Rai of Rath's location over FaceTime, and that Rai passed information on to Gyanendra and Krishna.

One significant finding, as per the CBI, was a photograph of Rath on an iCloud account linked to one of the numbers, loaded onto the cloud on March 18, when the phone was at Madhyamgram. CBI claims to have found at least one FaceTime conversation between the two phones allegedly being used by Sagar and Sanjay Rai shortly after the killing. Another call followed soon after, and CBI believes Sagar placed it to ascertain Rath's condition.

Anxious wait

On Thursday, many of the survivors, including a group of footballers from Odisha and their coach, reported safe although a number of them remain stranded. The Hosur pilgrims were part of a 57-member group that left through a Kumbakonam-based agency on Sunday. Officials said that 20 members of the group were safe, but there was no verified information about the others.

Roopalakshmi, whose mother-in-law was among the pilgrims, said, "We haven't received any details... We have come to know that 20 of them are safe. My mother-in-law's name is not among them." She said the telephone numbers broadcast as emergency helplines had elicited no response. "I really want the government to tell us how they are, where they are..." she said.

Two other Hosur residents, Thimarayassamy and his wife, Mamtha, were part of the same pilgrimage, according to his younger brother, Anand. "We have been calling them since

morning, but have been unable to connect to all," Anand said.

Separately, the Isha Foundation said it had lost contact with an 80-member international group returning from the Kailash Mansarovar pilgrimage. Founder Jaggi Vasudev said the group was believed to have reached an immigration building shortly before the flood struck. "The entire group must have been in that building," he said.

From Odisha, Sandeep Mohapatra, his wife Siddharthi Kumar Sahu and a 20-year-old woman are reported missing. From Khurda district, the couple had been living in Australia for the last eight years. They reached Nepal on August 22nd and had plans to visit Odisha thereafter. Their phones were switched off. "The couple's last location was detected near the immigration centre when the flood struck," said Pritish Panda, the nodal officer appointed by the state government to coordinate with authorities.

A missing 20-year-old from Baripada town in Mayurbhanj district had gone to Nepal with friends for trekking. A team of six football players from Odisha along with their coach Halim, who went to Pokhara for a

match, are reported safe and so is Puri native Rakesh Kumar Panda who is on his way back to India. Several persons from Andhra Pradesh have been identified as stranded or missing in Nepal. Four have been traced and are safe, and efforts are underway to locate three missing persons, said minister N Lokesh Naidu. Among the missing are Rajyalakshmi Nimmagadda and Sasi Kumar, part of Isha Foundation group. Bhaskar Shastri and three others from Adoni and Kurnool have been confirmed to be safe but remain stranded. They were part of a 156-member group travelling to Kailash Mansarovar.

From Kerala, 53 people, including a husband and wife resident Kallad, are stranded in Nepal. In a video shared by one of the travelling groups, the 35-member team got stranded in a forest while moving in two mini buses to Pokhara city.

In Gujarat, an agnising wait continues for families after 18 people from the state, including a husband and wife, Kailash Mansarovar pilgrims, went missing or lost contact.

Among those said to be missing are a US-based couple, Bimalkumar Patel, 47, and Jainima Patel, 43, originally

tions, their actions and even their human failings... My story also offers readers a unique perspective of the social and political changes I have witnessed for six decades."

Earlier this year, PRHI had issued a statement that it had "not printed" former Army chief K. J. Somiah's book, "The Soldier's Story". PRHI had said the book's title "Four Stars of Destiny" had a hard copy of the title was flashed by Rahul Gandhi in Parliament. Excerpts from the memoirs, including Naravane's account of the India-China clashes in Galwan and the Agni-path scheme, had been expressed in the news.

In June this year, The Indian Express had first reported how PRHI pulled the plug on a candid graphic novelist Joe Sacco's book on the Muzaffarnagar riots titled "The One and Future Riot". Then, CEO Shrinagar had said that the publisher had raised some "content issues" with the author. Sacco's legal scrutiny process which included a map showing inaccurate boundaries of India.

Glacier

disaster we have just seen in Nepal. We have had such events in the past. So it is important for us to study this, and understand this. We do plan to look at it in detail," Krishna Kumar Singh, a member, NDMA, said.

India has had several major flash flood incidents in recent years, including the Kedarnath tragedy in 2013, the Shimoli disaster in 2021, the Chamoli lake burst in 2023 and in Dharali last year. These incidents claimed hundreds of lives and caused large-scale damage.

Following the Chamoli incident in 2021, the NDMA had initiated an effort to mitigate the risks from such events through the installation of early warning systems on glacial lakes considered vulnerable to breaches.

The National GLOF Risk Management Program seeks to strengthen the boundaries of these glacial lakes in the four hilly states of Arunachal Pradesh, Sikkim, Uttarakhand and Himachal Pradesh, and equip them with early warning systems. The programme covers the Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh as well. In April 2024, ISRO has revealed that of 2,431 glacial lakes larger than 10 hectares in size in India, 1,000 are at high risk of glacier mass and the swollen channel of the Roshote Khosi river.

"This programme is progressing well. It will take some time, but this will help in significantly reducing the risks from glacial outbursts. The Nepal incident just reinforces the importance of this programme. Simultaneous efforts to create capabilities in forecasting landslides, and develop a landslide early warning system, are also extremely crucial. Experimental landslide forecasts are already being done in some areas. These are very important," Vatsa said.

While scientists are still trying to assess the exact trigger for the Nepal flash flood, glaciologists and AI Kulkarni of the Indian Institute of Science said the col-

lapse of a large chunk of snow and rocks from a hanging glacier was the most likely cause. He likened the fall of this chunk to "a high-intensity bomb blast".

The National Remote Sensing Centre Thursday released satellite images of before and after the event, which, too, indicated the collapse of a glacier mass and the swollen channel of the Roshote Khosi river.

"From various satellite images and evidence available as on Thursday, it can be said that a hanging glacier collapsed vertically with a drop of between 1.5-2 km into a deglaciated valley. The drop was quite steep and the mass of ice that crashed must have generated immense energy. The force of the steep drop together with the debris, water available in the deglaciated valley is likely to have unleashed the flood," Kulkarni told The Indian Express.

He said he likened it to a hydrogen bomb blast as the large mass of ice dropped on a soft bed of moraine and debris in a deglaciated area, which means

that it was once covered by ice.

"The impact converts the ice into smaller pieces or flakes," he said. The NRSC's preliminary satellite-based assessment indicated that an ice-avalanche may have temporarily blocked a river and then suddenly released the impounded water and debris. On the collapse of the glacier, it was difficult to say with certainty at this point whether the glacier collapse or ice-avalanche created a temporary blockage of the river water which was eventually breached due to pressure.

On Wednesday, the US Geological Services reported an earthquake of 4.4 magnitude around the area just before the event. That was widely believed to have been the trigger. But on Thursday it revised its assessment and said "additional analysis of long period seismic waves indicate that the seismic energy was instead generated by a glacial collapse and debris bomb blast as the assessment put the magnitude of the seismic signal to be of magnitude 5.2."



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MAX: 34-36
1.9°C above normal

MIN: 25-27
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• AQI Tracker

Alipur Satisfactory AQI: 73

Mundla Moderate AQI: 147

Dwarka Poor AQI: 207

Anand Vihar Poor AQI: 328

● Good (50-50)

● Satisfactory (51-100)

● Moderate (101-200)

● Poor (201-300)

● Very Poor (301-400)

● Severe (401-500)

166 new H1N1 cases

New Delhi: Delhi reported 166 fresh H1N1 cases in the last 24 hours, taking the cumulative tally to 2,612.

The cumulative number of influenza A cases in H1N1 category has also risen to around 3,300 from 3,177 reported a day earlier, according to Delhi government data. PTI

Caught breaking a traffic rule in Capital? Your local cop can now issue an e-challan

Sakshi Chand

New Delhi, August 27

DELHI POLICE personnel posted at police stations and other units will soon be able to initiate action against traffic rule violators using an e-challan application on their mobile phones, significantly expanding the force available for traffic enforcement in the Capital.

How will it work?

Under the new system, police personnel will be able to photograph vehicles violating traffic rules and upload the details on the e-challan app. The information will then be processed through the system and a challan notice issued to the registered owner of the vehicle.

At present, local police personnel who spot traffic violations have to involve the Traffic Police to issue a challan.

Delhi Govt invites bid for scheme offering Rs 10 L medical cover for families of construction workers

Gayathri Mani

New Delhi, August 27

THE DELHI Government has invited bids for the Delhi Building and Construction Workers Health Scheme, which will provide around 2.7 lakh registered construction workers and their families in the Capital with free annual health check-ups and several medical services worth up to Rs 10 lakh per year.

According to officials, the government has invited bids from central and state public sector undertakings (PSUs) to appoint a Project Implementing Agency (PIA) for providing construction workers and their families with annual health check-ups, OPD (Outpatient Department) and IPD (Inpatient Department) services through empanelled hospitals, laboratories and clinics, as well as its own facilities, officials said on Thursday.

The scheme was approved by the cabinet chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta in June. The scheme is expected to cover nearly 10 lakh beneficiaries in the city with providing free and quality healthcare services to construction workers and their eligible family members, including spouses, children and parents. Under the scheme, officials said, each



LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta visit a state-of-the-art lecture hall at Indira Gandhi Delhi Technical University for Women at Kashmere Gate, in New Delhi on Thursday. ANI

registered worker will be entitled to treatment of up to Rs 2 lakh at empanelled hospitals, while the limit for a family will be up to Rs 10 lakh.

"Construction workers are particularly vulnerable to extreme conditions, which can lead to health related risks. In this context, the Board aims to ensure the timely health screening of approximately 2.70 lakh registered workers and their families to support their health, safety, and overall working conditions...the number of beneficiaries and strengthening the

social security framework for building and construction workers, said officials. Officials said that the number of beneficiaries has been estimated as per the records available with the board but "actual screening may vary depending upon beneficiary availability, field verification, operational feasibility, and administrative approval."

circumstances like a worksite accident or medical emergency, officials said.

"Coverage shall be on a per-beneficiary basis per financial year and shall include diagnostics, medicines and hospitalisation," an official said.

The selected PIA will also establish a 24x7 Toll-free helpline and call center to provide beneficiary support for healthcare services and establish minimum six labs spread evenly across the city, an official said.

Officials said that the PIA will also test all the samples in its own laboratories. It will also be tasked to maintain electronic medical records through central dashboard of cloud based system developed by it on their own cost for DBOCWW board, they added. "PIA shall ensure that the beneficiaries availing healthcare services under Delhi State health scheme or any other govt schemes shall not be eligible for availability benefits under this scheme (the Delhi Building and Construction Workers Health Scheme)," read a document.

The annual health check-up package, conducted by the PIA under the approved government health department scheme, will be Rs 2,000 for men and Rs 2,200 for women workers.

Delhi govt plans to appoint transaction advisor to assess its land and buildings

Express News Service

New Delhi, August 27

DELHI GOVERNMENT is planning to engage a professional transaction advisor to conduct a comprehensive assessment of its land and building assets, which can be redeveloped and commercially utilised.

According to officials, the aim is to assess the existing assets and redevelop it for optimal commercial utilisation. "It will also help in identification of revenue-enhancement opportuni-

ties and development of financially viable models for under-utilised assets," said an official.

These assets include Varun-alaya/Jhandewalan office premises as well as residential housing at Haiderpur and Lajpat Nagar.

"The objective is to unlock the value of DJB's existing assets and generate additional sustainable revenue without compromising operational requirements," said the official. The government, through the IT department, had devel-

oped a portal named Delhi Asset Management Information System (DAMIS) — a centralised, digital and GIS enabled repository of all government owned land and properties.

Under this, the government urged all its departments to submit details of land parcels and properties under them so that it can use the same to build schools and hospitals, among others. Various departments have already uploaded details of nearly 14,000 properties on the DAMIS, said officials.

ATTEMPT TO IDENTITY DELHIITES

Check missing person reports, Chief Secy tells DMs after flash floods in Nepal

Gayathri Mani

New Delhi, August 27

DELHI CHIEF Secretary Rajeev Verma has directed all district magistrates in the Capital to co-ordinate with the Delhi Police on missing persons' complaints registered in the city to find out if any resident has gone missing during the recent Nepal flash floods, officials said on Thursday. The flash flood on Wednesday claimed at least 392 lives, while thousands, including 290 Indians, have been reported missing so far.

Officials said that the district magistrates have also been asked to approach private tour operators to ascertain how many residents of Delhi travelled to Nepal through them and whether they have received any complaint yet.

"This is to ensure prompt action can be taken to rescue those who may have been stranded and assist their families," said a senior Revenue department official.

According to a statement shared by the Chief Minister's Office, a group of 25 people from Delhi had visited Mansarovar before the tragedy hit Nepal and have now returned. "Information about those who went on personal tours is being collected," the statement read.

"People visit Mansarovar after registering for trips organised by the Ministry of External Affairs... As per information shared by the Centre, 25 recently went to Nepal through a tour facilitated by the government and they already returned to Delhi before the disaster happened... as of now, no one has approached us, nor

have we received any missing complaint. However, the Delhi government is taking all necessary steps and putting efforts to help people..." said a senior official.

The Transport department, meanwhile, has closed bus services between Delhi and Kathmandu. "...a Flash Flood hits Nepal on 26.08.2026 due to which approximately 160 people have been killed and hundreds are missing, after a massive flash flood road transportation was completely shut on National Highway, Delhi-Kathmandu Route in Nepal at present," read a government order.

The Delhi-Kathmandu International bus services, officially known as Indo-Nepal Maitri Bus Sewa, operates from the Dr. Ambedkar Stadium Terminal near Delhi Gate. The Delhi Transport Corporation has now cancelled trips to and from Nepal, scheduled for Friday and Saturday.

A senior transport official said, "Buses between Delhi and Nepal run on alternate days. The buses that arrive from Nepal and those routed from Delhi to the neighbouring country are currently stuck at the check post... With the current situation being critical, the Transport department has decided to cancel all trips till Monday. If the situation gets normal by then, the services will resume."

Delhi-Kathmandu Maitri Bus Sewa operates six days a week, with DTC buses running on Mondays, Wednesdays and Fridays, while buses operated by Nepal's Manjusree Yatayat run on Tuesdays, Thursdays and Saturdays.

PUBLIC NOTICE
PUBLIC NOTICE
FOR INVITING OBJECTIONS REGARDING AMENDMENT IN PROJECT REGISTRATION NAMELY
"ASTER AVENUE 36"
LOCATED AT SECTOR 36, SOHNA, GURGRAM BEING DEVELOPED BY M/S AS DEVELOPERS PVT. LTD.

It is for the information of the general public and the allottees of the project, namely "Aster Avenue 36", situated in Sector-36, Sohna, Gurugram, that an application dated 19.08.2026 has been submitted by M/s AS Developers Pvt. Ltd. for amendment of the registration certificate no. 104 of 2024 of the project. The project, which is registered with the Department of Town & Country Planning, Haryana in favour of Sh. Anshu Kumar S/o Sh. Baldev Kumar S/o Sh. Mahesh Kumar S/o Sh. Hari Chand and M/s AS Developers Pvt. Ltd. in collaboration with M/s AS Developers Pvt. Ltd., for setting up an Affordable Group Housing Colony over an additional area measuring 1.37 acres (in addition to Licence No. 253 of 2023) in Sector-36, Sohna, thereby making the total project area 9.860 acres.

The Promoter obtained the revised demarcation-cum-zoning plan and phasing plan of the project vide DTPC Memo No. ZP-1049/DTPA/2024/14070 dated 09.05.2024. As per the phasing plan approved on 09.05.2024, the entire project comprises two phases, namely Phase I measuring 7.207 acres and Phase II measuring 2.477 acres. Further, the Promoter obtained approval of the building plans vide Memo No. ZP-1049/DTPA/2024/02070 dated 09.07.2024 from DTPC-Haryana.

Thereafter, the aforesaid project namely "Aster Avenue 36" was registered with the Authority vide Registration Certificate No. 104 of 2024, dated 19.08.2024. Subsequently, the Promoter obtained approval of the building plans vide Memo No. ZP-1049/DTPA/2024/02070 dated 09.07.2024 from DTPC-Haryana.

The proposed changes include an increase in the number of shops in Commercial-1 from 39 to 43. The Promoter has disclosed that 18 shops in Commercial-1 have already been sold. In respect of Commercial-2, the Promoter has proposed a revised configuration comprising from 69 shops to 89 shops and 108 service apartments, and has stated that no third-party rights, sale, or transfer have been created in Commercial-2.

As per the provisions of Section 142(c)(i) of the Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Act, 2016, any alteration or addition to the sanctioned plan of the project requires the written consent of at least two-thirds of the allottees. As per the details submitted by the Promoter, all 788 residential units have been sold to 788 allottees. In respect of the commercial units, 18 out of 89 units have been sold, involving 16 unique allottees. The Promoter has further submitted the written consent of 724 unique allottees, comprising consents in respect of 514 residential units and 4 commercial units, which constitutes more than two-thirds of the total number of unique allottees in the project, for the revision of the approved building plans.

The Authority is considering the application submitted by the Promoter for amendment of the registration certificate under Section 4 of the Act of 2016 in respect of the aforesaid project and hereby invites objections, if any, in this regard.

The relevant application and related documents are available in the office of the Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Gurugram which can be seen by any concerned on any working day during office hours up to 11.09.2026 from 11:00-4:00 PM for filing of objections to the above application dated 19.08.2024.

Any such objections shall be filed in the registry of the Authority up to 11.09.2026 till 4:00 PM. Also, if anyone wishes to appear, may appear before the Authority on 14.09.2026 at 11:00 AM during the hearing.

Given under the approval of the Authority and its seal.

Dated: 28.08.2026

Secretary,
Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Gurugram.

EXPRESS Careers

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4	Rajarshi Chhatrapati Shahu College, Kolhapur, Dist.-Kolhapur	1	Shivaji University, Kolhapur	
5	Balwant College, Vita, Dist.-Sangli	1		
6	Sharadchandra Pawar Mahavidyalaya, Lonand, Dist.-Satara	1		
7	Yashwantrao Chavan Mahavidyalaya, Pachwad, Dist.-Satara	1		
8	Arts and Commerce College, Madha, Dist.-Solapur	1	Purnyashlok Ahilyadevi Holkar Solapur University, Solapur	Principal Open to All
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12	Maharaja Ajayashir Shinde Mahavidyalaya, Shrigonda, Dist.-Ahilyanagar	1		
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फॉर्म-6
नए मतदाता के लिए
यदि आप 18 वर्ष की आयु पूर्ण कर चुके हैं और आपका नाम मतदाता सूची में नहीं है, तो फॉर्म-6 भरें।

फॉर्म-7
नाम हटाने के लिए
यदि कोई मतदाता स्थायी रूप से स्थानांतरित हो गया है, मृत्यु हो गई है या दोहराव (डुप्लीकेट) है, तो फॉर्म-7 भरें।

फॉर्म-8
विवरण सुधारने के लिए
यदि आपका नाम, आयु, पता, फोटो या अन्य विवरण में कोई गलती है, तो फॉर्म-8 भरें।

उपरोक्त फॉर्म 6 व 8 के साथ आवश्यक दस्तावेज एवं घोषणा-पत्र संलग्न करें।

फॉर्म के साथ आवश्यक दस्तावेज जमा करने के विकल्प

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50-km roads cleared this week: Demolition drive in Gurgaon now focuses on footpaths, cycle tracks

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, August 27



The drive underway at Gurgaon Sector 51 on Thursday. GMDA

TWENTY-THREE DAYS after assuring the Supreme Court that all illegal encroachments within its jurisdiction would be removed within two weeks, the Gurugram Metropolitan Development Authority (GMDA) has reclaimed 49.5 kilometres of road space this week, as per data shared by officials.

While earlier drives mainly targeted arterial roads, the focus this week was on freeing up footpaths, cycle tracks, and pedestrian walkways from commercial spillover and illegal construction. The authority deployed heavy machinery and multi-departmental teams on Monday, Wednesday and Thursday to dismantle permanent sheds, concrete ramps, and scrap shops that have long choked the city's right of way (ROW). ROW refers to public land legally meant for unobstructed roads, footpaths, utilities, and emergency access.

The enforcement drive cleared 16 km of roads in Sectors 30 to 41, Sohna Road, and Sectors 60 to 67 on Monday, officials said. On Wednesday, 18.5 km was covered at MG Road, Gwal Pahari Road, and Sectors

27 and 28. Illegal boards, slum clusters, and vendor carts were removed. A GMDA spokesperson said. Another 15 km was reclaimed on Thursday.

The drive also covered the upscale Golf Course Road and Vyapar Kendra Road and Basai Road, Sectors 101 to 106.

District Town Planner (Enforcement) Amit Madholia Thursday issued a warning against the commercial misuse of stilt parking too, stating that converting mandated parking floors into PG accommodations, guest houses or shops will invite sealing and demolition.

Recognising the chronic problem of quick re-encroachment once the bulldozers leave, GMDA Chief Executive Officer PC Meena has mandated strict post-demolition surveillance across the cleared stretches.

ACCUSED ON THE RUN; WOMAN CREMATED AMID HEAVY POLICE DEPLOYMENT

Months before West Delhi woman's killing: A tale of suicide attempt, drugs and abuse

Pragynesh
New Delhi, August 27

A SUICIDE attempt, followed by drug addiction and increasingly abusive behaviour, marked a dramatic change in 23-year-old Imran's life before he allegedly killed a 21-year-old woman at her West Delhi home on Wednesday.

Imran had entered Muskan's house in Tilak Nagar and allegedly strangled her and stabbed her multiple times in the stomach before fleeing.

Police said Muskan and Imran, who is on the run, met in 2024. At the time, Muskan was beginning to build a career as a content creator while pursuing a Bachelor of Arts degree through Delhi University's School of Open Learning, an officer said.

The two met at Seven Zone gym, about 2 km from Muskan's house. Imran had joined the gym as a trainer around four months ago, while Muskan joined soon after.

Police said things began to change about two months ago. Imran allegedly attempted suicide and subsequently became addicted to drugs. His behaviour towards Muskan also

turned abusive, prompting her to approach the police once, a senior officer said.

"He became abusive... Due to this, she went to the police once," the officer added.

The gym later fired Imran over what the trainer described as his "erratic behaviour".

Police said Imran, who had been booked in a culpable homicide case from 2021, subsequently went to a de-addiction centre.

When he returned, he allegedly met Muskan at a hotel on August 20.

"He was suspicious that she had been talking to another man and confronted her. This led to a fight between them," claimed an officer.

According to police, Imran reached Muskan's neighbourhood around 5.40 pm on Wednesday. Police said there was no sign of a forced entry into the house, and that Imran was likely let in.

She was alone at home. Her mother was out buying vegetables. Her two sisters were in Chandigarh.

"Muskan and Imran got into a heated argument. It appears that Imran strangled her before stabbing her multiple times in



Security was stepped up near the victim's house. RENUKA PURI

the abdomen with a knife he had brought with him. He then took her phone and fled," a senior officer said.

About 6.40 pm, the family's domestic help came to the house and found the door open. She saw that all the lights had been switched off, except

for the one in Muskan's room.

"She went inside and found Muskan, injured and bleeding. Hearing her screams, neighbours rushed to help and took Muskan to the hospital," the officer said.

Muskan was cremated around 3 pm on Thursday amid

heavy police deployment outside the crematorium ground. No media persons were allowed to enter.

Security was stepped up near her house. Barricades blocked the entry to the lane, with police officers questioning everyone trying to enter.

Muskan was one of four siblings raised by their mother, Kamlesh Sharma, after their father died about 15 years ago. Her mother works as a lab assistant at Guru Gobind Singh Hospital, a family friend said.

Her two older sisters include Anamika, while her younger brother is 18 years old. The family lived on the second floor of a building inside a narrow lane in Old Mahavir Nagar, a dense mix of shops and residential buildings in Tilak Nagar.

"Muskan had been pursuing content creation like her sister, Anamika, who is a model. She started earning enough to build a decent career," said a friend who lives three lanes away from her home.

Muskan's social media accounts show a young woman trying to establish herself in the world of content creation. Her Instagram is filled with professionally shot pictures from gymns and wedding wear, and a few more of her modelling shoots, along with reels she made while travelling and at home.

Imran's Instagram profile, meanwhile, largely reflects his life at the gym, with several reels of him working out.

EXPRESS special

Faridabad doctor's clients: Patient who sold drugs for Rs 40k, Afghan national who bought medicines

Manish Sharma arrested on April 21 with cancer medicines worth Rs 50 lakh

Pragynesh
New Delhi, August 27

A BLOOD cancer patient, desperate for a medicine after three others had failed to provide relief, got Iclusig — an advanced cancer drug not approved for sale in India — through a US-based patient assistance programme. When the drug did not suit him, he decided to sell it.

That was when 39-year-old Dr Manish Sharma, a resident of Faridabad in Haryana, allegedly stepped in.

In January 2024, Sharma — who had been running online pharmacy HK Pharmaceutical on IndiaMART portal since 2023 — bought two packs of Iclusig (ponatinib) from the patient for Rs 40,000, Delhi Police said. Each pack, containing 30 tablets, was worth more than Rs 17 lakh in the market.

According to the police, this was not an isolated transaction. For over a year, Sharma had allegedly been buying and selling expensive cancer medicines through his online pharmacy, including Darzalex and Human Albumin.

He had, police said, sold the two drugs to a patient from Afghanistan among others.

Sharma was arrested last Friday in Delhi with medicines worth more than Rs 50 lakh.

The orders

Police said Sharma's alleged dealings began with his IndiaMART listing for HK Pharmaceutical. Pharmacies and medi-

cine suppliers use the platform to list their businesses and provide contact numbers, through which customers and wholesalers can place orders.

In January 2024, a blood cancer patient contacted the number listed by Sharma. At least three medicines had failed to provide him relief, following which he was prescribed Iclusig, a drug that works by blocking proteins that promote tumour growth.

"A US-based organisation, Max US Foundation, had agreed to provide the medicine to the patient under a patient assistance programme and sent him batches of Iclusig," said a police officer.

"But even this medication was not suiting the patient. So, he decided to sell it," the officer added. Sharma allegedly agreed to buy two packs for Rs 40,000.

According to police, Sharma knew the real value of the drugs. For over a year, the officer said, his company had been sourcing and selling Darzalex 18 mg — banned in India — and Human Albumin Solution 20%.

"Darzalex is not entirely banned, just its 18 mg version. It's used as an antibody to treat plasma cancer in patients, and is priced at around Rs 2.27 lakh. Human Albumin is used to expand blood volume in cancer patients and maintain blood flow through their heart," said an officer.

Police said Sharma had already paid Rs 40,000 for



Packs of Iclusig and Darzalex seized by police from accused Manish Sharma (right). EXPRESS

batches of Darzalex and Albumin to sellers he contacted through IndiaMART and was planning to sell them.

Doctor who couldn't be

Sharma was born and brought up in a well-to-do family in Gwalior. He was the first in his family to pursue an MBBS after Class 12.

"But unable to get admission in a decent medical college in India, he went to Russia in 2010 to study medicine," the officer said.

He returned to India in 2014 and sat for the Foreign Medical Graduates Examination three to four times. But he failed to clear the test required for foreign-trained doctors to obtain a licence to practise in India, police said.

"He then started working at Park Hospital in Faridabad. While working, he met his wife, who is Ayurvedic doctor," the officer said.

In 2021, Sharma opened his own hospital, KMC Hospital, in Faridabad's Jawahar Colony. In



2023, he married his then girlfriend and opened another branch of the hospital in Sonaha, Haryana.

The businesses, however, struggled to meet their operating costs.

"They used to hire freelance doctors but the incurred cost was too much. So, they shut down the hospitals and transitioned into smaller medical businesses," said the officer.

The couple set up HK Polyclinic in Faridabad and started HK Pharmaceutical. The latter was registered on IndiaMART.

The arrest

To arrest Sharma, a team led by Inspector Pawan Kumar and Sub Inspector Anupama laid a trap. They placed a fake order

with Sharma and asked him to deliver the medicines near Sukhdav Vihar in Southeast Delhi. On April 21, he allegedly drove from his home in a Honda City carrying packs of Iclusig, Darzalex and Albumin.

"When he reached Sukhdav Vihar and got out of the car, he was apprehended... On verification, he was found to be Manish Sharma," said DCP Harsh Indora.

Four packs of Iclusig tablets, four 100-ml vials of Human Albumin Solution IP 20% and two boxes of Darzalex 1800 mg were seized from him.

"Inspection of some of these batches of Albumin and Darzalex revealed that they might have been produced in Turkey," the officer said.

Police suspect human carriers may have been used to bring the medicines into India through air or sea routes. "We are talking to customs regarding this," the officer said.

The officer added that inspectors linked to Darzalex and other brands examined some of the seized batches. "They suspected that the MRP stickers could be fakes. We are waiting the FSI report for confirmation if the medicines are authentic."

Following his arrest, Sharma allegedly told police that he had procured the Albumin and Darzalex from pharmacists in Patel Nagar in Delhi and Gurgaon in Haryana.

"But when we raided these places, we didn't find anything. We are trying to ascertain whether they got a tip about us coming or whether Dr Manish is lying. We are yet to confirm what the source of these medicines are," the officer said.

IIT DELHI STUDENT'S SUICIDE

Students want inquiry panel to probe claims victim's mother made to cops

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, August 27

FIVE DAYS after the alleged suicide of MSc Physics student Rishikesh Kumar, IIT Delhi late Wednesday reconstituted an external inquiry panel, to be now headed by retired Delhi High Court Judge Justice Mukta Gupta — an appointment that was sought by the students. But the move did little to halt the student mobilisation that began spontaneously on Monday and has since grown into a campus-wide protest.

The reason: The students now want the panel's terms of reference widened to include the serious allegations made by Kumar's mother to police and assessing whether those named should be held accountable. Initially, the panel was tasked with discussing Kumar's death with students, faculty and administrative offices; reviewing protocols and processes and submitting a report within two weeks.

In her complaint to the police, Rishikesh's mother had alleged that the IIT Delhi administration had not allotted her son a hostel and that he was humiliated by the college's dean. She claimed Rishikesh was told that there was no provision for "such children" to stay in the hostel. According to the complaint, the incident left Rishikesh deeply distressed.

The protest began on Monday with six students from different programmes, including PhD, MSc and BTech. With most students still in class, they approached classrooms and asked professors to release students early. "Some professors were very receptive. Some didn't take it very well," a student said.



At the protest on the campus on Thursday. EXPRESS

The gathering grew through the day, eventually drawing thousands of students. The student said around 1,700 people had joined a WhatsApp channel being used to coordinate the protest.

However, sustaining the protest alongside IIT Delhi's academic schedule has not been easy. Students have continued attending classes and laboratories while participating in the protest, pooling money for water, sandwiches and snacks. "People are tired. Many students are not able to eat on time," the student said, adding that still, students continued to protest because Kumar's death had resonated with their own experiences on campus.

The protests have also prompted students to share their experiences. One student, the protester said, recalled approaching a counsellor simply to be heard but being told: "Just go back and sleep for now."

"The protest is continuing because every student is somehow affected by the general unacceptance they have faced," the student said.

Students have particularly

objected to the administration's refusal to accept the demand for the resignation of the Associate Dean (Student Welfare). They said the demand is about accountability. "We were disturbed and disappointed when IIT Director explicitly told us that there cannot be any resignation. This complete denial has hurt the student community. We just want administration action against someone incompetent," the student said.

Students are now collecting emails, messages and testimonials from current and former students about alleged insensitive remarks by officials, faculty and staff. They also alleged that some professors had made comments linking academic performance and suicide while the protest was underway.

In a statement on Thursday, IIT Delhi said student wellbeing was a "fundamental prerequisite" for its academic ecosystem and cited measures already in place, including lighter first-semester credit loads, life-skills courses, academic flexibility, faculty mentorship and 24/7 counselling and psychiatric support.

● SOUTH CITY II RESIDENTS SAY OVERFLOWING MASTER DRAINS LEAVE THEM WITH NO OPTION

Upscale Gurgaon colony pumps out rainwater to save homes, gets FIR warning

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, August 27

AROUND 12.30 pm on Monday, S C Sharma, a 72-year-old tax consultant, was at home in Block A1 of Gurgaon's South City II when rainwater began entering houses in his lane.

Within minutes, the internal colony road was submerged, leaving residents with little choice but to switch on emergency dewatering pumps through his online pharmacy, including Darzalex and Human Albumin.

He had, police said, sold the two drugs to a patient from Afghanistan among others.

Sharma was arrested last Friday in Delhi with medicines worth more than Rs 50 lakh.

The orders

Police said Sharma's alleged dealings began with his IndiaMART listing for HK Pharmaceutical. Pharmacies and medi-

residents of the upscale plotted colony — where ground-floor plots command upwards of Rs 3 crore — and the GMDA.

On Tuesday, an official on duty warned residents that an FIR would be lodged against them for pumping water from the society onto the main road.

In a formal representation to GMDA Executive Engineer Ajaydev Singh Suhag, marked to CEO P C Meena, the South City II Residents' Welfare Association (RWA) flagged severe and recurrent waterlogging in Block A1 and also protested against the alleged FIR threat by GMDA Junior Engineer (JE) Sonu Kaushik.

RWA flags recurring flooding

According to the RWA, each time the city sees a spell of heavy rain, it causes the master stormwater and sewer lines along the Sector 47-49 dividing road to overflow.

This, it said, results in sewage and runoff flowing into Block A1 through internal drainage lines and from beneath the boundary wall adjoining the GMDA road.

The flooding directly impacts nearly 200 households. The RWA pointed out that even on July 9, 2024, approximately 160 houses had been severely affected, and a community dog died of electrocution during the waterlogging.



The point where pumps of South City II's A1 block discharge excess stormwater into surface drains of GMDA; (right) waterlogged street outside A1 block. GMDA OFFICIALS, EXPRESS

"We are not doing it out of choice," said Navdeep Yadav, president of the South City II RWA. "When the water volume



increases and the government agencies do not intervene, what other option do we have but to deploy our own tempo-

rary pumps so society roads can remain clear?"

RWA member Neeraj Yadav maintained that temporary pump arrangements remain the only lifeline for residents during torrential showers when master drains overflow into their homes.

'Surface drains not for pumped-out water'

Responding to the RWA, Suhag, it is learnt, told residents that surface drains are not meant for pumping society water. "The Municipal Corporation of Gurugram (MCG) officer concerned was requested to get the society's connection hooked into the master stormwater line, and not the roadside surface

drains," Suhag told the RWA.

Speaking to The Indian Express, JE Sonu Kaushik explained that the roadside surface drains are only 2 to 2.5 feet wide and are designed to carry runoff from the carriageway, rather than the high-volume discharge pumped out of residential complexes.

"We got the information from the labour supervisor of the workforce clearing the surface drains. I only warned them about pumping water onto the road, letting them know that if there are any further violations, an FIR may be filed. There was no threat," Kaushik said.

"Societies and commercial establishments dump water on the road like this and make 10

mm of rain seem like 50 mm, and then videos are flashed all over social media to defame authorities," he claimed.

Kaushik added that societies and residents must maintain their internal rainwater harvesting systems and instead push the burden onto public infrastructure.

He said GMDA officials had also warned the society on Friday against deploying pumps in this manner, but the warning was not heeded. "As per legal norms applicable, the FIR can be lodged under relevant sections regarding damage to public property," he said.

GMDA has not formally responded to the RWA's communications.

Maharajganj, Kushinagar districts on high alert in UP

Express News Service
Lucknow, August 27

MAHARAJGANJ AND Kushinagar districts in Uttar Pradesh remained on high alert on Thursday with officials monitoring the water level of rivers emanating from Himalayas, especially Gandak following Wednesday's devastating flash flood in neighbouring Nepal.

Three bodies, believed to have been swept downstream from Nepal, were recovered from Gandak in Maharajganj district on Thursday.

Officials have been directed to ensure that residents of vulnerable villages can be evacuated immediately if the situation deteriorates. Police stations and revenue department personnel have been deployed in riverine areas and equipped to begin rescue operations when required.

In Kushinagar, District Magistrate Mahendra Singh Tanwar and Superintendent of Police Keshav Kumar inspected vulnerable riverside villages and the Valmikinagar barrage.

The water discharge from the Valmikinagar Barrage on the Gandak River, which originates from the Kali and Trishuli rivers and is known as Narayani in Nepal until it enters India, peaked at around 1.5 lakh cusecs (cubic feet per second) on the intervening night of August 26 and 27, according to sources at the

The UP government says its priority is to safely evacuate stranded Indian citizens from Nepal

Central Water Commission (CWC). Since then, the discharge has receded steadily, falling to around 1.02 lakh cusecs by noon on Thursday and the current discharge remains well below the barrage's designed discharge capacity of 8.50 lakh cusecs, the sources said. Residents were advised to stay away from the river and low-lying areas and remain alert to official advisories.

Similarly, in Maharajganj, senior officials, including Additional DM Prashant Kumar, have been deployed in vulnerable riverine areas to monitor the water level and flow of the Gandak, Darjanyia, Tail Fall and other rivers and water channels receiving water from Nepal. The administration has also directed officials to use loudspeakers to alert residents in vulnerable villages. Drinking water, mobile toilets and other essentials are being arranged as a precaution.

The government said its priority was to safely evacuate stranded Indian citizens from Nepal and ensure that residents of vulnerable border villages have timely access to relief and

rescue assistance.

Three bodies, including two women, were spotted by a rescue team of the Sashstra Seema Bal being carried by the strong current of the Gandak river in Maharajganj. The team used a motorboat to retrieve the bodies and sent them to the district headquarters mortuary, officials said. Their identities have not yet been established, and the administration is coordinating with Nepal authorities to trace their relatives.

SSB Inspector Arun Pandey said three bodies are believed to have been swept into the Gandak from Nepal. With the river flowing rapidly following heavy flooding in Nepal, officials said more bodies could potentially be carried downstream.

Meanwhile, administration and police officials are monitoring the Gandak, known as the Narayani in Nepal, as well as other rivers and water channels emanating from Nepal.

The UP government has deployed one SDRF platoon comprising 32 personnel, along with 22 personnel of the 26th Battalion of the Provincial Armed Constabulary (PAC) to Nepal to assist in relief and evacuation operations.

A dedicated helpline, 1070, has been activated for relatives seeking information or assistance regarding UP residents stranded in Nepal.

Bihar CM conducts aerial survey along Gandak river

Patna: Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Thursday conducted an aerial survey of Bihar's northern border districts along the Gandak river basin, including Valmiki Nagar, Bagaha, Bettiah, and Motihari. The CM said ensuring the safety of communities in low-lying riparian zones and providing prompt relief remain the state's highest priority.

Choudhary held review meetings with local officials, instructing disaster management personnel and Water Resources Department (WRD) engineers to remain on high alert.

Local authorities in Bagaha reported that standard operating procedures (SOPs) were triggered early, with residents from vulnerable riverbanks safely relocated to higher ground and temporary shelters stocked with food and essential supplies. ENS

'We cannot just sit at home': Ranchi family wants to visit Nepal to find missing son

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, August 27

THE LAST 24 hours have been some of the worst the Ghosh family has been through. There's been no word on Ramprasad Ghosh since last evening, and with each passing hour, the Ghosh family's anxiety grows.

"It's been more than 24 hours. We have neither been able to speak to him nor received any information about him," Ramprasad's sister-in-law says anxiously.

The 41-year-old Ranchi man is one of 288 people missing after flash floods swept through parts of Nepal. The flash floods, triggered by an earthquake and an avalanche, have killed 359 people and left 1,500 people missing.

Of the 288 missing Indians, 73—including Ramprasad—were working on the Trishuli One hydroelectric site when the



Ram Prasad Ghosh's father and other family members show his photograph after he went missing while working at a project for a company based in Kathmandu. ANI

floods struck.

For the family, passing time brings more dread. "We spoke to him last on Tuesday," Diya says. "There's been no contact

since."

Ramprasad had been working on the project since last year. Back home, the family—his 75-year-old father, Ranjit

Kumar Ghosh, his older brother and his brother's family—have been in touch with the Jharkhand migrant workers' cell and have also contacted the Indian Embassy.

Shikha Lakra, head of the migrant workers' control room, said there was no information yet on Ramprasad's whereabouts. "We have written to them [the Indian consular authorities in Nepal] seeking an update," she said. "He is the only one who's untraceable in Jharkhand. The department had spoken to his family."

The family, meanwhile, is now making plans to travel to Nepal.

"We cannot just sit at home. We will leave tomorrow and see what we can do there. We will go and find him," Diya says, while his father, Ranjit Kumar Ghosh, adds: "Our only appeal is that he should be found as soon as possible and brought back home safely."

Prakriti International Documentary Film Festival

inviting entries
18th Prakriti International Documentary film festival
(South East Asia Region)



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India Tourism Development Corporation Limited
(A Government of India Undertaking)
Registered Office: SCORE Complex Gate 8, 6th Floor, 7 Connaught Place, New Delhi-110003
CIN: L74990DL196500094363, ☎ 011-24366303, 🌐 www.itdc.co.in

INTIMATION REGARDING 61st ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING (AGM)

It is hereby informed that the 61st AGM of the Company will be held on Tuesday, 22nd September 2026 at 1200 hours (IST) through Video Conferencing (VC)/Other Audio Visual Means (OAVM) in line with the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 and rules made thereunder read with circulars issued by MCA and SEBI. In this connection, following is informed:

1. Annual Report including AGM Notice of 61st AGM will be sent only through electronic mode to those shareholders whose email addresses are registered with the Company/depository participant.
2. Notice and Annual Report 2025-26 is available on ITDC website www.itdc.co.in, website of RTA, BSE and NSE.
3. Remote e-voting and e-voting at the AGM facility has been provided. Details are given in the AGM Notice. Voting period starts from Thursday, September 17, 2026 (09:00 a.m. (IST)) to Monday, September 21, 2026 (05:00 p.m. (IST)).
4. Procedure for E-voting, Voting at AGM, Registering email address, mandate for receiving dividends and other information for the shareholders have been described in detail in the AGM notice and are also available at the Website of the Company.
5. A letter with the web-link and path to the Annual Report 2025-26 and 61st AGM Notice is being sent to shareholders whose email addresses are not registered.

Shareholders are requested to scan the QR code given below for more details on 61st AGM of the Company. In case of any further assistance in this regard, shareholders may contact KFin Technologies Limited, RTA of the Company at: enward.rs@kfintech.com, or Contact No.: 1800 3094 001.

For India Tourism Development Corporation Limited
Sd/-
Date: 27.08.2026
Place: New Delhi
(Company Secretary)



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ICAR-INDIAN VETERINARY RESEARCH INSTITUTE
IZATNAGAR-243 122 (UP) INDIA
Website : www.ivri.nic.in
Walk in Interview

Walk-in-interviews have been scheduled for engagement of One Young Professional-II at ICAR-IVRI, Izatnagar in "Network Project on Agricultural Bioinformatics & Computational Biology". The engagement is purely temporary on contractual basis and there will be no provision of absorption/re-employment in ICAR or ICAR-IVRI on termination of the project.

A. ONE YOUNG PROFESSIONAL-II (Network Project on Agricultural Bioinformatics & Computational Biology): Eligible candidates will be interviewed on **22nd September, 2026 at 11:00 AM** at Bioinformatics centre, IVRI, Izatnagar.

Please visit Institute website www.ivri.nic.in for detail of advertisement and further updates and notifications regarding interview.

(Dr Amit Kumar)
Principal Investigator

स्नेह की डोर और सुरक्षा के विश्वास से सजे

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सत्यमेव जयते
दिल्ली सरकार

विद्या वाहिनी योजना : फ्री साइकिल

होली-दिलाली पर फ्री गैस सिलिंडर

फ्री एचपीटी वैक्सीन

नाइट शिफ्ट में काम करने की अनुमति

सहेली फिंक स्मार्ट कार्ड: फ्री बस टैवल

502 पालना केंद्र: कामकाजी माताओं को सहारा

दिल्ली लक्ष्मी योजना : ₹2,500 प्रतिमाह

लक्ष्मि बिदिया योजना: जन्म से ग्रैजुएशन तक आर्थिक सपोर्ट

DIP/Shabbardh/Display/079/26-27

Nepal Disaster

FRIDAY, AUGUST 28, 2026

ACROSS INDIA, PRAYERS FOR THE MISSING AND AN AGONISING WAIT

'A torrent of mud, rocks & ice'

'2 buses ahead swept away':
Karnataka man on lucky escape



Mallinath Kolkundi (extreme left) and other members of the group at the start of the journey.

Kiran Parashar
Bengaluru, August 27

"WE HEARD a deafening roar, and within seconds, before anyone could even comprehend what was happening, everything in front of us was destroyed," recalled Mallinath Kolkundi, 50, a pilgrim from Karnataka who narrowly escaped the devastating flash floods in Nepal on Wednesday. The deluge has claimed over 350 lives as of now, leaving scores missing, in the facility was entirely obliterated. His wife and two children are in Australia, and his parents in Dharwad, and they have appealed to the government for urgent assistance.

Part of a 25-member tour group that left Hyderabad on August 21, the duo had obtained their visa clearances on August 25. On Wednesday around 6 am, they boarded two buses toward the border.

Recalling the horror, Mallinath said the flood struck around 9.30 am while they were on their way.

"Our vehicle was barely 200 metres from the flood zone. Seeing the wall of water, our bus driver immediately executed a sharp turn and rushed to higher ground, which saved our lives," Mallinath said.

"There was nothing anyone could do. It was pure chance. Most people had no time to react; they were either starting or returning from their pilgrimage." A massive torrent of mud, water, rocks, and ice carved a path of destruction extending up to 64 km, sweeping away hotels, roads, and border infrastructure.

"In a matter of seconds, everything was wiped out. Two buses ahead of us were completely washed away, and I don't think bodies can even be retrieved from there," he added. "The hotel where we stayed and the immigration office were supposed to visit no longer existed; there is no trace left. By God's grace, we survived."

Mallinath and Sangamesh remain stranded, waiting for

road connectivity to be restored so they can return home.

While some survived, anxiety continues for families of other pilgrims. Rakesh Naik, a Dharwad native residing in Australia, went missing near the border. Rakesh was part of an Isha Foundation contingent on the Mansarovar circuit.

According to his brother-in-law, Praveen, Rakesh had reached Delhi on August 12 and was returning from the pilgrimage. "He called us around 3.30 am on Wednesday to say they were returning and planned to reach Kathmandu by morning before catching an evening flight to Australia," Praveen said.

Rakesh is believed to have been inside the border immigration centre when the floods struck; the facility was entirely obliterated. His wife and two children are in Australia, and his parents in Dharwad, and they have appealed to the government for urgent assistance.

Another survivor, Murali S, noted that several sites where his group had stayed just days earlier were washed away. "All the places we stayed, including hotels and administrative buildings, have been destroyed. We are lucky to be alive," he said.

Addressing the crisis, Deputy Chief Minister G Parameshwara confirmed that state authorities are actively tracking stranded citizens.

"We have information that eight people from Bengaluru are stranded in Nepal, and steps are being taken to rescue them. We have no reports of fatalities among Karnataka residents so far," Parameshwara said.

S Honnappa, Commissioner of the Karnataka State Disaster Management Authority (KSDMA), said that 13 inquiries had been received via state helplines. "We managed to establish contact with three individuals, who confirmed that a group of 23 people from Karnataka are safe. Severe network outages are hampering communication, but efforts are ongoing," she said.

Family members seeking information regarding stranded people can reach out to the state control room: 1070 / 080-22253707.



(Clockwise from top) A child traverses a sludgy street; children undergo treatment at a search and rescue camp; army personnel comfort infants, in Nepal on Thursday. PH

NRI couple unreachable, 12-yr-old son & kin await word

Aditi Raja
Vadodra, August 27

AS FLASH floods wreaked havoc in Nepal, an agonising wait has begun for families across Gujarat after 12 people from the state, including six non-resident Indians (NRIs) and several Kailash Mansarovar pilgrims, went missing or lost contact in the disaster-hit regions near the Tibet border.

According to data compiled by the State Emergency Operation Centre (SEOC) on Thursday afternoon, the uncontactable people hail from Ahmedabad, Anand, Surat, Valsad, and Rajkot, as well as those of Gujarati origin residing in the US and Australia.

Among those listed are a US-based couple, Bimalkumar Patel, 47, and Jaimina Patel, 43, originally from Anand, who were travelling to Kailash Mansarovar via Nepal.

"They had finished local sightseeing and were heading to the immigration office for their visas to cross into Tibet. They had an 8.30 am appointment... We have not been able to reach them since," said Nishlesh Patel, Bimalkumar's brother-in-law.

The couple's 12-year-old son remained in Anand with relatives. "He did not want to travel and stayed back," Nishlesh added.

Similarly, in Mehsana, the family of 43-year-old Australian resident Bhavinkumar Raval is awaiting an update from local officials. Bhavinkumar had arrived in India to embark on the pilgrimage with three friends.

According to authorities and family members, several untraced travellers had taken the Kerung route for the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra and were near the Bhoti Koshi River and Friendship Bridge along the Rasuwagadhi-Kerung border when the floods struck.

Kailash Mansarovar Yatra bookings saw a marked surge in '26

Divya A

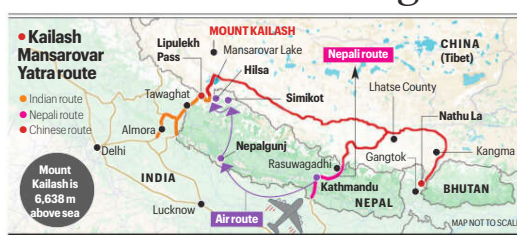
New Delhi, August 27

FOR FIVE years between 2020 and 2025, the Kailash Mansarovar remained out of bounds for Indian visitors in the wake of the Covid-19 pandemic and the Galwan standoff that strained India-China ties.

In late 2024, as New Delhi and Beijing began efforts to repair ties, the resumption of the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra in the summer of 2025 was the first tangible takeaway of the thaw.

As people waited to see how the resumption of the yatra panned out in 2025, when the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) took 750 Indian passport holders in batches, this year saw a rebound in the number of visitors to Kailash Mansarovar.

While the MEA marginally increased the quota from 750 to 1,000, the private operators — who take visitors through Kathmandu checkpoints such as Rasuwagadhi and Hilsa — saw a



marked surge in 2026. Though an exact count of the number of Indians who signed up for Kailash Yatra through private operators this year is not officially compiled yet, China had announced a cap on the total permissible quota for Indian passport holders via Nepal routes at 24,000 for the season. The quota was 20,000 in 2025.

A major tour operator based in Kathmandu told *The Indian*

Express that a huge number of experiential Indian travellers, including over a thousand Indian passport holders residing abroad (NRIs), had signed up for the yatra through their agency. "Despite rising costs owing to inflation, and increased fees and charges for allied services, this year saw maximum bookings so far," he said.

As the yatra took off in June, there were reports of Indian

citizens undertaking private tours being able to cross over to Tibet. On June 27, the MEA had issued an advisory to citizens to not commence their journey unless all permits were received.

"The Ministry is in receipt of several requests for help and assistance from Indian citizens stuck in Nepal while undertaking Kailash Mansarovar Yatra without the required entry per-

mit and visas for China, through tours organised by private operators," the MEA had said.

Before the yatra suspension in 2020, the government programme generally accommodated 800-1,000 pilgrims annually. For 2025, the capacity was 750 pilgrims — 250 through the Lipulekh route in five batches and 500 through the Nathu La route in 10 batches.

Beyond its spiritual significance, the yatra is also one of the world's most logistically complex pilgrimages. Located in China's Tibet Autonomous Region, it requires extensive diplomatic coordination between New Delhi and Beijing, meticulous planning and strict medical screening because of extreme altitude and inhospitable terrain.

Pilgrim groups having to halt yatra for days en route owing to inclement weather is a norm rather than an exception. But a tragedy of this scale has not happened before. The worst recorded tragedy associated

with the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra before 2026 has been the 1998 Malpa landslide in the Pithoragarh district of Uttarakhand, which claimed over 220 lives, including 60 pilgrims who were on their way to Kailash.

Mount Kailash is about 6,638 m above sea level, while the nearby Mansarovar Lake is at an altitude of 4,590 m, among one of the world's highest freshwater lakes. Pilgrims traditionally undertake the 52-km Kailash Parikrama, or Kora, which is now reduced to 13 km through some routes.

For those taking the government-operated Lipulekh route, the journey from Delhi to the Kailash covers roughly 1,000 km by road, besides the 52-km parikrama. The alternative Nathu La route through Sikkim is longer by road but involves comparatively less trekking.

In 2025, of the 750 pilgrims who registered for the yatra, 688 participated and completed the journey, as per the MEA.

Veteran mountaineer, wife go off the radar

Ishika Gupta

Mumbai, August 27

FOR DR Milind P Chitley, medicine was a profession but mountaineering was a calling. After completing his MBBS and beginning his career as a doctor, his growing love for the mountains and adventure eventually led him to leave medical practice and devote himself to mountaineering, a passion that would see him build an adventure company and spend more than three decades leading expeditions.

On Thursday, the veteran mountaineer was among the Indians reported missing after flash floods in Nepal. Chitley, his wife Janhavi and several members of a group of around 40 pilgrims travelling through

his Mumbai-based adventure company Hills and Trails for the Kailash-Mansarovar pilgrimage could not be contacted.

The group included two prominent Mumbai doctors, Anand-based gynaecologist Dr Gayatri Deshpande and her husband Dr Anand Deshpande, who headed the haematology department at Hinduja Hospital. Several senior citizens, including 68-year-old Sunil Subhedar and 64-year-old Chetana Gupta, are also among those reported missing.

Chitley, who is in his 60s, completed his MBBS from Grant Medical College in 1983. But his fascination with adventure sports drew him away from medical practice. In 1997, he co-founded Hills and Trails.

His own mountaineering



(Left) Dr Milind P Chitley and his wife Janhavi; Chetana Gupta

record is extensive. He has walked more than 3,000 Himalayan trails and expeditions and climbed to more than 23,000 feet on Mount Kanchenjunga. He was part of the organising committee of the 1997 Everest Expedition and served as the climbing doctor for the first Indian civilian expedition to a mountain above 8,000 metres.

He received the Girimitra

Award in 2005 for his contribution to mountaineering.

The group began its journey on August 23 and was scheduled to return on September 6. Chetana Gupta, 64, had learnt about Hills and Trails through close friends who had earlier participated in a Mount Everest trek organised by the company.

"She had her sights set on the Kailash-Mansarovar tour and had even explored me to come along. However, I preferred to opt out because of age-related concerns and worries about low oxygen levels at high-altitude places," said husband Anand Gupta.

He was last in contact with Chetana in the early hours of the day communication was lost. She was travelling towards an immigration centre, he said.

Actor stranded, TMC leader's wife missing

Sweety Kumar

Kolkata, August 27

AMID REPORTS of at least 32 visitors from West Bengal missing and several others stranded in Nepal following flash floods and landslides, the state government has set up a 24x7 emergency control room to track people missing from the state and coordinate assistance.

A 32-member team from Kolkata comprising 30 pilgrims travelling to Mount Kailash and Mansarovar along two staff travel agencies Cholo.Jai Travels has been unreachable since Wednesday night. The group, which left Kolkata on August 21, had reached the Nepal-China border immigration office around 8.30 am Wednesday to



Actor Kharaj Mukherjee and Sharmistha Bhownmik Roy, wife of TMC leader Subhranshu Roy

secure permits for Tibet when a sudden avalanche struck, instantly severing communication links. Expressing deep concern over the tragedy, Chief Minister Suvenudh Adhikari stated that West Bengal stands in full solidarity with Nepal.

"Deeply pained by the colossal tragedy caused by catastrophic flash floods in Nepal, I

extend my heartfelt condolences to all the bereaved families who have lost their loved ones in this devastating natural calamity. Extremely concerned about reports of over 100 Indian visitors, mostly pilgrims on the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, who are missing," he said on X late Wednesday.

Sharmistha Bhownmik Roy, wife of Trinamool Congress leader Subhranshu Roy and daughter-in-law of late veteran politician Mukul Roy, is among those reported missing after catastrophic flash floods struck near the Nepal-China border.

Sharmistha had left Kolkata on August 21 as part of a 30-member Kailash-Mansarovar pilgrimage group and was reportedly around 10 km from the site of the deluge when com-

munication with her was lost.

"I spoke to her at 11.30 pm on Tuesday; she was fine. She was somewhere called Kyirong. Since then, we have not been able to contact her," Subhranshu told *The Indian Express*.

Another Bengal actor Kharaj Mukherjee and his wife Profra are among those stranded. They had travelled to Nepal along with their film crew on August 20 for a shoot.

Mukherjee said his team, camping in a forest amid torrential rain, plans to head to Gorakhpur by road and then fly to Kolkata on Friday.

Several families across Bengal said dozens remain uncontactable or halted mid-journey. Some stranded tourists have managed to establish partial communication.

Politics

PROTESTERS AGREE TO END THEIR STIR AFTER MEETING SENIOR EDUCATION DEPT OFFICIALS

Bihar govt blinks on single-stage teachers' exam, protest called off

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, August 27

THE BIHAR government has agreed to the demand for a single examination in the fourth Teacher Recruitment Examination (TRE-4) following which the protesters agreed to call off their stir that entered its 10th day on Thursday.

Following a meeting with senior Education Department officials, a delegation of 13 student representatives unanimously agreed to withdraw its ongoing agitation, an official said. The decisions were taken at a meeting chaired by the Secretary, Education Department, Bihar.

The protesters have promised that further action would be initiated on the "one candidate, one result" issue according to rules.

Protesters have been demanding a "One Candidate, One Result" policy to prevent the appointment of fresh faces in the recruitment process. The Congress vet to officially start, camps in both parties are keen to know what transpired at the meeting. While it was described as a courtesy meeting by the leaders, insiders suspect there could be more than what meets the eye.

Protesters have urged that a



Bihar CM Samrat Choudhary interacts with students during Samvad programme at Magadh Mahila College in Patna on Thursday. PTI

filtering system be implemented that removes successful candidates from lower-tier merit lists, ensuring each person fills only one seat and enables others to take up the remaining vacancies.

According to the proceedings of the meeting, the government accepted the demand for conducting the TRE-4 recruitment process through a single examination as against separate prelims and mains. "On the issue of one candidate, one result, it

was decided that further action would be taken as per the applicable rules," an official said.

The meeting also addressed several other demands raised in a written memorandum submitted by the student delegation. "On demands relating to the 70th Bihar Public Service Commission (BPSC) examination, recruitment examinations conducted by the Bihar Staff Selection Commission (BSSC), the sub-inspector recruitment examination and the

Bihar Eligibility Test (BET), it was decided that the complaints and suggestions would be placed before a committee to be constituted under the chairmanship of a Patna High Court judge," the official said.

The committee will examine the issues on the basis of evidence and suggestions submitted by complainants, with further action to be taken according to its recommendations. The proceedings also state that the further process of the 1,799-post sub-inspector recruitment examination will be taken up only after the committee submits its report.

The government further decided that the BSSC would issue a recruitment examination calendar at the earliest and take steps to conduct examinations on schedule.

"On the recruitment of librarians, officials agreed to initiate necessary action soon to begin the process in accordance with the available vacancies," the official said, adding that a high-level committee will also examine the demand for a separate quota where contractual employees are given marks or weightage in Bihar government

recruitment processes, in accordance with government provisions.

On domicile issue, it was decided in the meeting that further action on implementing the maximum possible domicile policy in Bihar's recruitment processes "would be taken in accordance with legal advice obtained from jurists". The demand concerning the maximum age limit for recruitment was also agreed to be placed before the committee for consideration.

There was also consensus on issuing recruitment calendars and ensuring their strict adherence. A proposal to ensure transparency in the question papers, OMR sheets and answer sheets of recruitment examinations conducted on the lines of BPSC examinations will be placed before the committee headed by a Patna High Court judge.

"Regarding allegations of paper leaks in BPSC examinations, including the AEDO and the available vacancies," the official said, adding that a high-level committee will also examine the demand for a separate quota where contractual employees are given marks or weightage in Bihar government

Cong slams BJP over state chief justifying 'purification' ritual at Kharage rally venue

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, August 27

THE CONGRESS on Thursday accused Uttarakhand BJP chief Mahendra Bhatt of "justifying" the "shuddhikaran" (purification) ceremony at the venue of a rally addressed by Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge in Haldwani, and asked whether the ruling party would take action against the leader as he "defended untouchability".

Bhatt reportedly said the place was polluted with slogans unfit for a religious place, as he dismissed the criticism over the ritual.

Congress general secretary (organisation) K C Venugopal said, "It was evident from day 1 that Union Minister Sh J P Nadda's statement of regret in the Rajya Sabha was a mere eye-wash. If Mr. Nadda truly meant that the BJP doesn't subscribe to such acts, how is the BJP's own Uttarakhand Chief defending the so-called 'shuddhikaran' that their workers did after Kharage's event?"

"The BJP's true casteist nature keeps rearing its ugly head, no matter how much cover-up their leaders attempt. If there is even an iota of truth in Mr Nadda's statement in Parliament, they must sack Mr Mahendra Bhatt and take strict criminal action against those who insulted Kharage," he said.

Tagging a video of Bhatt's remarks, Congress's media and publicity department head



It does not matter that Nadda ji described the shuddhikaran in Haldwani, and asked whether the ruling party would take action against the leader as he 'defended untouchability'.

The truth is that discrimination flows through the veins of the RSS-BJP like blood"

K C VENUGOPAL
CONGRESS GENERAL SECRETARY (ORGANISATION)

Pawan Khara said, "It does not matter that Nadda ji described the shuddhikaran in Haldwani after Kharage's rally as 'unfortunate'. The truth is that discrimination flows through the veins of the RSS-BJP like blood." Now, the Uttarakhand BJP president has justified the "shuddhikaran," he said.

Last week, the Congress Working Committee (CWC) had strongly condemned the alleged purification.

Padma Awards not for family members: Shah

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, August 27

"PADMA SHRI, Padma Bhushan, Padma Vibhushan, Bharat Ratna — all these awards are not for the family, not for people known to you. It is for those who, without expecting praise dedicate their lives to the poor people of Bharat Mata," said Union Home and Co-operation Minister Amit Shah in Amreli on Thursday.

Shah also said that it was because of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "wish" that Surat-based diamond businessman Govind Dholakia was made a member of the Rajya Sabha.

Recalling the contribution of the Govind Dholakia founded Shree Ramkrishna Group in curbing religious conversions in the districts of South Gujarat, Shah said Dholakia's foundation (SRK Knowledge Foundation) built "Hannu temples and schools".

Shah was speaking at the inauguration of the Gujarat Gau-rav Sarovar in Amreli, built by the Hare Krishna Group and the Dholakia Foundation promoted by another leading diamondaire Savji Dholakia. Both Govind Dholakia and Savji Dholakia belong to Dudhala village of Amreli and are based in Surat.

Referring to the Padma Shri awarded to Savji Dholakia, Shah said, "Look at his modesty. Savji Dholakia I have not even applied and yet I got a Padma Shri... Savji Dholakia after rejuvenating 208 lakes if you have to apply for these (awards) our government would be considered useless.

Don't try & bulldoze: Kharage asks PM to call all-party meet on delimitation Bill

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 27

CONGRESS PRESIDENT Mallikarjun Kharge on Thursday wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, asking whether the government plans to hold a special session of Parliament to pass the delimitation Bill and reiterating the demand for an all-party meeting on the issue.

Kharge, who is also the Rajya Sabha Leader of Opposition, said he is writing the letter "to reiterate this request for all-party meeting" since the Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs (Kiren Rijiju) has publicised that in a television interview last night that such a special session of Parliament could well be convened. "This perhaps explains the continued delay in the propagation of the Monsoon Session itself," Kharge wrote.

The letter comes days after the Congress questioned why the Lok Sabha had not been prorogued after 10 days of it being adjourned sine die. "What explains the abnormal delay now? Is the Union Home Minister

(Amit Shah) still in search of his bahukalakati (tarnished) 2/3rd majority to get the Constitutional Amendment Bill on Delimitation passed in a Special Session," asked Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh in a post on X.

Kharge in his letter mentioned an earlier letter on July 16 "requesting you (the PM) to convene an all-party meeting for discussing the government's proposals for delimitation." "I had also requested you to give all political parties adequate time to study such proposals in detail before they are introduced in any special session of Parliament that you may be contemplating," he wrote.

Kharge said the Congress was "very clear" on its stand on the issue. "Maintain the existing strength of the Lok Sabha at 543 for another 25 years. Maintain the existing state strength in the Lok Sabha for another 25 years. Introduce one-third reservation for women from the 2029 Lok Sabha elections," wrote Kharge.



Pre-Poll Buzz

A MEETING between veteran Congress leader Pramod Tiwari and Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav has set off speculation among party circles in Lucknow as well as Delhi. Tiwari, who is among the tallest Congress leaders in Uttar Pradesh, met Akhilesh at the latter's residence on Wednesday. Tiwari's MLA daughter Aradhana Mishra was also accompanying him. Sources said the three leaders had a discussion behind closed doors. With seat-sharing negotiations between the BJP and the Congress vet to officially start, camps in both parties are keen to know what transpired at the meeting. While it was described as a courtesy meeting by the leaders, insiders suspect there could be more than what meets the eye.

Fresh Faces

FOLLOWING BJP national president Nitin Nabin's first meeting with the eight new general secretaries of the party on Thursday, insiders are looking forward to several high-profile organisational appointments over the weekend. Sources said the meeting, held at the party headquarters in the Capital, focused on party affairs in poll-bound states. The interaction is likely to pave the way for the appointment of fresh faces on posts such as state election in-charge as part of a party-wide restructuring, said the sources.

3 judicial officers appointed judges of Himachal HC

New Delhi: Three judicial officers were elevated to judges of the Himachal Pradesh High Court on Thursday. A notification regarding their appointments was issued by the Union Ministry of Law and Justice.

Chirag Bhanu Singh, currently District & Sessions Judge, Kangra at Dharmsala, was appointed as a judge, while Bhupesh Sharma and Yogesh Jaswal were appointed as additional judges.

Additional judges are usually appointed for a period of two years before being made judges, or what is popularly called 'permanent judges'. Sharma is currently Registrar General of the HC and Jaswal the District & Sessions Judge, Sirmaur. PTI

BJP's Dalit calculus in Haryana: Split the bloc, broaden Hindu identity

Manraj Grewal Sharma
Chandigarh, August 27

THE SLOGANS that rang out in Karnal earlier this month captured a political shift underway in Haryana.

The last prayers for Biru Balmiki, 25, shot dead in Karnal by bike-borne assailants on August 5, rang with "Jai Bhim, Jai Balmiki, Jai Shree Ram". Hours after the killing, the police shot dead two alleged shooters, one from the upper-caste Ror community. It was a response so swift that Dalit representatives such as advocate Satna Tanwar noted people struggled to digest such stringent action for a Balmiki youth. Hindu Raksha Dal members stood alongside the Balmiki community leaders throughout the protests and at the bhog (a ceremony to mark the end of the mourning period after someone dies).

The Karnal incident is a sharp contrast to the July 2025 case of Ganesh Valmiki in Hissar. The teenager died following a scuffle with the police for playing loud music at a birthday party. The family and the Balmiki community rose in protest and did not demand the body for 11 days until their cremation. The police response to the two incidents has not gone unnoticed.

Dalit assertion itself is relatively recent in a state long



Biru Balmiki was shot dead by bike-borne assailants on August 5.

described as Jat land. The change gained pace after the BJP came to power in 2014 under Manohar Lal Khattar, ending a long line of Jat chief ministers. Ever since, the party has pursued caste engineering by consolidating non-Jats and non-dominant Dalit groups, particularly Balmikis. The approach has continued under CM Nayab Singh Saini.

Scheduled Castes (SCs) form roughly a fifth of Haryana's population, with Jats, the large bloc and Balmikis, or Valmiki, among the largest of the rest. The BJP bets that splitting the Jat bloc from other SC communities yields a decisive edge. Post-poll data from the 2024 Haryana elections backs this: according to Lokniti-CSDS, the Congress gained Jat votes 50%–35%, while the BJP led among other SCs 45%–33%. This explains why Saini chose to be sworn in on Valmiki Jayanti, after visiting a Valmiki temple in Panchkula.

The outreach has moved past symbolism. After the Supreme Court's August 2024 ruling permitting SC sub-classification, Haryana was the first state to act on it, splitting its 20% SC quota in November 2024 into Deprived Scheduled Castes (DSC, 36 communities including Balmikis, Dhanaks, Mazhabi Sikhs, and Khatis) and Other Scheduled Castes (OSC, covering Jats and a caste associated with leather work), each entitled to 10% of total seats. In May 2025, of 7,696 Government Post documents addressed, 605 were reserved for DSC candidates and 604 for OSC.

The project is as much about identity as reservation. The slogans at Biru Balmiki's prayers reflect a vocabulary where caste assertion and Hindu identity aren't seen as contradictory. Young Balmikis increasingly call themselves "sab se kattar Hindustani" (the most fundamentalist Hindus) online.

Political scientist Krishan Kumar, the author of "Reading

Caste in India", notes that this also reflects divisions among Dalits: Kanshi Ram's Bahujan Samaj steered away from Brahmanical traditions towards Buddhism, with some rejecting Valmiki as mythological, while Balmikis assert their distinct identity and stress Valmiki's authorship of the Ramayana.

This is the space the BJP occupies, mobilising caste identities such as Balmiki, Dhanak, and Khatri around specific grievances while inviting them into a larger Hindu collective. It dovetails with RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat's repeated calls for Hindu sub-caste divisions in the name of unity. In a September 2024 Nagpur speech, he said caste discrimination had no place in Hindu society and Hindus must treat each other as one family, ending the "feeling of superiority and inferiority" tied to caste. His focus, notably, is integration into a Hindu framework, not autonomous Dalit politics, an ideological vocabulary in which caste is acknowledged but ultimately subsumed.

In Haryana, these three strands are coming together: Ambedkarite (Jai Bhim) dignity, Balmiki community pride, and a wider Hindu identity represented by Lord Ram. The BJP is trying to bring these strands together, giving Dalit assertion a place within a larger Hindu identity. Whether it becomes a unifying or a polarising factor vis-à-vis other Dalit communities, only time will tell.

• FOR THE LAST TWO-AND-A-HALF YEARS, DILAWAR HAS BEEN IN THE LINE OF CONGRESS FIRE OVER A SLEW OF ROWS AND CONTROVERSIAL REMARKS

Why Rajasthan's Education Minister Madan Dilawar is facing CJP firestorm

Hamza Khan
Jaipur, August 27

FLAGGING A news report about around 30 students of a Kota government school falling ill after having a mid-day meal, the CJP's co-convenor Ashutosh Rana Tuesday said that none of the students would have seen as many as 100 different food items as Rajasthani Education Minister Madan Dilawar.

Kota is also BJP leader Dilawar's home turf, with his Assembly constituency, Ramganj Mandi, falling in the district.

During the last two-and-a-half years of the Bhajan Lal Sharma-led BJP government, Dilawar has been in the line of the Congress's fire over a slew of rows and controversial remarks.

Now, the CJP has turned up the heat on Dilawar. Following the outfit's move to inspect schools in Rajasthan under its countrywide "School Think

Karo" campaign, the BJP government recently imposed restrictions on entry of outsiders and taking photos and videos in government schools, citing privacy of students.

Divisive pitch

A six-time legislator, Dilawar has been embroiled in multiple rows in his career, especially after the shock change as the Education Minister in December 2023 following the BJP's return to power in the state.

In January 2021, Dilawar had slammed the farm agitation against the now-repealed central agricultural laws, saying "so-called farmers" were enjoying dry fruits, chicken biryani and other luxuries at protest sites and that it was a "conspiracy to spread bird flu".

Speaking in the Assembly in September 2021, Dilawar called Mewat a "mini-Pakistan", alleging that the Braj region had become a "den of terrorists and

goons" where cow slaughter and atrocities against Muslims were rampant coupled with the replacement of destroyed temples with mosques.

In another Assembly speech, in March 2023, he called the Congress's state in-charge Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa a "terrorist".

In May 2023, referring to Mallikarjun Kharge, Dilawar said the "Congress president, who is 80 years old, bhagwan kabhi bhi unko uttha sakti hai" (God can summon him anytime) but I would pray to God to not call him for 200 years."

'DNA test' remark

In February 2024, the Education Department directed schools to hold "surya namaskar", amid opposition by Muslim groups who pointed out that Muslims only pray to God.

In the same month, Minister Dilawar suspended three Muslim teachers at a govern-



Madan Dilawar, FILE

ment school in Kota, alleging that there is a "conspiracy of religious conversion, love jihad, and Hindu girls are forcefully being made to offer namaz." However, a spot visit by *The Indian Express* then found school staff, local education officials and several villagers denying any conversion attempts, with inquiries finding no evidence beyond a few disputed student statements.

In June 2024, Dilawar said the heat wave was "the result of Congress's *sukarm* (misdeeds)

In July 2024, the Education Department announced that Vir Savarkar Jayanti will be marked in schools on May 28 and Swarna Mukurt Mastak Diwas will be held on August 5 to celebrate the abrogation of Article 370 from Jammu and Kashmir, apart from Matr Pitri Diwas on February 14 and Surya Namaskar Diwas on February 4. Referring to the Hindu religious event, the Congress state president Govind Singh Dotasra castigated the "politicisation of education".

In September that year, Dilawar announced that the bicycles given to schoolgirls would be saffron — a shift from black during the Congress regime — reasoning that their colour was safe from under the previous BJP government (2013-18).

In October, referring to female teachers, he said that "*kai beheno ko dekhta hun, jo ache kapde nahin pehenti, pooru shayer dikha kar ke school mein jaati hain* (I see several women who do not wear proper clothes and go to school exposing their entire body)," which he added, led to "*bad sanskaar*" among students.

2025: Targeting Akbar
In January 2025, amid a spike in student suicides, Dilawar said some cases were also caused by "*prem-prasang* (love affairs)" promoting "Dekhai" saying, "I request the CM (Bhajan Lal Sharma) to save the state — make Dilawar the CM but please hand over Education Department to someone else."

In March 2025, he said Mughal emperor Akbar was a "rapist and looter." "It pains you and I so much what they used to teach about the great men (of the country). They tried to belittle Maharana Pratap. And Akbar, who used to set up '*meena bazaar*', was a rapist, an invader and a looter, was called as great. This was an insult to the country,

of our great men. This cannot be tolerated." In February 2024 too, he had said that even "taking Akbar's name in India is a sin".

In June 2025, Dilawar stoked another controversy by saying, "*Main aag prakar ka admi hun, gaushalaon ke khilaaf hun* (I am a different kind of person, I am against cow shelters)."

In November 2025, orders were issued, and withdrawn twice by the state government to schools to "celebrate" the Babri Masjid demolition day (December 6) as "Shaurya Diwas", with Primary and Secondary Education Director Sita Ram Jat maintaining that he did not issue any such orders. However, in the second instance, the official statement accompanying the government order had stated that it was decided upon instructions from Minister Dilawar.

'Leak not a big deal'

In May 2026, following the

NEET paper leak, Dilawar said, "The investigating agencies must have found that there are some irregularities and decided to cancel it. *Toh is mein koi badi baat nahin hai* (So it isn't a big deal). Wherever irregularities are found, the government will work to fix it."

In July, he also justified the police crackdown on student protesters during the CJP's march in New Delhi, saying it was "less" considering the "hooliganism" there.

Jhalawar school

The biggest controversy of Dilawar's tenure has been the collapse of a Jhalawar government school in July 2025 in which seven students were killed and eight seriously wounded.

The Jhalawar case prompted a statewide audit of schools which revealed that of the 63,018 government schools in the state, 5,667 were "completely dilapidated".

Modi to begin four-day visit to Uzbekistan and Kyrgyzstan tomorrow

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 27

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi will go on a bilateral visit to Uzbekistan from August 29 to 30 and the Kyrgyz Republic for the 26th Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit, to be held from August 31 to September 1.

Announcing the visit, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said, "At the invitation of the President of Uzbekistan, Shavkat Mirziyoyev, Prime Minister will undertake a state visit to Tashkent on 29-30 August 2026. This will be the Prime Minister's fourth visit to Uzbekistan."

During the visit, the Prime Minister will hold delegation-level talks with President Mirziyoyev to further strengthen the strategic partnership between the two countries.

"The two leaders would review cooperation in trade and investment, defence, digital connectivity, energy, education and people-to-people domains and set the agenda for the road ahead. Modi will also share perspectives on advancing the shared developmental visions of Viksit Bharat 2047 and Uzbekistan-2030," the MEA said.

Prime Minister Modi is also expected to visit the Shastri Memorial in Tashkent and the



PM Narendra Modi. FILE

Mahatma Gandhi Centre at the Tashkent State University of Oriental Studies.

From Tashkent, MEA said, at the invitation of the President of Kyrgyz Republic, Sadyr Zhaparov, the Prime Minister will travel to Bishkek to participate in the 26th SCO Summit on August 31-September 1.

The summit marks the 25th anniversary of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, of which India has been a full member since 2017. "The Prime Minister will address the summit where he will highlight India's priorities of security, connectivity and opportunity at the forum," it said.

Modi will also hold bilateral meetings with SCO leaders on the sidelines of the summit. In addition, he is also expected to attend the opening ceremony of the sixth World Nomad Games, a celebration of the cultural heritage of Central Asia.

Fadnavis gives auto and taxi drivers a year to learn Marathi

Vallabh Ozarkar
Mumbai, August 27

JUST DAYS after Maharashtra began checking auto-rickshaw and taxi drivers for Marathi proficiency, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Thursday put enforcement on hold for a year, giving drivers a fresh window to learn the language and ruled out action against those who failed the test during this period.

The decision follows protests by drivers' organisations which argued that many drivers — from different age groups and with limited formal education — could not be expected to acquire even basic Marathi within weeks.

Representatives of the organisations met Fadnavis and sought a year to comply. "Their demand was that they should be given one year's time. The state government has accepted their demand," Fadnavis said. He said the year would be used not simply as a grace period but to train drivers.

"During this one year, no action will be taken against them. We will help them by arranging different types of classes and preparing literature so that they can learn basic Marathi," the chief minister added.

The rollback comes just a week after the Transport De-



Officers verify if an auto driver in Mumbai has the required working knowledge of Marathi. FILE

partment began enforcing the language requirement from August 20. On the first day alone, 8,217 drivers were tested and 1,268 were issued notices after failing to demonstrate the required working knowledge of Marathi.

Under the amended Maharashtra Motor Vehicles Rules, drivers of auto-rickshaws, taxis and other public service vehicles must demonstrate basic Marathi communication skills with passengers. A driver failing the test was initially given one month to improve. A second failure could result in suspension of the public service vehicle badge for three months.

Transport Minister Pratap Sarnaik had strongly defended the enforcement, arguing that drivers were required to know only basic Marathi needed to communicate with passengers and that the government did not intend to deprive anyone of their livelihood.

On Thursday, however, Sarnaik backed the one-year window announced by Fadnavis, emphasising that it would be the final concession. "We have waited 36 years for the implementation of the 1989 rule, so waiting another year is not an issue. But after one year, there should be no further demands. If you want to do business in

Maharashtra, you will have to speak Marathi," he said.

He also claimed that a 105-day Marathi training campaign conducted by the Shiv Sena had helped around 1.65 lakh auto-rickshaw and taxi drivers learn the language.

Haji Ashraf, who was part of the delegation that met Fadnavis, said drivers would use the one-year window to learn Marathi properly. "Within one year, every auto-rickshaw and taxi driver will learn Marathi and speak it properly. We will not just learn a little Marathi; we will learn to speak good, proper and fluent Marathi," he said.

Delhi High Court quashes defamation case against former MP Pinaki Misra

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, August 27

THE DELHI High Court Tuesday quashed criminal defamation proceedings against former BJP Janata Dal Lok Sabha MP and senior advocate Pinaki Misra, ruling that there was insufficient material to sustain the case.

The order, made public on Wednesday, was passed by Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma, who noted that continuing the criminal proceedings "would not advance the cause of justice and would instead subject (Misra) to the rigours of a criminal trial in the absence of sufficient foundational material".

The case arose from a complaint filed by advocate Siddhartha Singh, who had accused Misra of professional misconduct before the Bar Council of Delhi in August 2018, alleging that Misra took contradictory positions on e-waste rules — first before a parliamentary committee, and later, while representing power distribution companies at the National Green Tribunal. Misra denied the allegations and, in response, called Singh a "crook" and "blackmailer".

Singh subsequently filed two criminal complaints in 2019 before a magistrate court in Patiala House, seeking defa-

mation proceedings against Misra over the remarks. The magistrate court summoned Misra to stand trial in both cases on April 20, 2019.

Justice Sharma noted that there is "no material on record, in the form of statement of any other person or otherwise, to prima facie demonstrate that the alleged imputation had the effect of lowering" Singh's reputation. The court further stated that during the pre-summoning evidence stage, Singh had examined only himself as a witness, and that a bare assertion of reputational harm did not meet the legal threshold required to initiate criminal defamation proceedings.

Singh's case relied on an online report by Dailyhunt in which Misra was quoted calling him a "crook". Misra denied giving any such interview and pointed to a letter he had written in March 2019 to the editor of *Odisha Post*, seeking a published clarification on the same grounds.

The court also observed that the magistrate had not examined the publication or the reporter concerned — a step that could have established, at least prima facie, that Misra had actually made the statement. In its absence, the court found "no independent material" linking the remarks to Misra.

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Memo No.-EC/EW/E800/198/26/146
E-Tender Notice No. -IGIMS/EC/EW/06/2026-2027

IGIMS, Patna invites sealed tender in two bid system (Technical and Price) from reputed agency/authorized dealer for "Supply, installation, testing and commissioning of 15 Passenger/102 kg (Stretcher & Passengers) Lift/elevator for G+2 New Modular OT Complex building, IGIMS, Patna".

The last date and time for submission/uploading of complete tender document at www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in is 21/09/2026. Up to 3:00 PM. The Technical bids will be opened on 23/09/2026 at 3:00 PM at www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in. Details of the tender can be seen and downloaded from institute website : www.igims.org & www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in. The Undersigned reserves the right to accept/reject any or all tenders without assigning any reason. Prospective bidders are advised to regularly visit : www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in & www.igims.org for corrigendum/amendments etc. if any. It will be notified on these portals only and no separate advertisement will be made.

This information is available on www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdibihar/also

PR. No. 010636 (B&C) 2026-27
नमामुक्त र्हे जाए विहार, सुप्रखित रहे घर परिवार।
Director,
I.G.I.M.S. Patna

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Amit Tomar S/o Lt. Shadav Tomar R/O- H. No. A-119, Gail No-8, Meet Nagar, Delhi** has committed /or is suspected to have committed the offence in case FIR No. 440/2013, U.S 279/337 IPC PS Welcome, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Amit Tomar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Amit Tomar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Amit Tomar** accused of FIR No. 440/2013, U.S 279/337 IPC PS Welcome, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.09.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Deepakshika Rana
JMF-03, Room No. 19
Karkardooma Court, Delhi

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
Notification No. : DRMC/AGRA/2026/1-16 Dated : 27.08.2026
Public Notification

On behalf of President of India Senior Divisional Commercial Manager, North Central Railway, Aggra invites applications for engagement of station ticket booking agent (STBA) on commission basis for issuing the unreserved Railway tickets through reservation preserved ticketing system (UTS) at 18 locations of NR (NSG-4, NSG-5 & NSG-6 Category) Railway stations of Aggra Division, for the period of (NSG-6 & NSG-5) 03 years and (NSG-4) Category Station till 20.05.2027 or instruction received from Railway Board.

Notification No. : 2026/01 To 2026/16
Nature of work : Engagement of STBA for Location of 16 Stations (NSG-4, NSG-5 & NSG-6 Category) in Aggra Division.

Earnest Money (EMD) in Rs. : (NSG-4-10,000/NSG-5-5,000/- & NSG-6-1,000/-)
Cost of the Application form in Rs. : Rs. 1,000/- + 180 (16% GST) + Rs. 1,180/- (Last date - Retention of EMD)

Last date & time for purchasing of the application form : Date - 24.09.2026 till 17:00 hrs.
Date & Time for dropping the filled application form in the Box : Date - 25.09.2026 till 12:00 hrs.
Date & time for the opening of applications : Date - 25.09.2026 at 11:30 hrs.

1. Details of station proposed for station Ticket Booking Agent (STBA) :-

Notification No.	Name of Station	Category	Code	Shift
2026/1	JHAREDA	NSG-6	JREA	24 Hrs.
2026/2	BHAINSA	NSG-6	BSA	24 Hrs.
2026/3	BIWAI	NSG-6	BW	24 Hrs.
2026/4	RUNDHI	NSG-6	RDE	24 Hrs.
2026/5	AGRA CITY	NSG-6	AGA	24 Hrs.
2026/6	CHHALESAR	NSG-6	CHLR	24 Hrs.
2026/7	GAZKA	NSG-6	GZKA	24 Hrs.
2026/8	KITHAM	NSG-6	KTHM	24 Hrs.
2026/9	BAAD	NSG-6	BAAD	24 Hrs.
2026/10	FARAH	NSG-6	FAR	24 Hrs.
2026/11	RUNKHTA	NSG-6	RNKA	24 Hrs.
2026/12	ACHNERA	NSG-5	AH	00:00-12:00 Hrs. 12:00-24:00 Hrs.
2026/13	KOSI KALAN	NSG-4	KSV	00:00-12:00 Hrs. 12:00-24:00 Hrs.
2026/14	RAJA KI MANDI	NSG-4	RKM	Platform No.-01 side 00:00-12:00 Hrs. Platform No.-02 side 12:00-24:00 Hrs.
2026/15	IGDAH	NSG-4	IDH	Platform No.-04 side 00:00-12:00 Hrs. Platform No.-05 side 12:00-24:00 Hrs.
2026/16	DHOLPUR	NSG-4	DHO	12:00-24:00 Hrs.

Note : A Person can apply for one Shift/one Platform side only.

Office address from where Application form may be obtained : Applicant can obtain Application form along with terms & conditions from the office of DRMC (C & R) Aggra on cash payment of Rs. 1,000/- (16% GST) + Rs. 1,180/- to the Chief Booking Supervisor, Aggra Cantt in any working day from 31.08.2026 to date 24.09.2026 up to 17:00 hrs. The Application form is not transferable and its cost is Non Refundable.

Duration of work : According to Railway Board's letter no. 20167/GP/2020/STBA Dated-14.08.2024, engagement of station ticket booking agent at NSG-4 & NSG-6 category Railway stations for the period of 03 years and Railway Board's letter no. 20167/GP/2020/STBA dated - 20.05.2026 engagement of station ticket booking agent (STBA) at NSG-04 category railway stations till 20.05.2027 or instruction received from Railway Board.

Last date & time of depositing of application form : Duty filled Sealed Application Form should be dropped in Tender Box Date - 25.09.2026 till 11:00 Hrs. and after that Box will be sealed.

Date and Time of Opening of Application form Tender box : Application forms will be opened on 25.09.2026 at 11:30 hrs in the presence of Applicants. If the day of acceptance of Application form and the day of its opening is holiday the next working day will be the last day for submitting and opening of Application form.

Place of Submitting & Opening of Application form : Office of the Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager, DRMC Office, Aggra Cantt.

Website description and Notice Board where full details can be viewed : The Notification inviting Application, Application form, Terms and conditions are also available on the website of North Central Railway <https://nctr.indianrailways.gov.in> as well as on Indian Government portal www.tenders.gov.in. If the Notification documents are downloaded from the website, then, the applicant will have to attach the cost of Application Form in Rs. 1,000/- + 180 (16% GST) + Rs. 1,180/- with Application form in the form of DD. (in original) issued by any Nationalized/Scheduled Bank in favour of Sr. Divisional Finance Manager N. C. Railway, Aggra, otherwise the Application will be rejected. Application received after the date and time specified above will not be considered. Offer valid up to 90 days from the date of opening of application form.

Railway Administration keeps its right reserved to Cancel any one or all of the applications forms without assigning any reason. 1998/26 (C)

North central railways www.nctr.indianrailways.gov.in CPNROC

'Serious concern': Rajasthan lawyers' groups break silence on allegations against Acting CJ

Hamza Khan
Jaipur, August 27

"STRONGLY CONDEMNING" any alleged misuse of position" and expressing "deep concern" at the recent allegations against the acting Chief Justice (CJ) of Rajasthan High Court Sanjeev Prakash Sharma, three lawyers' associations in the state have demanded that the matter be addressed with "maximum seriousness".

The Rajasthan High Court Bar Association, Jaipur; the Rajasthan High Court Lawyers' Association, Jaipur; and the Rajasthan High Court Advocates' Association, Jaipur, convened an emergency online meeting of their office bearers on Thursday, where they expressed "serious concern over the recent developments that have come to light through the media".

Earlier this month, Justice Sandeep Mehta of the Supreme Court wrote three letters to Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant, seeking the transfer of the acting CJ of Rajasthan and the appointment of a new CJ there.

Justice Mehta accused Justice Sharma of "misuse of powers" and said he had received "several complaints" which "raise doubts" on the Acting CJ's "integrity".

"The Chief Justice of the Supreme Court has requested an institutional investigation. Since this matter is extremely serious and concerns the institutional dignity and independence of the judiciary, the legal community views this entire development with deep concern," the associations said in a joint statement.

"We strongly and unequivocally condemn any alleged misuse of any position or office within the judiciary... any incident or conduct that calls into question the impartiality, dignity, or credibility of the judiciary must be addressed with the utmost seriousness," they said.

Earlier, in December 2025 and in April, the Rajasthan High Court Advocates' Association, Jodhpur, had written to the CJI seeking a permanent Chief Justice for the HC.

In December, it had said that the relationship between the Bench and the Bar was deteriorating and that, "the absence of a permanent Chief Justice often leads to an administrative vacuum or, as witnessed currently, an overreach of acting powers."

In April, it had requested the CJI to shift the acting CJ out of Rajasthan "so that harmony can be maintained between the Bar and the Bench."

Meanwhile, both Jodhpur-based lawyers' associations have requested the acting Government in-charge of VB-G RAM G in states.

In their letter to the acting CJ, they said that it has been the consistent tradition, practice and institutional history that the strength in Jodhpur "has ordinarily remained higher than that at the Jaipur Bench..."

They said that on several occasions, both associations have requested that the permanent sitting at Jodhpur be suitably increased, "keeping in view the enormous volume of litigation, mounting pendency and the continuing institutional responsibilities of the Principal Seat..."

Objecting to the nomination of two judges to Jaipur Bench despite their letters, they said, "It is, therefore, a matter of serious concern for the members of the Bar that, notwithstanding the repeated representations for strengthening the permanent sitting at Jodhpur, Hon'ble Mr. Justice Farzand Ali as well as Hon'ble Mr. Justice Arun Monga have recently been nominated to sit permanently at the Jaipur Bench until further orders."

They said that such an arrangement "has caused considerable concern among the members of the Bar."

GRAMG funds for JIM 2.0: Secys back 'integrated planning'

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 27

THE CENTRE has asked states to tap VB-G RAM G funds for drinking water source sustainability works under the Jal Jeevan Mission 2.0 by converging both schemes.

This was emphasised by two Central Secretaries Ashok K Meena, Secretary, Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation, Ministry of Jal Shakti, and Rohit Kansal, Secretary, Department of Rural Development — in a joint letter sent to Principal Secretaries and Commissioners in-charge of VB-G RAM G in states.

In their letter, the secretaries stressed on integrated planning. "Drinking water source sustainability works under JIM 2.0, greywater management interventions and sanitation and Solid & Liquid Waste Management (SLWM) works under SBM(G) 2.0 should be integrated into the Viksit Gram Panchayat Plans (VGPPs) Under the appropriate thematic categories of the VB-G RAM G Act, ensuring that the implementations are guided by water budgeting, local resource assessment and water security plans," read the joint letter.

The secretaries highlighted that the Viksit Bharat - Guarantee for Rozgar and Aajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) Act, 2025, which came into effect from July 1 and replaced the MGNREGA, provides a comprehensive statutory framework for creating durable assets through community-led planning.

Death of rape victim in abortion bid: Kishtwar hospital worker among 3 held

Arun Sharma
Jammu, August 27

THREE MORE people, including an employee of the state-run district hospital in Kishtwar, have been arrested by Jammu & Kashmir Police in connection with the alleged sexual assault of a tribal teenager by a school headmaster last week, leading to her fatal pregnancy.

A sweeper at the hospital where the teenager was taken for an abortion and two relatives of the headmaster have been arrested, taking the total arrests to five. Kishtwar SSP Nareesh Singh said a Special Investigation Team is conducting a "thorough, scientific and time-bound investigation into all aspects of the case". It comes days after the National Commission for Scheduled Tribes sent a notice to district authorities over the incident.

According to police, the teenager had allegedly been abused by the headmaster for several months, leading to her death on August 20 after a failed abortion attempt last

week. Her death led to protests against the district.

The case emerged after the girl complained of stomach pain and was allegedly taken to a local health centre, which confirmed her pregnancy. She was eventually taken to local medical facilities, where a fatal abortion bid allegedly weakened her. Labour was allegedly induced, leading to a stillbirth.

Police allege that the headmaster and his brother took her to the district hospital in Kishtwar and, with the help of the sweeper, got an ultrasound done and made her take abortion medication.

"The SIT is investigating all aspects of the case," the officer said. Although the girl died on August 20, no formal complaint was registered, with police eventually initiating inquest proceedings. Police later registered a case under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act (POCSO) and a criminal conspiracy, rape of a minor, and death caused by an act intended to cause miscarriage, among others.

The headmaster and his brother — both of whom are said to have accompanied the teenager for the failed abortion attempt — have been arrested. The education department has initiated an inquiry and suspended the headmaster.

The National Commission for Scheduled Tribes (NCST) issued notices to the J&K Chief Secretary, Director General of Police and Kishtwar SSP, asking them to submit a report within five days.

In its notice, the commission said police had failed to invoke the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act even though the teenager was a tribal. The commission has also asked authorities to verify the status of the girl and the headmaster, provide protection to the family, consider compensation for them and preserve evidence.

In Western, SSP Singh said the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act has also been invoked in the case.

• BRIEFLY



The wreckage of the aircraft in Kanpur on Thursday.

UTTAR PRADESH

Trainee pilot, instructor killed as aircraft crashes in Kanpur; probe on

A TRAINEE pilot and an instructor were killed on Thursday when an aircraft crashed near the Ganga in Kanpur, with a three-member DGCA team set to probe whether a technical or human error caused the accident, officials said. The Tecnam P2006T aircraft, operated by Garg Aviation, took off from Kanpur Civil Airport around 11.30 am and crashed about 20 minutes later along the Ganga said Police Commissioner Raghubir Lal. The deceased were identified as instructor Sachin Bhatia, from Gujarat, and trainee pilot Abhishek Pujari, from Karnataka. PTI

Two workers killed in BSNL optical fibre duct

TWO YOUNG workers died by suffocation inside a Bharat Sanchar Nigam Limited (BSNL) optical fibre duct near Lokmanya hospital in Nigdi Pradhikaran on Wednesday night. Police have identified the deceased persons as Manoj Baburao Shinde (26) and Anmol Ashok Shinde (19), both hailing from Aundha taluka, Hingoli district of Maharashtra. Last year, three workers had died in the same BSNL duct, police said. Firemen pulled the two workers out of the duct. They were taken to the YCM hospital, where they were pronounced dead. ENS

At least 4 Nagas killed in militant attack in Manipur

Express News Service
Imphal, August 27

AT LEAST four Nagas civilians were killed and one injured in an alleged ambush by armed militants suspected to be the Kuki militants along the Imphal-Tamenglong (TT) Road in Kangpokpi district on Thursday morning, Manipur Chief Minister N. Biren Singh said. He said the incident occurred at around 9 am between Kamui Ashang and Thanamaba Nagas villages when a group of Nagas leaders belonging to the Liangmai tribe were returning from a meeting. Four were killed and one sustained serious injuries. The identities of the attackers and the exact circumstances of the ambush have not been officially established. Liangmai Nagas Council president Timothiy Wiumalai said the bodies of the four victims were still waiting retrieval from the site at the time of filing this report.

The government condemned the killings in the strongest terms, with the CM describing it as an incident in which "four civilians were killed and one injured". Security officials were directed to identify, arrest and initiate action against those responsible.

The meeting also reviewed the 15-day ultimatum issued by

the CM on August 12, calling on individuals possessing illegal weapons to surrender them. The government decided to take stringent action against anyone, irrespective of community, found in possession of illegal arms. It also resolved to act against cadres of outfits under Suspension of Operations agreements or engaged in peace talks if found carrying weapons outside their designated camps, the statement said.

The United Nagas Council (UNC), the apex Nagas body, condemned the killings and demanded immediate intervention by authorities, and delivery of justice. They called for the constitution of a Special Investigation Team to probe the attack as a serious security failure and expressing concern over safety of Nagas civilians travelling along the TT Road.

Deputy CM Losli Dikho

condemned what he called a "heinous" and "barbaric" attack on innocent Nagas.

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2 Karni Sena factions clash in Ujjain, 2 dead

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, August 27

A DISPUTE over Karni Sena leadership turned deadly in Ujjain when two rival factions clashed at a dhaba in the Kachhura area in the early hours of Thursday, leaving a 42-year-old district vice-president of the organisation and the eatery owner dead and several others injured, police said.

The attackers allegedly arrived with knives and swords and an argument over an official Karni Sena position escalated into violence.

The deceased were identified as Karni Sena district vice-president Rahul Darbar alias Vijay Pratap, 42, a resident of Minamvas, and dhaba owner Jitendra Pawar, 35, of Undasa. Police have registered an FIR for murder and rioting against five named accused — including Shakti Singh and Sonu Banjara — along with 15 to 20 unidentified persons.

Police said a case had been registered based on the injured men's statements against Shakti Singh, Arpit, Ramesh Mahana, Anna and Sonu Banjara, besides 15-20 unidentified persons.

According to police, the incident began with a verbal altercation between Darbar and Shakti Singh over the appointment to a Karni Sena post. The two groups had gathered at Lucky Darbar Dhaba around 2 am, apparently to settle their differences. During the gathering, Singh allegedly slapped Darbar, following which Darbar retaliated. The argument then intensified, with supporters of Darbar allegedly assaulting Singh.

Singh subsequently left the dhaba and allegedly called his associate Sonu Banjara for help. He later returned with Banjara, his brother Arpit, Ramesh Mahana, Anna and more than a dozen other men, according to the police account.

The group allegedly reached the dhaba carrying knives, swords and other sharp-edged weapons and attacked Darbar and others present there.

Darbar sustained critical injuries in the attack and was rushed to a private hospital, where he died during treatment on Thursday morning.

Pawar, who owned the dhaba and was present at the spot, was also stabbed.

His body was subsequently found in bushes near the eatery.

Two other men, including

Shakti Singh and Shrawan Kumar, were injured in the clash and were admitted to Charak Hospital for treatment. Earlier accounts had also identified Pappu Jat among those injured. Police reached the dhaba after being alerted to the violence, inspected the scene and recorded statements from the injured.

Chimanganji police station in-charge Vivek Kanodia told *The Indian Express* the two men had "fought over a Karni Sena posting, and they also had old rivalry over land disputes."

The killings triggered tension in the area, with a large number of Karni Sena members gathering at Charak Hospital after Darbar's death. Police were deployed at the hospital, and additional forces were put on alert to prevent the situation from escalating.

Investigators are examining CCTV footage from the dhaba and surrounding areas and conducting searches for the accused.

Police are also trying to establish the precise sequence of events, including the role played by each member of the group that allegedly arrived at the dhaba after the initial altercation.

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10 newborns dead in a single day at Malda Medical College; probe launched

Sweety Kumari
Kolkata, August 27

THE MALDA Medical College and Hospital (MMCH) has reported 60 infant deaths in August till Monday, with 10 newborns dying on August 24. It has prompted health officials to launch inspections across various hospitals and nursing homes in the district. A report has been sought from MMCH on infant mortality cases.

The MMCH authorities claim that among the 10 newborns who died, eight were born in other hospitals or nursing homes in the district and were brought to the government medical college in a critical condition. "Of the 10 children, only one was born at the MMCH hospital, and additional forces were put on alert to prevent the situation from escalating."

Investigators are examining CCTV footage from the dhaba and surrounding areas and conducting searches for the accused.

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Govt starts retail sale of onions at Rs 35 per kg

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 27

THE CENTRE on Thursday began retail sale of onions at Rs 35 per kg from the government's buffer stock. The onions will be sold through mobile vans and stores of two cooperatives — National Agricultural Cooperative Marketing Federation of India Ltd (NAFED) and National Consumer Cooperative Federation of India Ltd (NCCF). Consumer Affairs Secretary Nidhi Khare flagged off mobile vans of NCCF and NAFED from Krishi Bhavan on Thursday.

Khare said there is sufficient production and availability of onions and in order to stabilise the price volatility of onions, owing to festive demand, the government has taken proactive

measures to cool the prices down, she said.

The retail sale through 9 stores of NCCF, 13 stores of NAFED, 100 stores of Kendriya Bhandar, 40 mobile vans of NCCF and 39 mobile vans of NAFED has started with effect from August 27, as per the Department of Consumer Affairs.

"The intervention... is aimed at improving consumer access, moderating price pressures and ensuring that adequate quantities of onions remain available in the market," the Department said in a statement.

"The Kanda Express initiative has strengthened the government's logistics response by facilitating the movement of buffer onions from producing regions to major consumption centres," it said.

Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport, Mumbai
1st floor, Terminal 1, Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport, Santacruz (E), Mumbai - 400 099.

INVITATION TO PARTICIPATE IN BIDDING PROCESS FOR NON-AERONAUTICAL CONCESSION AT CSMI AIRPORT

Mumbai International Airport Limited ("MIAL") invites reputed parties to participate in the competitive bidding process for non-aeronautical concession at Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport ("CSMI"), Mumbai.

The parties can participate by submitting required documents and the requisite fee as specified in the Tender Notice available on following link: <https://csmi-mumbai.adaniports.com/en/business-tenders>

Upon payment of prescribed fee and submission of requisite documents, the interested parties shall be provided with access to the tender documents containing qualification criteria and other terms. Please check the above link for last date and time for submission of bids.

Note: MIAL reserves the right to cancel the bidding process at any time without prior notice or without assigning any reason whatsoever.

J&K gets new Intelligence chief

Srinagar: In a major police reshuffle, the government has shifted out Jammu and Kashmir's intelligence chief Nitish Kumar, replacing him with M K Sinha.

Sujit Kumar has taken over as the Valley's new Inspector General of Police while Tejinder Singh would be his counterpart in Jammu.

Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha ordered the appointment of M K Sinha as the new intelligence chief of Jammu and Kashmir. A 1996-batch IPS officer, M K Sinha has been appointed as ADG of J&K Police's CID. Nitish Kumar, meanwhile, has been posted as ADGP, ENS

ARMY LAW COLLEGE, PUNE

Old Pune - Mumbai Highway (NH-4)
Sahabai Sawadham, Kharve, Pune - 411005 Phone No: 0214-297338, 297339, Website: www.armylawcollegepune@gmail.com
An Institution of Army Welfare Education Society (AWES)
Affiliated to SPPU and Approved by BCI & Government of Maharashtra (Permanently Non-Aided College)

VACANCY FOR CONTRACTUAL FACULTY

1. Applications for the following posts are invited for BALLB and B.A. curriculum as eligibility prescribed by UGC, SPPU and BCI. The detailed qualifications, specializations and other details are available on Website: www.armylawcollegepune@gmail.com

S. No.	Post	Preferred Specialization	No. of Vacancies	Qualification	Salary
1.1	Assistant Professor (Law)	Criminal Laws, Banking & Insurance Law, International Law, Family Laws, Taxation Laws, Labour & Industrial Law, Competition Law, CPC, CrP, Evidence, Bankruptcy & Insolvency	02	LL.M. NET or SET or PhD	₹57,700/- (Consolidated)

2. Eligibility requirements prescribed by UGC, SPPU and BCI shall apply. Candidates shall send applications along with Biodata and scanned copies of documents related to qualification/work experience by email at: armylawcollegepune@gmail.com by 08 Sep 2026. Format of CV/Biodata as per Annexure I for Faculty available on college website.

3. Service conditions and pay shall be as per the UGC/AWES norms. Candidates should carry all relevant original documents with 2 passport size photos on the date of interview. Date of interview will be communicated to eligible candidates separately. Candidates to specify in their application in subject "Application for Asst Prof/Law-Contractual".

4. Interviews for Contractual posts will be conducted by Local Selection Committee constituted by ALC Management.

5. Contractual appointment will be initially for one year and may be extended to two years. Performance of contractual employees will be reviewed after successful completion of six months' probation period.

6. No TA/DA is admissible for attending the interview.

Principal-in-Charge
Army Law College Pune

OFFICE OF THE ADDL. DEPUTY COMMISSIONER OF POLICE-II, OUTER DISTRICT, DELHI, Office No. 011-27010144

PUBLIC NOTICE

The general public hereby informed that the following unclaimed motor vehicles of different models, seized under Section 66 DP Act by the various police station and presently lying on ground. It will be disposed of soon by E-Auction through MISC LTD. If there is any claim for any of these vehicles, they may personally contact the relevant authority at the relevant documents proving ownership on or before 31.10.2026. No claim will be entertained after 31.10.2026 and the vehicles will be disposed of by e-auction.

List of vehicle seized U/s 66 DP Act.

Sr.	DO NO & DATE	POLICE STATION	REG. NO.	ENGINE NO.	CHASSIS NO.	TYPE OF VEHICLE & MAKE
1	58A, 03.01.26	Munda	DL3SF2A502	—	—	Scouty
2	112A, 08.01.26	Munda	DL4SDH3303	—	—	Honda Dream Yoga
3	151A, 14.01.26	Munda	DL4SAC8329	—	—	Platina
4	172A, 20.01.26	Munda	DL11L9211	1443	1907	MI/Cycle
5	163A, 24.01.26	Munda	DL9SAJ3370	—	1865	Honda Shine
6	74A, 02.02.26	Munda	DL11H2016	—	—	Electric Scooty
7	123A, 20.03.26	Munda	DL9SAH775	—	—	Hero
8	104A, 07.04.26	Munda	DL4SC14552	0	34060	Passion
9	6A, 11.04.26	Munda	DL4SCX721	0	0	TVS Raider
10	123A, 18.04.26	Munda	DL4SAR4339	0	0	MI/Cycle
11	88A, 26.04.26	Munda	HR26DK5799	0	0	Platina
12	62A, 27.04.26	Munda	WU0t No. Plate	0	83977	Splender
13	105A, 07.05.26	Munda	DL12SE8393	—	—	Honda Activa
14	101A, 26.05.26	Munda	WU0t No. Plate	0	98401	Splender
15	138A, 09.05.26	Munda	DL5CH1305	0	0	Hero
16	104A, 09.06.26	Munda	DL5CQR4216	0	0	Scooty
17	112A, 09.06.26	Munda	DL8SBV4802	2693	7208	Scooty
18	29A, 22.06.26	Munda	DL4SCQ7661	56950	0	ACTIVA
19	99A, 23.06.26	Munda	DL8SCA2763	1053	0	Platina
20	77A, 24.06.26	Munda	HR11B2434	0	0	Splender
21	88A, 26.06.26	Mandi Puri	HR11B2434	0	1616	Splender Plus
22	98A, 19.06.26	Mandi Puri	DL11P53546	88708	88523	Honda Shine
23	121A, 30.06.26	Mandi Puri	DL3SE9547	—	48019	Splender Plus
24	101A, 02.07.26	Rani Bagh	DL8SAR1710	99644	38950	Two Wheeler
25	49A, 03.07.26	Rani Bagh	DL8SAA4454	20807	9938	Two Wheeler
26	86A, 10.02.25	Rani Bagh	DL8SAD9971	54090	31509	Two Wheeler
27	67A, 27.04.25	Rani Bagh	DL8SAR2819	52428	75588	Two Wheeler
28	88A, 26.07.26	Nangli	DL11H2016	—	—	E-Rikshaw



The Indian EXPRESS
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RAMNATH GOENKA
IN 1932

BECAUSE THE TRUTH
INVOLVES US ALL

Himalaya needs shared early-warning system

THE TRAGEDY unfolding in Nepal is a reminder of the fragility of the Himalayan ecosystem. The jury is out on what exactly caused Wednesday's flash flood in the Bhoté Koshi River, which claimed at least 200 lives and left several hundred missing. Satellite analysis points to a massive collapse of glacier ice and rock in Tibet, which temporarily obstructed the river before releasing a destructive surge downstream. The landslide was by its intense it was initially thought to be an earthquake. But the time it reached the China-Nepal border, the cascading debris reportedly resembled a tsunami of mud. Authorities have correctly made rescue their immediate priority. Experts are working to pinpoint the cause of the calamity. The next step should be to find ways to keep local people, pilgrims, and tourists out of harm's way in a region of high vulnerability to nature's vagaries.

Floods, landslides, and glacial lake bursts are not alien to the Himalayan region. In 2013, the Kedarnath disaster in Uttarakhand killed thousands after exceptionally heavy rainfall triggered floods and landslides across the Mandakini and Alaknanda valleys. Five years ago, a massive debris flow in Uttarakhand's Chamoli district killed more than 200 people and damaged hydropower projects. The disaster was linked to a rock-and-ice avalanche in the Himalayan valley. Then, in 2023, a collapse of the South Lhonak glacial lake in Sikkim sent a wall of water down the Teesta Valley, killing at least 50 people and damaging dams, bridges and roads. There is, however, a crucial difference between these calamities and Wednesday's tragedy: The latter happened in peak monsoon season when the rivers already have a fair amount of water. A surging river with large rocks can erode banks and slopes and collect more debris along the way.

That's why cooperation between upstream and downstream Himalayan nations shouldn't be limited to rescue and relief efforts. As temperatures rise, systems that monitor rapidly rising river levels, intense rainfall and seismic activity will become increasingly important to alert people in villages and towns located near melting glaciers or thawing permafrost. There are already foundations for such cooperation. The World Meteorological Organisation's South Asia Hydromet Forum brings together the region's meteorological and hydrological agencies, while the South Asia Flash Flood Guidance System provides regional forecasting and guidance. These systems need to be scaled up to enable greater sharing of data, forecasting expertise and early-warning systems among countries in the Himalayan region. Despite geopolitical differences, India and China are often on the same page in climate negotiations. Their shared outlook on protecting development imperatives now needs to be translated into securing people's lives.

Economy is resilient, but risks remain

LEADING ECONOMIC indicators indicate that the country's underlying economic growth momentum has held up in the first quarter and beyond. This view has been reinforced in the State of the Economy report prepared by economists at the RBI as well as in the finance ministry's monthly economic review. However, the outlook remains clouded with risks to growth emanating from continuing geopolitical and trade-related uncertainties, supply-chain pressures, volatile energy prices, and a strengthening El Niño.

Domestic household consumption remains healthy — there are several markers to that effect. As the report shows, e-way bill generation has been firm, and GST revenues are healthy. Passenger vehicle sales are strong, as are tractor and two-wheeler sales. At the same time, the index of industrial production was up 5.8 per cent in the quarter, aided by the manufacturing sector. Electricity demand has also been steady. Firms in both manufacturing and services sectors have also witnessed an improvement in their operating profits as per the report. Bank credit growth has also been growing at a brisk pace across sectors, which bodes well for both production (credit to industry) and consumption (retail loans). The optimism has been strengthened by the recovery in the monsoon, which has helped with kharif sowing. And despite an uncertain external front, non-oil exports have seen an uptick, growing at 12.8 per cent in the first four months of the year, perhaps aided by the currency's depreciation. Public sector capex, too, has held up, with the Centre's expenditure growing by roughly 24 per cent in the quarter.

In the August Monetary Policy Committee meeting, the central bank had projected the economy to grow at 7 per cent in the first quarter. This is in line with assessments by agencies such as Crisil and ICRA. Early next week, the National Statistics Office will release its estimate of GDP growth. Growth may well surprise on the upside. But the external environment will continue to weigh heavily. This calls for a more cautious approach. As the economic review notes, "recent years have been a time for hunkering down and battenning down the hatches. Coming years will be no exception." Policymakers will have to deftly navigate this challenging period.

The mirror mind of Yayoi Kusama

IT BEGAN with a red flower, a print on a tablecloth in her childhood home in Matsumoto, Japan. As 10-year-old Yayoi Kusama watched, the pattern spread across the room, covering the floor, ceiling, all the furniture, even her body. Similar hallucinations would plague the artist for the rest of her life, an affliction she could only cope with by making art out of it.

Over the course of her seven-decade career, Kusama turned the obsessions of her singular mind into work so distinctive that by the time of her death earlier this month she had cemented her place in the popular imagination as an icon of contemporary art. The spectacular nature of Kusama's works could sometimes overshadow the grit and ambition that defined her trajectory. She let nothing stop her, not her mental-health struggles, not the expectations of her traditional, abusive family, whom she fled in her late 20s, and certainly not the sexism of the male-dominated world of Pop Art and Abstract Expressionism in post-war US. The polka-dotted pumpkins, "tentacles", and mirrored "infinity rooms" that defined Kusama's work did more than reflect her visions. The immersive installations she was best known for, are a rebuke to solipsism, their rhythmic repetition of patterns an invitation to inhabit and understand the reality of another mind. That in the Instagram age these works are often treated as just another backdrop for selfies adds, perhaps, to the sense of irony that Kusama gave colourful form to her darkest thoughts.

Two wounded strongmen and the trouble with being invincible

INDIA AND America are facing a new spectre: The prospect of a deeply wounded elected strongman. A wounded strongman is a leader who rode to electoral success on personalised power as an answer to many of society's major challenges. What happens when the aura collapses? Leaders like Narendra Modi and Donald Trump were regarded by their followers as geniuses, with deep insights into the demands of history that ordinary mortals could not fathom. They could do no wrong. But then the tide turns, and the emperor suddenly has no clothes. Even their die-hard followers don't expect much; they cling on because of sunk costs, or fear, or simply their loathing for anyone else. The bottom line is: Both are deeply wounded. But at the same time, they are going to be in power for the next two to three years. Their authority and capacity to govern may have diminished. But their ruthlessness and stakes in power have not. They are still administratively empowered and have the state apparatus at their disposal. This is a novel challenge for us.

The failures that led to their diminished aura are all real. They are also at a dead end on how to address these failures. The headline numbers in both the United States and India don't look bad. But the deep anxiety about the economy in both countries is palpable. In the US, it is concern over the debt, inflation, jobs, tariffs, and all-round uncertainty. In India, the headline growth number can barely disguise deep unemployment and social discontent. The economy is officially successful, but that success is not translating into better individual life prospects. As

quodiam governance begins to collapse, the leaders appear even more disinterested in mundane administration. The corruption is now openly and palpably talked about. For Trump, there is no easy way to rein in the deficit, tame inflation, reduce tariffs, or maintain low interest rates. For Modi, there is no easy way of producing productive jobs. His governing style is not conducive to ordinary private investors, and his ideology is deeply destructive to education. There is no easy exit from the economic stasis.

Both Trump and Modi promised a foreign policy in which the leader would strike a new direction. Their sheer will would allow their countries to overcome the constraints of the past and ride the world in a blaze of national glory. Trump's foreign policy has been catastrophic, making both America and the world less secure. Modi's failures are subtler. But India is now less respected in the neighbourhood and the Global South; it has less room for strategic manoeuvre, and its overall security environment has not improved. The foreign policy does not provide a compensatory theatre for greatness.

There are big differences between the contexts of Trump and Modi: Modi has a powerful party, an ideological organisation, and an ideology that can survive his power. He is also dealing with weaker institutions. But both have run out of ideas; their paranoia makes their talent pool small; and their administrative style cannot deal with complex governance challenges. In truth, even strongmen rule through a clever combination of co-option,



PRATAP BHANU MEHTA

repression, and ideology. But most importantly, they cannot acknowledge political weakness without that weakness becoming a self-fulfilling reality. But their aura of strength is indispensable: give up on that, and everything else collapses.

But what happens when strength cannot be projected through popularity or actual achievement? How do you demonstrate strength when you cannot fix the economy, have failed to navigate the turbulence of world politics, and do not believe in institutions that can actually govern? The only answer is more repression and de-institutionalisation. In Modi's case, it is apparent: There is a surface concession to the Cockroach Janta Party and its demands. But institutionally, the search for more repressive instruments will only intensify. A wounded regime can have an enormous administrative apparatus for coercion at its disposal. Both strongmen have not been averse to using citizenship scrutiny, tax and regulatory enforcement, investigative agencies, welfare eligibility, and playing favourites with business. Both are beginning to toy with the legitimacy of the electoral mechanism, though in different ways. Trump might still try to legitimise the election process. In India, the legitimacy of the electoral process is now potentially hostage to the cruel and possibly selective procedures of the Election Commission.

Modi's ecosystem can employ more vigilante street power, targeting students, minorities, and dissenters. Just imagine, as *The Indian Express* reported, churchgoers

in Mumbai are being put in a position of having to self-declare that they are attending prayer voluntarily, as a response to disruptions, allegedly by groups like Bajrang Dal. The epitome of repression is when citizens are being asked to carry proof of their innocence at every turn. The Cockroach Janta Party, notwithstanding this trend towards repression, is not diminishing. Trump may not be able to resort to vigilante street actors without further losing legitimacy. It is an open question how much of the coercive apparatus of the state — ICE or federalisation of law enforcement — Trump can actually deploy. Modi has one more arrow in his arsenal: Communalism, the sense that he can address every cultural grievance. Trump can also try the politics of cultural grievance, but the axis of that grievance is less clear-cut than Modi's Hindutva. There is one final move wounded autocrats might be tempted to make. Since they have failed ordinary tests of competence, they might need a deeper crisis which might change the canons by which their usefulness is judged: A state of emergency of some kind. Can they manufacture one?

How much destruction the wounded strongmen can unleash will depend on a lot of factors: The persistence of counter-mobilisation, the nature of the opposition, etc. But it would be a mistake to think that political weakness means a loss of coercive power. Weakness just might be a reason to use power more ruthlessly. As PG Woodhouse might say, we might find ourselves in a novel picnic indeed.

The writer is contributing editor,
The Indian Express

Nepal floods pose questions for Delhi, Kathmandu, Beijing



ANIL PRAKASH

A WALL of water swept down the Bhoté Koshi valley on Wednesday morning, leaving at least 270 dead, hundreds injured and missing, and nearly 400 travellers, many of them Indian pilgrims, also missing. Rescue helicopters could not land in the worst-hit villages of Syapru Besi and Timure as floodwaters, surging from the Tibet side, demolished homes, roads, bridges and at least a dozen hydropower projects.

Early assessments point to a rock-ice avalanche that blocked the Lhende/Bhoté Koshi river, creating a temporary dam that burst and released a catastrophic surge downstream. While investigators will need time to confirm the exact trigger, the pattern fits a growing class of cryo-hydrological hazards, floods born not from rain alone but from destabilised ice, snow and meltwater in a warming High Mountain Asia.

The Himalaya is warming faster than most of the planet. This accelerates glacier thinning, exposes unstable ice patches and promotes the formation and expansion of glacial and supraglacial lakes.

A 2026 study of the Nepal Himalaya documented a jump from 1,926 to 2,631 glacial lakes between 2005 and 2024, directly correlated with regional warming and erratic precipitation. Another analysis found that ice loss rates across the Hindu Kush Himalaya have roughly doubled since 2000, elevating downstream risks for nearly 2 billion people who depend on these river systems.

This is not an abstract risk. In July 2025, a supraglacial lake on the Purophu Glacier in Tibet drained abruptly, triggering a high-energy outburst flood that caused severe loss of life and infrastructure damage and disrupted China-Nepal transport links. A satellite time series showed the lake had expanded rapidly through spring 2025 under above-average temperatures before failing.

Just a few months later, scientists from ISRO traced a flash flood impacting the village of Dharali in Uttarakhand to the sudden collapse of an exposed ice patch (the hazard here was not cloudburst but

"cryo-hydrological," that is, related to deglaciation phenomena). The message remains the same: As glaciers recede and become thinner, new modes of failure come into being, bringing the margins between stability and disaster ever closer.

Although scientists note that it is not always possible to attribute a given event to climate change, the connections here are apparent. Climate change is increasing glacier mass loss and lake size; it alters the englacial drainage system and can contribute to hydrofracturing of the ice dam. Concurrently, a warming atmosphere has an increased capacity to hold more moisture, leading to extreme precipitation that can trigger an outburst in this already fragile system. In this context, climate change can be seen as a threat multiplier, increasing the probability of a Bhoté Koshi surge disaster.

While Nepal and its neighbours cannot curb every avalanche or ice collapse, there are measures to reduce exposure and improve early warning: Real-time monitoring of glaciers, supraglacial lakes and river levels, expanding community-based alert systems in high-risk valleys, and better incorporating cryo-hydrological risk in land-use planning and infrastructure design. Regional cooperation to share data on glacier dynamics and conduct drills for transboundary flood response and evacuation protocols for pilgrim routes is critical.

There is no such thing as benign warming. Anywhere, any degree of temperature increase contributes to increased melting, destabilisation of glaciers and extreme precipitation patterns. The recent flood in Bhoté Koshi should serve as a reminder: The climate crisis is here, is happening now, and is deadly. For those working in Kathmandu, New Delhi, and Beijing, the question is no longer when such a disaster will strike again, but how fast they can mobilise to ensure fewer fatalities in future disasters.

The writer is professor of Public Policy at FLAME University. He has been contributing to various IPCC reports and is presently a lead author in IPCC's special report on Climate Change and Cities



QIN JIE

BRICS is now an engine of growth for the world

THE IDEAM of "BRIC" was first mooted by the former chief economist of Goldman Sachs, Jim O'Neill, in 2001. The four-nation group had its first high-level ministerial meeting in 2006, and held its inaugural summit in 2009. South Africa officially joined the group in December 2010, and BRICS emerged.

In Chinese, BRICS is referred to as *Jinzhuan* (golden brick), which emphasises its significance. Today, BRICS has expanded to include 11 member countries and 30 observer countries. BRICS and BRICS+ now account for 45 per cent and 55 per cent of the world's population respectively and are rapidly closing in on 35 per cent to 45 per cent of global GDP (by purchasing power parity; even in nominal terms, BRICS+ economies collectively surpass \$30 trillion in GDP). This collective voice cannot be neglected. BRICS+ is emerging as the world's most dynamic economic alliance, and according to international agencies like the IMF, it is to grow nearly three times faster than the G7 nations by 2028. As ancient civilisations that led the world for centuries, BRICS countries are on their way to revival. More countries like Argentina, Algeria, and Türkiye have expressed interest in formally joining the group. These facts show that BRICS provides a special platform for dialogue and cooperation.

In less than a month, the 2026 BRICS Summit will be held in New Delhi. As an important platform for cooperation, BRICS+ has to expand its agenda to respond to changing global realities while remaining focused on economic growth and people-centric development. Following India's 2026 agenda, the four priorities are resilience, innovation, cooperation and sustainability, which will advance through three pillars of the group: Political and security cooperation, economic and financial partnership, and cultural and people-to-people exchanges.

China has pledged firm support for India's role in the summit. Given their size, whether in population, economy, or markets, cooperation is the best choice for two countries. For instance, our economies are the first and third largest in terms of purchasing power parity (PPP), and their combined population is about 35 per cent of the world's total. We are both at a critical stage of national development. Cooperation brings common prosperity, while confrontation and antagonism can lead to a lose-lose situation. Recently, multiple direct flights between China and India have resumed. Exchanges and cooperation between sister cities, universities, and businesses have been increasing.

Of course, China-India solidarity benefits not only our two countries, but the region and the world. In the near future, China and India will remain strong engines of global economic growth. Our combined GDP will climb from the current 28.4 per cent using PPP terms, and roughly 20 per cent in nominal terms, of the world's total. The Five Principles of Peaceful Coexistence (Panchsheel) advocated by our two countries have become the fundamental principles of international law. Under our leaders' guidance, China and India can build more synergy and achieve mutual success. In the long run, more and more youth from both countries can become bridges between China and India.

The writer is consul general of the People's Republic of China in Mumbai

40 YEARS AGO

August 28, 1986



Procession ban in Gujarat

A CALL for a Gujarat bandh was given by the state unit of the Bharatiya Janata Party as the police came down heavily on people trying to take out a *shobha yatra* on the occasion of Janmashtami in Ahmedabad. More than 1,100 persons were arrested for trying to take out a procession while defying orders.

US 'war of nerves' on Libya

AS LIBYAN revolutionary committees called for attacks on "US interests", US officials acknowledged that the Reagan administration is waging a war of nerves against Colonel Gaddafi. The US objective is to frighten Col Gaddafi into reacting in ways which would

then allow his opponents, both within Libya and outside, to take drastic action against him. But on the other hand, some US officials are already worried that all this sabre-rattling may have got out of hand and will undercut US efforts to increase European economic and political sanctions against Col Gaddafi.

NAM vs South Africa

A COLLECTIVE strategy to meet the challenge of South Africa is expected to be worked out at the non-aligned summit next week. Non-aligned countries are apprehensive that the racist Botha regime will intensify measures to destabilise the frontline states in order to counter international sanctions being mobilised against it. The Prime Min-

ister, Rajiv Gandhi, who is NAM chairman, has already warned that there will be attempts by the South African government and its western allies to divide the movement at the eighth summit being held in Harare.

Anthem singing not popular

THE SPEAKER, Balram Jakhar, will be disappointed to learn that his zeal to make the singing of the national anthem mandatory is not shared across the country. Some schools sing it, some don't, and others according to an Express survey, prefer to sing something else altogether. In Orissa, the national anthem is rarely heard, even at government functions, except on Independence Day and Republic Day.

• NEPAL DISASTER

Echoes of past, warning for future

The devastating flash floods in Nepal are just the latest reminder of the vulnerability of the Himalayan region to similar natural disasters — from Kedarnath in 2013 to Dharali last year



AMITABH SINHA

THE DEVASTATING flooding in Nepal's Bhotekoshi-Trishuli river, which has already claimed more than 350 lives, is yet another reminder of the vulnerability of the Himalayan region to major disasters.

Though they were all triggered by a unique set of circumstances, the Nepal tragedy is not very different from similar disasters seen in India over the last 15 years — Kedarnath in 2013, Chamoli in 2021, Sikkim's South Lhonak lake in 2023, and Uttarakhand's Dharali last year.

Each of them involved a very large and sudden release of waters in the mountainous rivers, either due to a breach in a glacial lake, or because of a large block of glacial ice breaking off and falling into the river. The breach in the lake or the breaking off of the ice-block can be spontaneous — under accumulated stress over time — or be caused by an extremely heavy rainfall, a landslide or an earthquake.

The end result, however, is the same — a series of cascading events in which a mass of water, stones and soil gushes down steeply at great speeds, eroding river banks, uprooting trees, triggering landslides, and destroying buildings, roads and bridges. All the debris being collected by the river on the way further strengthens its force, and its potential to cause damage. The situation continues till the river arrives at a flatter landscape, offering the raging flow an opportunity to spread out and disperse.

What caused the Nepal event

Wednesday's event, which started in the northeastern district of Rasu in Nepal, is currently understood to have been triggered by a rock and ice avalanche, a result of a large block of glacier in the upper reaches of the Bhotekoshi river (the lower side is also called the Trishuli) falling off. What caused this break-off is not very clear as of now. There was no heavy rainfall incident recorded in the area, so that factor is largely ruled out.

The US Geological Survey had reported a 4.4 magnitude earthquake in the region on Wednesday, which was initially believed to be the trigger. On Thursday morning, however, it said the signal that was captured by its sensors was most probably a result of a landslide and not a seismic event.

"This event was initially reported as a magnitude 4.4 earthquake. Additional analysis of nearby seismic stations, long period seismic waves and satellite imagery led to the determination that the seismic event was instead a glacial collapse and debris flow, and that no earthquake had occurred," said the USGS update. That could mean that a large chunk of snow broke off from the glacier on its own, possibly under its own internal stress, and caused a landslide which triggered the chain of events.

But Syed Iqbal Hasnain, a veteran glaciologist and former vice-chancellor of University of Calicut, pointed out that ice-blocks were not visible in any of the videos of the disaster. "The ice that breaks off from a glacier is almost like a solid rock. It does not melt immediately. But no ice blocks were visible in the videos of the incident. It is possible therefore that the incident was caused not by ice blocks breaking off from a glacier, but from

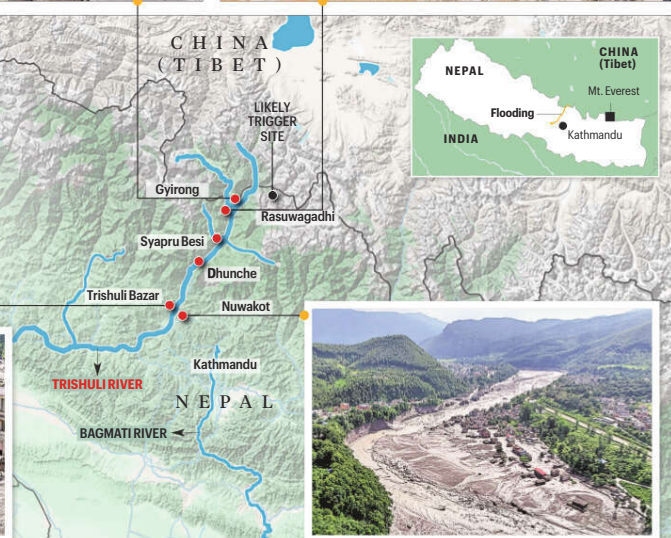


THE TRAIL OF DESTRUCTION

THE DISASTER in Nepal was most likely triggered by a rock and ice avalanche, a result of a large block of glacier in the upper reaches of the Bhotekoshi river (the lower side is also called the Trishuli) falling off.

THE CAUSE of the break-off is unclear as of now. While an earthquake was speculated earlier, it has emerged that it was the break-off that caused the seismic event.

THE EFFECT, however, was devastating — from the Gyirong land border between China and Nepal to Nuwakot district and beyond.



PHOTOS: AGENCIES; NOTE: MAP SHOWS APPROXIMATE LOCATIONS OF SITES SEEN IN PHOTOGRAPHS

agglacial lake outburst," he said.

Safi Ahsan Rizvi, an IPS officer who worked with the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) before his retirement, suggested that it could have been a result of a breach in a "supra-glacial lake". Lakes are generally formed at the end of a glacier, but sometimes, mainly as a consequence of climate change, lakes emerge within the glaciers themselves, and are known as supra-glacial lakes. A breach in this kind of lake could explain the lack of ice blocks in the visuals.

Previous events

The actual sequence of events can be ascertained only after scientists are able to complete a comprehensive study. But it unfolded in a manner very similar to the other incidents in India in the previous years.

"As of now, the Nepal event looks very similar to the Chamoli disaster of 2021 in the way it got triggered. But in terms of its impact downstream, and the destruction it has caused, it is more like the Kedarnath tragedy of 2013," said Farooq Azam, an associate professor at IIT Indore. Azam currently heads the Cryosphere group at the

Kathmandu-based The International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development (ICIMOD), a major research organisation working on the Himalayas.

Chamoli was caused by an ice and rock avalanche, a result of a large ice-block of a glacier, estimated to be 27 million cubic metres in all, breaking away and falling downhill. Kedarnath, on the other hand, was a GLOF (Glacial Lake Outburst Flood) event, the result of a breach in a glacial lake.

The Kedarnath incident was much more devastating. The damage potential of an event like this depends on factors like geography, the incline of the river, vegetation, population and urbanisation. The amount of rock and ice that fell off in the Nepal incident is yet to be estimated, but the fact that its fall was captured as a fairly large seismic wave (USGS had revised its 4.4 measurement to 5.2) suggests the involvement of a very big chunk of mass. It is not surprising, therefore, that the impact of the Nepal event appears to be significantly bigger than the Chamoli incident, in which about 200 people were reported to have been killed, or gone missing.

The reason these events in the Hima-

layan region become so risky is that while they start off as individual events — extreme rainfall or landslide or lake overflow — they soon transform into a multi-hazard disaster, involving multiple landslides, flooding and building collapse episodes.

"The Himalayan region is very fragile. Such events lead to a chain reaction. A surging river with large rocks and ice blocks would erode the banks and slopes, and more soil, mud and rocks would become part of the raging river. It becomes a cascading disaster because the waters do not have any other way to spread out. That is why any such event in the Himalayan ecosystem becomes extremely dangerous," said Azam, currently in China attending a disaster risk reduction conference.

A study published in *Science* magazine last year about a 2023 event in Sikkim captured the cascading impact of such flash flood events in the mountains. This event had been triggered by the collapse of a large chunk of glacier into the South Lhonak lake, situated over 5,000 metres above sea level, in northern Sikkim. This led to a GLOF event that took the shape of flash floods.

The study found that a landslide had re-

• HIMALAYAN DISASTERS

KEDARNATH, 2013: In June, Uttarakhand received an unusually high amount of rainfall, leading to the melting of the Chorabari glacier and the Mandakini river overflowing. The floods affected large parts of Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh and Western Nepal, causing massive flash floods and landslides. Nearly 6,000 people were presumed dead.

CHAMOLI, 2021: A large glacier broke away and set off a flood, leading to surging waters in the Rishiganga river in Uttarakhand. Over 200 people were reported dead.

SIKKIM, 2023: A glacial lake (large bodies of water that sit in front of, on top of, or beneath a melting glacier) situated in northwest Sikkim at 5,000 metres burst due to incessant rains. It led to the release of water in downstream areas and the deaths of at least 55 people.

DHARALI, 2025: The terrain of the region in Uttarakhand (6,900 metres above sea level), combined with continuous rain for days, triggered mudslides, debris slides and flash floods. At least 69 people were reported dead.

sulted in the collapse of nearly 14.7 million cubic metres of rocks, soil and snow deposited around a glacier into the South Lhonak lake, which triggered a series of cascading events. The volume of the flowing sediment downstream had grown to about 270 million cubic metres.

"The collapse of approximately 14.7 million cubic metres of frozen lateral moraine into the South Lhonak Lake... on 3 October 2023 generated a 20-m-high displacement wave. The wave overtopped and breached the frontal frozen moraine, causing the sudden drainage of approximately 30 million cubic metres of water... The GLOF eroded approximately 270 million cubic metres of sediment and triggered 45 secondary landslides. Most of the erosion occurred within about 67.5 km of the lake," the study had found.

Vulnerable Himalayas

Azam said the entire Himalayan region was "out of balance entirely" because of population pressure and climate change.

"The whole ecosystem is vulnerable. Because of climate change and increasing instances of extreme weather events, newer areas are getting exposed. Earthquakes or heavy rainfall events are quite common, and any of them can trigger these kinds of disasters," he said.

The Himalayan region is also one of the most dangerous places for earthquakes, recording some of the biggest tremors in the past. Nepal itself was the victim of a 7.2 magnitude earthquake in 2015.

The only way to minimise the damage from such events is to install early warning systems, prepare evacuation plans, and strictly monitor and regulate construction and other activities in the ecologically fragile region so that further instability is avoided.

After the Sikkim disaster, the NDMA had initiated a National GLOF Risk Mitigation Programme (NGRMP) seeking to install early warning systems at glacial lakes at high risk of facing a breach. The Rs 150-crore programme is targeting connecting 195 glacial lakes in Sikkim, Uttarakhand, Arunachal Pradesh, Himachal Pradesh and the Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh with early warning systems.

• DIPLOMACY

India-China boundary talks: Some progress, but a long road ahead



EXPERT EXPLAINS

SUJUAN CHINYO

DIRECTOR GENERAL, MANOHAR PARIKAR INSTITUTE FOR DEFENCE STUDIES AND ANALYSES

THE EIGHT-POINT consensus reached at the 25th round of talks between Special Representatives (SRs) Ajit Doval and his Chinese counterpart Wang Yi in Beijing is a welcome step ahead of the expected visit of President Xi Jinping to India for the BRICS Summit.

Some of the outcomes concern the maintenance of peace and tranquillity in the border areas, and advancing negotiations on a framework for the settlement of the boundary question in accordance with previous agreements. There is a specific reference to advancing discussions through an Expert Group and Working Group respectively, to explore an "early harvest" of boundary delimitation in appropriate sectors, and effective border management.

Last year, there was agreement in principle on working towards setting up additional General-Level Mechanisms/Senior

Highest Military Commander (SHMC) meetings in the Eastern and Middle sectors akin to the existing mechanism in the Western sector at Chushul/Moldo.

This time, the two sides agreed to implement that understanding along with establishing two hotlines in the Eastern and Middle Sectors. Going forward, the implementation will have to be handled carefully.

The past as prologue

In 1992, the Joint Working Group (JWG) on the Boundary Question decided on confidence building measures (CBMs) such as border personnel meetings (BPMs), complementing forward movement on border trade. A sub-group of the JWG was created following the border peace and tranquillity agreement (BPTA) of 1993 — the India-China Expert Group of Diplomatic and Military Officials (EG), a precursor to the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on India-China Border Affairs (WMCC), an institutional mechanism for border management set up in 2002. After the success achieved in 1995 on disengagement at Sumdorong Chu (along the India-China Line of Actual Control in Arunachal Pradesh), Lipulekh (Middle Sector) and Dicho (Eastern Sector) were subsequently identified as additional military meeting points. The plan for BPMs at Lipulekh was abandoned due to lack of infra-



structure and adverse weather conditions. A trial meeting at Dicho in the Kibithu sector in Arunachal Pradesh was finalised. Dicho is a sensitive area in Anjaw district, and the site of a famous battle in 1962 at Hill 100, in which the Kumaon Regiment did the Indian Army proud. The site chosen for the BPM on Madan Ridge proved contentious. No further meetings could take place. It was not until 2014 that the proposal for additional points for BPMs was revived. Eventually, it was decided to have regular BPMs at Wacha/Kibithu in the same sector opposite Damal on the Chinese side, in addition to existing venues across Bum La in

Arunachal Pradesh and Nathu La in Sikkim. Together with BPMs across the Lung-nak Lungpa stream at Daulat Beg Oldie (DBO) and Tianwendun (TWD) in the Chip Chap valley, and at the Chushul-Moldo meeting point in the Spanggar Gap, these have contributed to the two militaries maintaining direct contact. Additional meetings would further the cause of peace. Existing hotlines at DBO and Chushul, some informal communication at Demchok in the Western Sector, and similar hotlines at Nathu La (Sikkim) and Bum La and Kibithu in the Eastern Sector have pro-

• THE LAC's sectors

THE LINE OF ACTUAL CONTROL separates Indian-controlled territory from Chinese-controlled territory.

IT IS DIVIDED INTO three sectors: the Eastern Sector (Arunachal Pradesh and Sikkim), Middle Sector (Uttarakhand and Himachal Pradesh) and Western Sector (Ladakh).

NSA Ajit Doval and Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi at the 25th Meeting of Special Representatives in Beijing on Tuesday.

vided the two militaries with channels for direct contact. The two additional hotline channels agreed to for the Eastern and Middle sectors could strengthen this capacity and help defuse local tensions.

The road ahead

The SRs are working to realise the consensus reached between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Xi at Kazan in October 2024 and at Tianjin in August 2025 on improving ties.

Recent developments such as the resumption of the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, direct flights, and border trade are mean-

ingful steps in the right direction.

However, the road ahead, especially on the task of "early and substantial harvest of boundary delimitation and border management" may be long and arduous, requiring patient negotiations. It would be premature to suggest that substantive boundary delimitation has already begun in earnest. After all, the Expert Group and Working Group under the WMCC are now explicitly tasked with finalising their respective Terms of Reference. That means the framework is being created and the process is being activated incrementally.

There is also the issue of making piecemeal progress as against a more holistic settlement of differences along the Line of Actual Control. Neither the Sikkim sub-sector nor the Middle Sector are free from the burden of differences. The negotiators must be empowered to engage in meaningful discussions. They must have sufficient experience in handling a matter that has proved vexatious for previous generations. If taken in the right direction, the guidance provided by the political leadership can lead to lasting peace and cooperation between two large and populous neighbours in an era of global flux.

(The author was head of the Indian side in the Expert Group of Diplomatic and Military Officials negotiating with China between 1996 and 2000)

THE CEA RECENTLY CALLED FOR A LOWER ETHANOL-PETROL BLEND OPTION

'No reversal to E10, choice for old vehicles being explored'

Sukal Sharma
New Delhi, August 27

AMID THE public debate around E20 petrol — 80% petrol and 20% ethanol — being the only standard petrol variant in the country, the option of additionally offering petrol with 10% ethanol blending, or E10, is being explored specifically for older vehicles, Sanjay Khanna, chairman of the country's second-largest fuel retailer Bharat Petroleum (BPCL), said Thursday in an interaction with reporters.

But no concrete decision has been taken yet as discussions are on regarding supply chain and logistical challenges that selling two variants of base fuel are likely to pose.

Khanna also said that there is no proposal to fully replace the E20 blend with E10.

"One of the options being explored is we can have E10 fuel for the older vehicles, which is what is being pursued right now. What are the challenges related to the supply, can we handle another grade of MS (motor spirit, or petrol) simultaneously? Yes, those challenges are there and they are being debated, they are being worked out right now. That is the reason why we don't have

• THE E20 DEBATE

INDIA ACHIEVED 20% ethanol blending in petrol last year, five years ahead of the deadline

THERE HAS been opposition over the E20 fuel from various quarters, with claims ranging from notable reduction in mileage and engine component wear in older vehicles

ON ITS part, the government has been trying to ally fears, saying that the drop in mileage in older vehicles would be 3-5% at most,



and would be outweighed by E20's benefits as it is a superior fuel

any ready answer. But definitely, it was one of the options that was being pursued. In what form it would come, to what extent it would come, the details are being worked out at this juncture at different levels," Khanna said in response to a question from *The Indian Express*.

On August 19, *The Indian Express* had reported quoting sources that early exploratory discussions within the government and the industry were underway on whether E10 petrol can also be retailed for older vehicles alongside the E20 fuel. Any decision on the matter

is likely to be taken at the government level, and will be binding on all fuel retailers.

India achieved 20% ethanol blending in petrol last year, five years ahead of the original deadline. There has been opposition over the E20 fuel from various quarters, with claims ranging from notable reduction in mileage and engine component wear in older vehicles whose engines were not designed for higher ethanol blends.

On its part, the government has been attempting to ally fears, saying that the drop in mileage in older vehicles would

be 3-5% at most, and would be outweighed by E20's benefits as it is a superior fuel.

It has also consistently reiterated claims that E20 fuel could damage engine components. Questions have also been raised on why motorists aren't being offered the choice of pure petrol, E10, and E20 fuels. According to sources in the know, the discussions — described as preliminary — are being held on various technical as well as non-technical aspects of the country's complex fuel retail supply chain.

They said that the backlash from certain quarters against E20 and the lack of choice for consumers, specifically those with older vehicles — particularly two-wheelers — that were certified for E10 petrol, led to the initiation of these discussions.

In July, the government had said that offering multiple grades of base fuel across the country would create an "enormous logistical challenge", apart from raising costs and reducing operational efficiencies in India's complex fuel retail network. It also said that the current base fuel E20 is cleaner and superior than pure petrol and lower ethanol-petrol blends.

www.indianexpress.com

Subhash Chandra case: HDFC Bank eyes NCLAT over Rs 6.5 crore order

George Mathew
Mumbai, August 27

HDFC Bank is "exploring an appeal" against a National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) order approving a repayment plan for Essel Group founder Subhash Chandra that entails a substantive haircut on creditors' admitted claims.

The NCLT has approved Chandra's proposal to pay Rs 6.25 crore against total guarantees signed for Rs 22,000 crore. HDFC Bank said it admitted claim accounted for 3.2% of the total claims and that it was inherited from erstwhile HDFC Ltd prior to the merger of the two entities. The NCLT verdict said the case from going into bankruptcy. The proceedings concern personal guarantees given by Chandra for borrowings of Essel Group-linked companies. When a promoter gives a personal guarantee for corporate loans, the lender can, subject to the applicable legal process, pursue the guarantor when the underlying borrower defaults. Chandra's insolvency proceedings were initiated in 2024 for

lowing a petition by Indiabulls Housing Finance.

The case therefore goes beyond Zee Entertainment Enterprises. It concerns Chandra's personal liability arising from guarantees linked to corporate debt. There is a separate corporate insolvency proceedings involving companies associated with the Essel Group, or with regulatory proceedings involving Zee Entertainment and its executives. "Total claim against Subhash Chandra as a personal guarantor, in the personal insolvency proceedings is only Rs 3,992 crore by the objectors of the plan and not Rs 22,000 crore," Subhash Chandra's office said in a press statement issued on Thursday. "Out of which, also a claim of Rs 620 crore settled and further Rs 1,063 crore offered to be paid by the borrower entities. The borrowing entities for whom Chandra has provided personal guarantees have till date repaid Rs 43,000 crore. The borrowing entities have assured to settle any other amount which might have left," it said.

"He (Subhash Chandra) declared his total assets stood at Rs

39.08 crore which he declared in the Parliament of India in 2016, which is a public record. How could a bank take/accept his net worth of Rs 45,888 crore in 2017?" the statement said.

"His personal net worth came down to Rs 31.79 crore in 2024 from Rs 39.08 crore in 2016," it said. The August 25 order was not the result of a straightforward unanimous decision. A two-member NCLT bench had earlier delivered a split verdict on the repayment plan. With the members divided, Nitesh Sharma, judicial member of the NCLT, acted as the third member to resolve the disagreement.

The third member ultimately sided with approval of the repayment plan. Creditors had mounted strong objections, particularly over the extraordinarily low amount they were being offered. But the tribunal concluded that the objections did not provide sufficient legal grounds to reject the plan. The tribunal reviewed the available financial information and concluded that the approved repayment plan could yield a better outcome than forcing the matter into

bankruptcy. Put simply, the reasoning was pragmatic: recovering Rs 6.5 crore could be preferable to the potentially lower returns from liquidation or bankruptcy.

The creditors' objections centred on the extraordinarily low recovery. Creditors also questioned whether the debtor's assets and financial affairs had been examined deeply enough, including whether a forensic investigation should have been conducted. The tribunal, however, did not accept the argument that a forensic investigation was an essential precondition for approving the repayment plan.

The NCLT also emphasised the importance of the commercial decision of creditors. Where creditors have voted on a plan in accordance with the IBC, the tribunal does not ordinarily substitute its own commercial assessment for that decision.

The repayment plan had secured the requisite support from creditors, reportedly receiving approximately 80.81% of the voting share. **FULL REPORT ON** www.indianexpress.com

FM: Closer India-Canada economic ties important amid global uncertainty

Press Trust of India
Washington, August 27

CLOSER ECONOMIC cooperation between India and Canada has assumed greater significance amid a rapidly changing global landscape marked by geopolitical uncertainty, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said, calling for stronger partnerships to build resilient, sustainable and inclusive economies.

"The world is going through a profound transformation. There's just a lot of uncertainty everywhere. And the geopolitical and economic realities are constantly evolving," Sitharaman said while addressing a joint briefing after the inaugural Economic and Financial Dialogue between India and Canada at Toronto.

Against this backdrop, she said, closer economic cooperation between the two countries would be important to build resilient, sustainable and inclusive



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman with Francois-Philippe Champagne, Minister of Finance & National Revenue of Canada, in Toronto. PHOTO CREDIT: MINISTRY OF FINANCE

ive economies in both Canada and India. Her remarks came amid evolving global economic and geopolitical conditions that have heightened the need for greater international cooperation to strengthen economic resilience and promote inclusive growth, Sitharaman further said the economic and financial

dialogue between India and Canada reflects the shared ambition to move beyond traditional trade in goods and services and build a deeper economic partnership encompassing investment, finance, capital markets and regulatory cooperation.

Prime Minister Narendra

Modi and his Canadian counterpart have set an ambitious goal for strengthening bilateral ties, giving fresh momentum and strategic direction to the relationship, she said. The discussions with her counterpart Francois-Philippe Champagne, covered three broad areas: macroeconomic developments and domestic policy priorities in both countries; practical avenues for financial-sector cooperation; and broader international and multilateral cooperation on issues of shared interest. Highlighting that India has demonstrated "remarkable macroeconomic resilience," she said the complementarities between the two economies, along with considerable scope for expanding investment and economic cooperation.

On financial-sector cooperation, she said the two sides explored areas including cross-border payments, financial stability, fintech and capital markets.

S&P affirms 'BBB' rating on India; cites infra push, policy stability

Reuters
Bengaluru, August 27

GLOBAL RATINGS agency S&P Thursday affirmed India's sovereign ratings at "BBB/A+" with a "stable" outlook, citing continued policy stability and high infrastructure investment that supports the country's long-term growth prospects.

The affirmation comes despite risks from higher energy prices, which could strain India's external balances and inflation outlook given its heavy reliance on imported crude oil. S&P estimates India's real GDP growth to ease slightly to 6.6% this year, a pace it said remains strong compared with most emerging-market peers amid a broad global slowdown.

Gadkari: India's EV market to hit Rs 20L cr by 2030

New Delhi: India's electric vehicle (EV) market is expected to grow to Rs 20 lakh crore by 2030, with the potential to create five crore jobs, Union Minister Nitin Gadkari said on Wednesday.

Addressing a summit organised by the CII-ITC Centre of Excellence for Sustainable Development, Gadkari said that currently 57 lakh electric vehicles are registered in India, with 7% market penetration. "India's electric vehicle (EV) market will be worth Rs 20 lakh crore by 2030. It will also create five crore jobs by 2030," he said.

The road transport and highways minister highlighted that India's two largest two-wheeler vehicle manufacturers, Bajaj Auto and Hero MotoCorp, export more than 50% of vehicles they produce. PTI

SIA to 'carefully consider' Air India's cash infusion pleas

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, August 27

THE BOARD of Singapore Airlines (SIA), which owns 25.1% stake in Air India, will carefully consider any request from the latter for additional capital infusion after considering the SIA group's other capital requirements as well as Air India's overall business strategy, the city state's flag carrier said Thursday.

The comments come amid the loss-making Air India seeking capital infusion from its shareholders Tata Sons and SIA, which has also led to concerns being raised by a member of parliament (MP) in Singapore.

Air India, which is implementing an ambitious and cash-guzzling transformation programme, is also struggling due to external headwinds like the Pakistani airspace closure, West Asia conflict-related disruptions, and sky high fuel prices. The airline recently sought about \$1.5 billion from its shareholders, it is learnt.

"As a significant minority shareholder, Singapore Airlines works with Tata Sons to support Air India's transformation programme. SIA's Board will carefully consider any requests for additional capital from Air India, taking into consideration the Group's other capital requirements and Air

India's business strategy," an SIA spokesperson said.

"The SIA Group's capital allocation follows a disciplined evaluation process that considers its operating cash flow, investment requirements in new aircraft and products, as well as multi-bu investments such as Air India, to support sustainable long-term growth and returns," he added. In a social media post on Wednesday, Kenneth Tiong, an opposition MP in Singapore's parliament, raised concerns over Singapore Airlines investing further in Air India, which he said could impact it could have on Temasek, the Singapore government-owned global investment company that in turn owns Singapore Airlines. "Singapore Airlines owns about a quarter of it (Air India), and Temasek owns most of Singapore Airlines, so the question is not only a question for private shareholders. Whichever of the two writes the cheque, it will have a significant impact on Temasek... No one, least of all Singaporeans, owes Air India a living. I will not, support, nor expect, any future use of Temasek's funds to prop up Air India via Singapore Airlines. If Singapore Airlines wants to continue its bet on Air India, it should do so on its own two feet, and not on Temasek's," Tiong said.

FULL REPORT ON www.indianexpress.com

BEFORE THE NATIONAL COMPANY LAW TRIBUNAL
AHMEDABAD BENCH, AHMEDABAD
C.A. (CAA)/ 33 (AHM) 2026

In the matter of Sections 230 to 232 read with other applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 and
In the matter of Scheme of Amalgamation of
ACC Limited ("Amalgamating Company")
with
Ambuja Cements Limited ("Amalgamated Company")

— APPLICANT NO. 1 /
AMALGAMATING COMPANY

NOTICE AND ADVERTISEMENT OF NOTICE OF THE MEETING OF THE EQUITY SHAREHOLDERS (WHICH CONSIST OF PUBLIC SHAREHOLDERS)

Notice is hereby given that by an order dated July 29, 2026 ("Order"), the Hon'ble National Company Law Tribunal, Ahmedabad Bench ("Hon'ble Tribunal") has directed convening of the meeting of the equity shareholders of ACC Limited (hereinafter referred to as the "Amalgamating Company"), for the purpose of considering, and if thought fit, approving the arrangement embodied in the Scheme of Amalgamation of the Amalgamating Company with Ambuja Cements Limited (hereinafter referred to as the "Scheme") pursuant to the provisions of Sections 230-232 of the Companies Act, 2013 ("Act") and other applicable provisions thereof and applicable rules thereunder.

In pursuance of the Order passed by the Hon'ble Tribunal and as directed therein, further Notice is hereby given that a meeting of the equity shareholders of the Amalgamating Company will be held on Tuesday, September 29, 2026 at 10:30 a.m. (IST) through Video Conferencing ("VC")/Other Audio Visual Means ("OAVM") (hereinafter referred to as the "Meeting") in compliance with the applicable laws including circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA Circular") from time to time and the Circular No. SEBI/HO/CFD/PD-2/P/CIR/2023/93 dated October 5, 2024, issued by the Securities and Exchange Board of India ("Circular issued by SEBI") and the said equity shareholders are requested to attend the Meeting.

The Amalgamating Company has completed the electronic dispatch of the Notice of the Meeting dated August 20, 2026, the explanatory statement as required under Sections 230(1), 232 (1) and (2) and 102 of the Act read with Rule 5 of Companies (Compromises, Arrangements and Amalgamations) Rules, 2016; and the annexures to the explanatory statement which includes the Scheme (collectively referred to as "Particulars") on August 27, 2026, through e-mail. The Particulars were sent through electronic mode to those equity shareholders whose e-mail addresses are registered with Kfint Technologies Limited, the Amalgamating Company's Registrar and Transfer Agent, (hereinafter referred to as "Kfint")/depositories/Amalgamating Company and whose names appear in the register of members/list of beneficial owners as on Friday, August 14, 2026. The Particulars are placed on the website of the Amalgamating Company and can be accessed at www.acclimited.com and are also available at the websites of National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.nseindia.com, Bombay Stock Exchange Limited at www.bseindia.com, Central Depository Services (India) Limited ("CDSL") at www.evotingindia.com, and Kfint at https://kfint.kfintech.com/bmails/254982_ACC_Merger_R1.pdf.

If so desired, copy of the particulars can be obtained free of charge, between 10:30 a.m. to 12:30 p.m. on all working days up to one day prior to the date of the Meeting at the registered office of the Amalgamating Company, or from the office of its advocates, M/s. Singhi & Co., Singhi House, 1, Magnet Corporate Park, Off. H. S. Highway, Ahmedabad - 380 059, Gujarat, India or by sending a request along with the details of shareholding to the Amalgamating Company by email at acc-investorsupport@adani.com.

Since, the Meeting is being held pursuant to the Order passed by the Hon'ble Tribunal and in compliance of MCA Circulars and Circular issued by SEBI through VCOAVM, physical attendance of the equity shareholders has been dispensed with. Accordingly, the facility for appointment of proxy by the equity shareholders of the Amalgamating Company is not available at this Meeting.

The Hon'ble Tribunal has appointed Justice Mr. Virendra Singh Gyan Singh Bhat, former member of the National Company Law Tribunal, to be the Chairman of the Meeting.

Mr. Anil S. Kadri, Advocate, or in his absence, CS Rameen Maradiya, Partner, Chirag Shah and Associates, Practicing Company Secretary (Membership No. 11283 B C P. No. 17554), has been appointed as the scrutineer to scrutinize the e-voting during the Meeting and the remote e-voting process.

The Scheme, if approved by the equity shareholders will be subject to subsequent approval of the Hon'ble Tribunal and such other regulatory approvals as may be necessary.

NOTICE is further given that:

- The Amalgamating Company has provided remote e-voting facility to its equity shareholders to enable them to cast their votes electronically and has availed the services of CDSL for providing VCOAVM facility, remote e-voting and e-voting during the Meeting. Some of the important details regarding remote e-voting are provided below:

EVSN	260824011
Commencement of remote e-voting period	Thursday, September 24, 2026 at 9:00 a.m. IST (0900 hours)
End of remote e-voting period	Monday, September 28, 2026 at 5:00 p.m. IST (1700 hours)

The remote e-voting module will be disabled by CDSL thereafter.

- The e-voting facility will also be made available during the Meeting to enable the equity shareholders who have not cast their vote through remote e-voting, to exercise their voting rights. Equity shareholders who have cast their vote through remote e-voting prior to the Meeting may attend the Meeting but shall not be entitled to cast their vote again.
- An equity shareholder, whose name is recorded in the register of members or in the list of beneficial owners maintained by Kfint/depositories/Amalgamating Company as on the cut-off date, i.e. Tuesday, September 22, 2026, only shall be entitled to exercise his/her/its voting rights on the resolution proposed in the Notice and attend the Meeting of the equity shareholders. The voting rights of the equity shareholders of the Amalgamating Company shall be in proportion to their share in the paid-up equity share capital of the Amalgamating Company as on cut-off date i.e. Tuesday, September 22, 2026.
- The Scheme shall be acted upon if a majority of persons representing three-fourth in value of the equity shareholders of the Amalgamating Company voting through remote e-voting and e-voting during the Meeting approve the Scheme. In terms of the provisions of Sections 230-232 of the Act.
- Further, in accordance with Master Circular No. SEBI/HO/CFD/PD-2/P/CIR/2023/93 dated June 20, 2023 issued by Securities and Exchange Board of India, the Scheme shall be acted upon only if the number of votes cast by the public shareholders (through remote e-voting and e-voting during the Meeting) in favour of the Scheme is more than the number of votes cast by the public shareholders against it.
- The results, together with the scrutineer's report, will be displayed at the registered office and on the website of the Amalgamating Company and on the website of CDSL at www.evotingindia.com and shall be communicated to National Stock Exchange of India Limited and to BSE Limited on or before Thursday, October 1, 2026.
- Information and instructions for attending the Meeting including manner of voting (both remote e-voting and e-voting at the Meeting) by the equity shareholders holding shares in dematerialised mode, physical mode and for equity shareholders who have not registered their e-mail address has been provided in the Notice of the Meeting. The manner in which (a) person who becomes an equity shareholder of the Amalgamating Company after dispatch of the Notice and holding equity shares as on cut-off date (mentioned above); (b) equity shareholders who have forgotten the User ID and Password, can obtain/generate the User ID and password, has also been provided in the Notice of the Meeting.
- Equity shareholders holding equity shares in physical mode, who have not registered/updated their e-mail address with the Amalgamating Company, are requested to register/update their e-mail address by submitting Form ISR-1 (available on the website of the Amalgamating Company at <http://www.acclimited.com/investors/shareholders-information> duly filled and signed along with requisite supporting documents to Kfint at investor@kfint.com.
- Equity shareholders holding equity shares in dematerialised mode, who have not registered/updated their e-mail address with their depository participant(s), are requested to register/update their e-mail address with the depository participant(s) where they maintain their demat accounts.
- Equity shareholders seeking any information with regard to the Scheme or the matter proposed to be considered at the aforesaid Meeting, are requested to write to the Amalgamating Company at least 3 (three) days before the date of the Meeting through e-mail on acc-investorsupport@adani.com.
- In case of any difficulty or queries in connection with attending the Meeting through VCOAVM or casting vote through remote e-voting facility, equity shareholders may contact:

For	Name & Designation	E-mail	Address	Contact No.
E-voting	Mr. Rakesh Dahi, Sr. Manager (CDSL)	helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com	Central Depository Services (India) Limited, A Wing, 25th Floor, Marathon Futurex, Mafatali MI Compounds, N. M. Joshi Marg, Lower Parel (East), Mumbai - 400 011	1800 21 09911
VCOAVM				

Dated: August 27, 2026

Sd/-
Justice Mr. Virendra Singh Gyan Singh Bhat,
former member of the National Company Law Tribunal,
Chairman appointed for the Meeting

Sensex 76933.59	NIFTY 24090.85	Gold ₹1,58,386	Silver ₹2,39,500
-539.35	-116.90		
-0.70%	-0.48%		

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER PRICES AS PER INDIAN BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION OF AUGUST 26, 2026
GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 10G, CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF AUGUST 26, 2026

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DAY AFTER 'HIMALAYAN TSUNAMI' IN NEPAL: HELICOPTERS DROP AID & SEARCH FOR THOSE ALIVE, FAMILIES PICK UP THE PIECES

'Can't explain how big waves were'

For survivors, in just a minute their world turned upside down

Binod Ghimire
Kathmandu, August 27

• Foreign Nationals Missing in Nepal

As many as 540 foreigners from 31 countries are among the 667 tourists missing in Nepal after the devastation

COUNTRY	MISSING
CHINA	100+
US	65+
MALAYSIA	55+
UKRAINE	53
BRITAIN	33
AUSTRALIA	25
CANADA	25
SINGAPORE	9
RUSSIA	8
GERMANY	8
NEW ZEALAND	5
SOUTH KOREA	19

REUTERS

But for the survivors, it is the force of the deluge that haunts them. One minute, their lives were routine. The next, the world turned upside down.

Rajan Khatri, 41, a police officer posted at Syabrubesi, one of the riverine villages worst affected by the floods, said he had received a call around 9:10 am local time from a friend warning him that a massive flash flood was heading downstream.

He and his colleagues had no time to react. As soon as he hung up, high waves swept through the police station.

The water flung him out of the building, and he lost consciousness. "One of my senior officers and I were together when the wave struck. I was thrown out, but he was unlucky and was buried or swept away," he said from a hospital bed in Kathmandu.

"I cannot explain how big the waves were. They engulfed several-meters-high buildings in a fraction of seconds," he said. "It wasn't just water. It was a combination of boulders, sand and thick sludge."

Of the seven people who had been working at his police station, Khatri is one of three to have been found alive. He said he was worried about whether the other four had survived.

After regaining consciousness, he looked around and saw nothing but debris. He said at least 100 houses had been swept away, along with the office of a hydropower project, schools and other government facilities.

Khatri waited amid the debris until his rescue on Thursday morning. He had sustained chest injuries from the force of the floodwaters.

Smriti Ojha, 17, was getting ready for school in Trishuli, in Nepal's Nuwakot district, when she felt a tremor.

Initially, she thought it was an earthquake, not unlike the one in 2015 that destroyed her family's home. She rushed out of the house where she lives with her friends. Just as she came out, she saw enormous waves.

"Everyone in the house got out before it was too late, but we couldn't save anything," she said from her hospital bed, where she was receiving treatment for a cut on her right foot. Her immediate family, which lives more than five miles from the destruction, is safe, but four of her relatives are missing.

"It was terror," she said. "I cannot believe everything was swept away before my eyes."



UK offers funds, responders; King Charles 'heartbroken'

London: The UK on Thursday offered Nepal \$5 million pounds and emergency responders. British PM Andy Burnham described scenes emerging as "devastating" and urged British nationals caught in crisis to follow guidance from local officials.

"It's a devastating picture that is emerging from Nepal... An offer has been made of emergency responders to head to region... there are a number of British nationals who currently are thought to be missing and we'll be providing all the support we can to their families," he said.

King Charles III and Queen Camilla said they were "heartbroken" to hear of the devastating flooding and expressed their "profound sympathy". "Many in the UK have strong, deep and personal ties to this part of the world," the royals said. **PTI**



"I am saddened by severe flooding in Nepal & China, which claimed many lives, left people missing, and caused destruction. I extend my condolences to the families of the victims, and wish a swift recovery to those injured. My solidarity is with all affected. The UN is supporting Government-led response. UN teams... are mobilising aid & personnel."

ANTONIO GUTERRES,
SECRETARY-GENERAL OF THE UNITED NATIONS

A drone view shows mud covering buildings following the devastating floods at Trishuli in Nuwakot district, Nepal on Thursday. (Left) A girl cries as she awaits news of relatives missing in Bidur district. **PTI/AP**

China's information control could hamper flood rescue efforts in Tibet

Lily Kuo
August 27

AS JOURNALISTS in Nepal gather eyewitness accounts and up-to-date information about the deadly flood that swept entire villages away Wednesday, the scene across border in China could not be more different.

By Thursday, videos taken and posted online by locals, including a widely circulated clip of a mudslide engulfing a border crossing in Gyirong County, in China's Tibet, were censored on Chinese social media platforms.

More than 500 people were missing in Gyirong, with three confirmed deaths in the county of about 2,000 people. The authorities have provided no details about which villages and settlements in the mostly rural area

have been affected.

Instead, the only information has come from China's government-controlled state media outlets, where coverage has focused mostly on the rescue efforts. The government has sent members of Chinese military and other emergency workers into the area, the outlets report, along with drones and helicopters.

The *People's Daily*, the official newspaper of the Chinese Communist Party, led on Thursday with a story about China's leader, Xi Jinping, ordering that all-out efforts be made to help the victims in Gyirong.

Censorship and tight control of information is common throughout China, but nowhere is that more apparent than in Tibet, which has been under

• DEADLIEST GLACIER DISASTERS IN HISTORY

1941 — HUARAZ, PERU:
A glacial lake outburst flood destroyed one-third of Huaraz, killing 5,000 people.

1962 — RANRAHIRCA, PERU:
An ice, rock and snow slide from Mount Husscarán buried Ranrahirca under 12 metres of debris, killing about 4,000.

1970 — YUNGAY, PERU:
A magnitude 7.9 quake destabilised Mount Husscarán, ice and rock buried Yungay and Ranrahirca, killing 20,000 people.

1981 — CIRENMA CO, TIBET:
A glacial collapse into Cirenma Co sent nearly 20 million cubic metres of water, ice and debris into Nepal, 200 people and damaging infrastructure.

2021 — CHAMOLI, INDIA:
Ice and rock from Ronti Peak triggered a flash flood in Uttarakhand, killing more than 200 people and destroying villages and two hydropower projects.

2026 — NEPAL-TIBET BORDER:
A Himalayan glacier collapse sent ice, rock and mud down the Lhende Khola river, triggering flash floods across Tibet and Nepal. Over 1,000 are missing and at least 270 dead. **REUTERS**

Chinese control since 1950s and where calls for greater autonomy have erupted into protests.

No foreign journalists are allowed in except on heavily orchestrated government tours. Officials in Tibet have tightened restrictions on Tibetan monks and nuns and expanded policing to prevent any renewed protests.

Tibetans in the region can be detained or arrested for speaking to journalists or posting anything online that is seen as counter to the government narrative, according to rights activists.

"If people are afraid to share that information, or if their posts are removed," he said, "potentially useful information may not reach families, relief workers or the wider public." **NTV**

Qatar PM pursues mediation in Iran as US ramps up 'economic war'

Reuters
Cairo, Dubai, August 27

THE PRIME minister of US ally Qatar visited Tehran on Thursday in a bid to revive diplomacy as the US and Iran traded re-creations over Washington's latest sanctions drive, described by one Iranian official as "all-out economic war".

The visit comes as the war nears its sixth month with fighting largely paused but no diplomatic breakthrough in sight. Both sides are at odds over control of the Strait.

The White House said there were currently no negotiations happening between the United States and Iran as Tehran had not yet "come to the table in a meaningful way". Iran has repeatedly said it has never left the negotiating table.

Qatar's Prime Minister

Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al Thani, who is also his country's foreign minister, held talks in Tehran with Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, according to Iran's foreign ministry channel on Telegram.

The two discussed a proposed phased framework that includes establishing a temporary joint Iranian-Omani shipping corridor through strait and carrying out a joint project to clear mines from the waterway, Qatar's foreign ministry said.

A memorandum of understanding reached between the US and Iran in June to end the conflict broke down in part because of differences over the strait between Iran and Oman.

Tehran has said the strait will remain shut unless the US meets Iranian conditions agreed under the June interim ceasefire. Those conditions in-

clude an end to the US blockade on Iranian ports, compensation and removal of sanctions.

The two officials also reviewed the latest developments in the region and efforts to de-escalate tensions and create conditions for dialogue, the Qatari ministry said.

White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt said on Thursday that President Donald Trump "continues to retain all options on the table" with regard to Iran. "We've had Operation Epic Fury to destroy their military. Now we have Operation Economic Outcast to destroy their economy," Leavitt said in an interview with Fox News.

"No negotiations are happening right now, and this will continue until the president feels that maybe they come to the table in a meaningful way," Leavitt said.

Trial for accused mastermind of 9/11 attacks set for June 2028

Washington: A US Air Force judge on Wednesday ordered Khalid Sheikh Mohammed, the accused mastermind of the September 11, 2001, attacks on the United States, and three co-defendants to go on trial before a military tribunal in June 2028.

The trial-scheduling order entered by Air Force Lieutenant Colonel Michael Schramma marked the latest milestone in a military prosecution beset by two decades of legal deadlock surrounding the four detainees held in Guantanamo Bay, Cuba.

Last month, a US appeals court had refused to allow Mohammed and two of his co-defendants to plead guilty under agreements that would have spared them the death penalty. **REUTERS**

Russia bombards nine Ukraine cities in massive overnight drone strikes

Associated Press
Kyiv, August 27

RUSSIA BOMBARDED cities across Ukraine with missiles and drones in an overnight onslaught that ran into the daylight hours Thursday, when explosions echoed around Kyiv through the morning.

The Russian Defence Ministry said its forces carried out a "massive" strike on targets in nine Ukrainian cities that began after nightfall on Wednesday. It described the targets as military related, including industrial facilities, oil refineries, logistics hubs and port infrastructure.

Civilian areas, including apartment buildings, suffered damage. The barrage killed a 78-year-old woman in the southern Zaporizhzhia region and

another person in the northern Kharkiv region, with at least 14 people reported wounded elsewhere, Ukrainian officials said.

"Russia continues to invest in missiles and in expanding its war, which means more countermeasures are needed," Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said, noting promises earlier this week by European countries to provide more air defence assistance. "It is important that these (measures) are also supplemented by additional ballistic missile defence packages" through European purchases of weapons from US, he said.

Zelenskyy was due to visit neighbouring Moldova on Thursday to mark its national day commemorating its 1991 declaration of independence from the Soviet Union.

• BRIEFLY

SERBIA

'Butcher of Bosnia' Ratko Mladic, convicted of genocide, dies at 83



Ratko Mladic was captured in 2011 and put on trial for genocide

RATKO MLADIC, the former Bosnian Serb general whose actions during the Balkan wars of the 1990s led to him being called the "Butcher of Bosnia" and who was held responsible for Europe's deadliest massacre since World War II, the killing of some 8,000 Muslim men and boys at Srebrenica in 1995, has died. He was 83. His death was announced on Thursday by Serbian state media. Mladic was captured on May 26, 2011, in a farming village north of Belgrade, Serbia's capital, after almost 16 years as a fugitive, ending one of the longest manhunts in modern history. His 2017 conviction by an international tribunal on charges of genocide, crimes against humanity and war crimes marked the end of a dark and bloody chapter. **NTV**

FRANCE

2 killed after car rams into crowd, suspect arrested

A DRIVER deliberately rammed their car into a group of people in northern France, killing two people and injuring nine others, authorities said. The incident Wednesday night in Caen isn't being treated by officials as a terrorist attack. Caen Mayor Aristeide Olivier told said it seemed to be the result of "a fight that turned bad." The top regional official, Calvados Prefect David Clavier, initially said that one person was killed. His office on Thursday revised the death toll to two. The suspected driver has been arrested, according to Clavier, who said the man was born in Russia. **AP**

UNITED STATES

Lake Ontario is Lake America: Trump signs it

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump signed an executive order on Thursday to rename Lake Ontario as Lake America, a change he said would "reflect the reality" of the lake's location. The order, signed by the Department of the Interior and Secretary Doug Burgum to make the change. One of the five Great Lakes of North America, Lake Ontario borders both the Canadian province of Ontario and the US state of New York. Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney's office did not immediately respond to a request for comment on the proposed name change. **REUTERS**

• META TO TIGHTEN AGE CHECKS, CAP UNDER-18 USE AT TWO HOURS DAILY, BLOCK ACCESS FROM MIDNIGHT TO 6AM AND HIDE 'LIKE' COUNTS ON POSTS

Time limits and a midnight cutoff: Meta's new rules for kids

Barbara Ortutay
& Wyatt Gramham-Phillips
Oakland, August 27

KIDS UNDER 18 will soon see changes to their Instagram and Facebook experiences under an \$18 billion settlement Meta Platforms reached with 48 US states.

Besides the money, Meta has agreed to strengthen age-related restrictions on children under 13 off its platforms, place teens in age-appropriate accounts, impose a two-hour daily limit for users under 18, block access from midnight to 6 am and hide "like" counts.

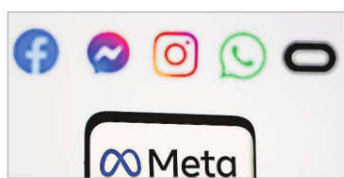
The safeguards apply only

in the United States, with most remaining for 10 years.

Critics acknowledged the measures go further than Meta has previously gone on child safety, but cautioned they will not solve its problems overnight.

Arturo Béjar, a former Meta engineering director and the first witness in the federal trial, called the settlement a "significant milestone" but said parents should not consider Instagram entirely safe for children.

He criticised the agreement for allowing Meta to define harm and urged Meta to define additive content recommendations. Teens may stop



using the platform after two hours but remain distressed because its design can leave them craving more.

Meta said users over 18 can adopt some controls individ-

ually, including daily time-limit reminders, but cannot opt into the overall teen settings.

Meta requires users to be at least 13 to create an account, in line with federal child privacy

law. Béjar testified that Meta had taken a "don't ask, don't tell" approach toward children under 13, despite having systems to detect fake accounts. He said there were "no goals, no metrics" for checking suspected underage users.

Many safeguards will be enabled by default, including the two-hour limit, which requires parental permission to disable, and the midnight-to-6 a.m. restriction. But features such as turning off video autoplay or displaying posts chronologically will remain opt-in.

Josh Golin, executive director of online safety nonprofit

Fairplay, said the deal focused too much on giving parents tools rather than restricting harmful features. He criticised the lack of default limits on recommendation algorithms that can connect children to predators or lead down "dangerous rabbit holes."

Yael Eisenstat, of the Cybersafety Research Center, said it was too early to know whether all desired changes would happen, noting that many past safety tools had proved ineffective. Still, she called the settlement monumental because it shows feasible options exist. **AP**

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कार्पोरेशन लि० विद्युत
पारेण मण्डल, मयूता, निवदि
सूचना, निविदा संख्या एथं
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पूर्व सामान्य को सूचित किया जाता है कि निम्नांकित दिनांक -08 / 06 / 20 के अतिरिक्त शिक्षा मन्त्रालय काठमांडौ क्षेत्राधिकार क्षेत्र में सम्मान्यता में प्राप्त नहीं है लेकिन जहाँ मानक माध्यिक का प्राप्ति प्राप्त प्रमाण नहीं है उक्त व्यक्ति होकर अपना दावा प्रस्तुत नहीं करिये हे तथा कुछ मामलों में दावा प्रस्तुत करने के उपरांत अधिवैधित्व हेतु

S/L NO.	CASE NO.	DM CASE NO.	THANA	LTR NO	NAME AND ADDRESS	THANA / CASE NO
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1	180/2026	405/2026	गोकुलपुर	1186 / फिलिप निका 28.05	लोरी कोंराइन विधान- सभा क्षेत्रीय जिला, मुजफ्फर नगर, सीताई 110092	मोहनपुर पंचायत बडा डोला-284 / 25 दिनांक 02.11.2025

अतः समाचार पत्र के माध्यम से उक्त जानकारी वादा माध्यिक को सूचित किया जाता है कि इस सूचना के द्वारा अपने अधिकार क्षेत्र के माध्यम से उपस्थित होकर निर्दिष्ट कार्य को वकालत करना कि अन्य कोई भी भ्रमण / धमकी / शिकायत -14.09.2025 तक या उससे पहले करने पर यह गम्भीर जागरण की संवेधित साक्ष्य को इतर तथ्यों के मुख्य रूप पर आधारित किया जाएगा।

यदि सूची में उल्लिखित वादान पर किसी अन्य व्यक्ति का दावा बनाओ तो उसे स्थिति ही सत्यमान न्यायालय उक्त सूचना www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdibihar पर भी देखी जा सकती है।

नशे की मार, बर्बाद करे सुझी
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Department of Agriculture, Government of Bihar

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Proposal can only be uploaded/submitted on EMD and Tender fee payment should be through online

SN	Activity
1.	Start Date & Time for Downloading of Tender Document
2.	Date and place for pre-bid meeting (Online/Hybrid mode)
3.	Last Date & Time for submission/ uploading of offer/Bid
4.	Date and time of technical bid opening
5.	Date and time of financial bid opening
6.	Nodal officer/Contact person for queries
7.	Mode of Selection

Agriculture Director, Agriculture Department, Patna
A proposal without assigning any reasons thereof.

PR-010623 (Agriculture) 2026-27

बिहार पोर्टल www.state.bihar.gov.in/

गोपालगंज			
कौन उपकरण अभियन्ता को सहायता प्राप्त करने के अधीन है। (एक पृष्ठ का संक्षेपित प्रारूप प्रस्तुत करना है।)			
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के 15 दिनों के अन्दर अवस्था-सूचक की म्यादावधि में स्वयं या अधिकृत पेशेवर यांत्रिक को परीक्षा कर लिया जाय। निम्नलिखित है और सदुपयोग अभियन्ता में उपलब्ध जानकारी को आधार

परीक्षित होकर सक्षम साबित करना पक्ष रख सकते हैं।

परीक्षक

अधिर सभापति (नोडिफिकेशन)
गोपालगंज

 GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA		TENDER NOTICE				
SR NO	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	PWD BSR, KARNAL	CONST. OF KARAOOI HALL WITH FACILITIES ACADAMY AT VILLAGE PAI IN DISTT. KATHAL (POG. CCTY SYSTEM ONLY) + 5 WORKS	26.08.2026 02.09.2026	272.62 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01842565696 pwd-eees@karnal.bhry.nic.in
2	PWD BSR, YAMUNA NAGAR	CONSTRUCTION OF RICE BOSS BRIDGE (SING) ON LINK ROAD FROM MUSTAFABAD CHAPAR ROAD TO SURKHOPAD (RD 395) KM 1.378 TO 1.462 IN YAMUNA NAGAR DISTRICT FOR CROSSING OF FLOOR/RAIN WATER. + 1 WORKS	26.08.2026 05.09.2026	429.34 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	pwd-eees@yamnanaagar.bhry.nic.in
3	PWD BSR, HISAR	WDG AND STD OF 08 NOS. ROAD (1) APP. ROAD TO GHURSA, ABADI ROAD RD 0.0 TO 0.50 (5041) (2) GHURSA, BANDHOARI TO CHAUDHARIALI SCHOOL ROAD RD 0.0 TO 0.200 (5043) (3) PHC DOBTI TO BUS STAND VIA MANDIR IN VILL. DOBTI ROAD RD 0.0 TO 0.430 (5029) (4) APP. ROAD TO PHIRNE VILL. DOBTI ROAD RD 0.0 TO 0.160 (5030) (5) KHARA DOBTI TO ABADI DOBTI ROAD RD 0.0 TO 0.380 (5033) (6) BURAK BANDHOARI ROAD TO BANDHOARI CHAUDHARIALI ROAD VILL. BANDHOARI ROAD RD 0.0 TO 0.870 (5045) (7) BANDHOARI TEMPLE ROAD RD 0.0 TO 0.315 (5046) (8) APP. ROAD TO BURAK ABADI ROAD RD 0.0 TO 0.300 (5047) IN HISAR DISTT. (ADAMPUR CONSTITUENCY WP 2026-27 (C. No. 5) + 3 WORKS	CLOSING DATE 03.09.2026	1425.18 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9878384499 pwd-espsd@hisar.bhry.nic.in
4	PANCHAYATI RAJ, GANUR	CONSTRUCTION OF NALA (BABA SARADHI TO RAIBER 5/3 SHRI PRITHI) AT VILLAGE BAMBAS KALAN BLOCK GANUR SONPAT NAME OF SCHEME VANGY	CLOSING DATE 09.09.2026	6.71 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	7015775121 sdganurraj@gmail.com
5	PANCHAYATI RAJ, NARNAUL	RAMBAAS BLOCK NZADPUR CUM OF GAD + 5 WORKS	26.08.2026 02.09.2026	324.51 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	901717990 preveen.nf@gmail.com
6	PANCHAYATI RAJ, KARNAL	CONST. OF HALL FOR INDOOR GYM IN VILLAGE MOHIDIPUR BLOCK KARNAL + 5 WORKS	25.08.2026 02.09.2026	196.05 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	989654422 preveen.kh@hry.nic.in
7	PANCHAYATI RAJ, KARNAL	RAISING OF MAIN PUIRIN FROM NAGDA NARAI TO MAHARANA PARTAB BHAVAN AT VILLAGE GENDER BLOCK NISSING DISTRICT KARNAL + 4 WORKS	26.08.2026 05.09.2026	147.46 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	989654422 preveen.kh@hry.nic.in
8	PANCHAYATI RAJ PINORE	COMPLETION OF VYAMSHAJA AT VILLAGE PALOHA BLOCK PINORE	28.08.2026 31.08.2026	7.50 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9466110204 sdgprpinore@gmail.com
9	SHOM GOVT. MEDICAL COLLEGE NALHARNUH	TENDER FOR PURCHASE OF VARIOUS MEDICINE FOR DEPARTMENT OF ORTHOPEDICS, SURGERY AND ORS & GYNAE AT SHAHEED HASAN MEWATI GOVT. MEDICAL COLLEGE, NALHAR	31.08.2026 14.09.2026	3.50 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01267-282007 tendermgcnal@gmail.com
10	SHOM GOVT. MEDICAL COLLEGE NALHARNUH	TENDER FOR PURCHASE ANTIBIOTIC DISCS FOR DEPARTMENT OF MICROBIOLOGY AT SHAHEED HASAN MEWATI GOVT. MEDICAL COLLEGE, NALHAR	31.08.2026 14.09.2026	98,280/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01267-282007 tendermgcnal@gmail.com
11	SHOM GOVT. MEDICAL COLLEGE NALHARNUH	TENDER FOR PURCHASE OF TONER CARTRIDGE FOR SHARP PHOTOCOPIER MACHINE MODEL NO. BP 2000 AT SHAHEED HASAN MEWATI GOVT. MEDICAL COLLEGE, NALHAR	31.08.2026 14.09.2026	2 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01267-282007 tendermgcnal@gmail.com
12	SHOM GOVT. MEDICAL COLLEGE NALHARNUH	TENDER FOR PURCHASE OF MEDICAL ITEMS FOR DEPARTMENT OF DENTISTRY AT SHAHEED HASAN MEWATI GOVT. MEDICAL COLLEGE, NALHAR	31.08.2026 14.09.2026	4.31 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01267-282007 tendermgcnal@gmail.com
13	BPS GMC FOR WOMEN KHANPUR KALAN, SONPAT.	REGULAR PUBLISHING OF ADVERTISEMENT FOR TENDERS OF PROCUREMENT OF CONSUMABLES & OTHERS ITEMS RGV UNITS-2 COLLEGE AT BPS GMC (W) KHANPUR KALAN SONPAT. (CATEGORY- GOODS)	27.08.2026 02.09.2026	EMD 25000	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416803361 bpsgmc.purchase@gmail.com
14	FOREST DEPARTMENT, SIRSA	NEW PLANTATION WORKS IN KULWANI NAGAR UNDER STATE, CAMPA AND WILDLIFE SCHEME	26.08.2026 02.09.2026	250.49 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	941667122 sirsa.enquiry@sho.com
15	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT	INTERNAL AND OUTLET CLEARANCE OF NATHUR MINOR FROM RD. 4 - 41260- TALAI IN KEHARWALI SECTION (KHARIF 2026) + 1 WORKS	CLOSING DATE 02.09.2026	3.97 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	999665651 xenss.espsd@haryana.gov.in



Department of Agriculture

2nd Floor, Krishi Bhawan, Mithapur, Patna-800001,
e-mail: diragri.bih@gmail.com,
<https://state.bihar.gov.in/krishi/CitizenHome.html>

NOTICE – INVITING E-TENDER

Through e-procurement mode only over (<https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in>)

E-Tender Selection of Agency for Managing Social Media Platforms for Department of Agriculture, Government of Bihar

For timely and smooth execution of different schemes of Agriculture development in 2026-27 in the State of Bihar invites e-Tender for Agency for Engagement of Public Relations and Social Media Management for Agriculture Department, Government of Bihar.

E-tender forms including terms and conditions for technical qualification, specifications and procedure are available on website: <https://state.bihar.gov.in/krishi/CitizenHome.html> and <https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in>. Applicants may upload/submit their tender along with all required documents for technical qualification through the online portal (<https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in>). Financial proposals should also be proposed on the portal in prescribed form separately. In case of any technical difficulty related to bid application e-proc team can connected on Toll Free Number: 1800 572 6571 or Email: eproc2support@bihar.gov.in

Proposal can only be uploaded/submitted on the website <https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in> while E-Tender Fee payment should be through online mode (NET/RTGS).

SN	Activity	Date/Time: Duration
1.	Start Date & Time for Downloading of Tender document	01.09.2026 (10:00 Hrs.)
2.	Date and place for pre-bid meeting (Online/hybrid mode)	03.09.2026 (13:00 Hrs.), Room No 123, Krishi Bhawan, Mithapur, Patna - 800001
3.	Last Date & Time for submission/ uploading of offer/Bid	21.09.2026 (15:00 Hrs.)
4.	Date and time of technical bid opening	23.09.2026 (15:30 Hrs.)
5.	Date and time of financial bid opening	To be intimated to technically successful bidder only
6.	Nodal officer/Contact person for queries	Sri Shashi Ranjan Kumar, Mob.No.- 6203899811
7.	Mode of Selection	Quality Cost Based Selection- QCBS

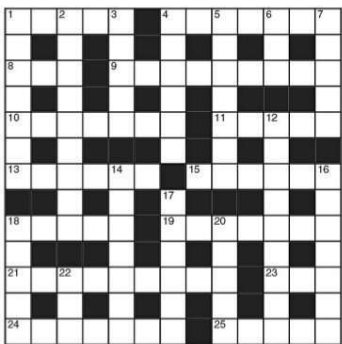
Agriculture Director, Agriculture Department reserves the right to revise/change/cancel the proposal without assigning any reasons therefor.

Agriculture Director
Bihar Patna

PR- 010623 (Agriculture)-2026-27
सिद्धि सुख www.state.bihar.gov.in/pr/bihar श्री देवी श्रमजी

CROSSWORD

6079



ACROSS

- 1 Type of Italian capitalist? (5)
 4 Return ticket to the Australian bush? (7)
 8 It is thought wise to be seen at night (3)
 9 Youngster put to bed and left alone (9)
 10 Motion for bail due to be heard (7)
 11 One studies images (5)
 13 One's characteristics begin holding one back (6)
 15 Much time and trouble is taken in its drafting (6)
 18 Pass out with many a twitch (5)
 19 Large vessel used as a pressure cooker (7)
 21 Yet it's wrong to imitate anything like this (9)
 23 Pile of carpets (3)
 24 Individuals appearing in court (7)
 25 Like to declare in test (5)

DOWN

- 1 Draconian law give Brazilian city discretion (4,3)
 2 Mother takes in the older variety of play (9)
 3 Article sent up by Robert — a rich man (5)
 4 It plays a vital part in a tent (6)
 5 Impressive work by the bookmaker (7)
 6 Wild cat exploit (3)
 7 Rising United Kingdom party's prestige (5)
 12 They add grace to manners perhaps (9)
 14 Many carried away by it lost their heads (7)
 16 A prize for waste (7)
 17 States times for customs (6)
 18 Groups of files for example dropping in (5)
 20 A minor player makes more (5)
 22 Shut up and write (3)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6078 ACROSS: 1 Grandstand, 8 Clout, 9 Ammeter, 10 Nebular, 11 Arrow, 12 Insist, 14 Adders, 17 Esie, 19 Escapes, 21 Emerged, 22 Verne, 23 Put on an act DOWN: 2 Rhombus, 3 Natal, 4 Stary, 5 Ambled, 6 Deter, 7 Crowd scene, 8 Considered, 13 Slight, 15 Empiric, 16 Redden, 18 Steep, 20 Coven

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Happiness isn't something you experience; it's something you — Oscar Levant (8)

ALVEE EGRMR

ELVER EFLUMB

remember Oscar Levant

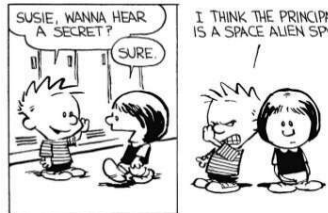
SOLUTIONS: Leave, Leery, Mergery, Fumble

OVER THE HEDGE



BY MICHAEL FRY & T. LEWIS

CALVIN & HOBBS



BY BILL WATTERSON

MARVIN



BY TOM ARMSTRONG

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 3s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius



SUDOKU 6424



SOLUTIONSUDOKU6423

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

- ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20):** This is a challenging day at work. Unexpected problems, including staff shortages, might occur. People are also touchy. Be mindful of everything you say and do. Tonight: Privacy.
- TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21):** Today you need to keep track of your money because something unexpected could impact your wealth through damage, loss or theft. This is an accident-prone day for your kids. Social plans will change. Tonight: Friendships.
- GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21):** This is a challenging day! It's the classic day for rebellion against authority. Your home routine might change. Equipment might break. Tread carefully. Tonight: Be modest.
- CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23):** Pay attention to everything you say and do today because this is an accident-prone day. Think before you speak, because you might feel controlled by your impulses. Be aware of everything you do. Keep things simple. Tonight: Check your finances.
- LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23):** This is a challenging day in terms of dealing with your money as well as friends and groups. Fortunately, you will be diplomatic and skillful when speaking with others. By nature, you are quick to see the big picture, and this will help. Tonight: Cooperate.
- VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23):** Today the Sun is in your sign at odds with Uranus and the Moon. This is not easy. You might suddenly have an argument. Sudden upsets are classic. Equipment or cars might have sudden breakdowns. Keep your eyes open to avoid accidents. Tonight: Work.
- LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23):** This is a tough day, but there are some blessings. For the most part, your work routine might be interrupted. Travel plans might suddenly change. It's the kind of day where you take two steps forward and one step back. Tonight: Get better organised.
- SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23):** Unexpected upsets with friends, groups and financial institutions might take place today. People might quarrel about assets or money. This is an accident-prone day for your kids. Tonight: Socialise.
- SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22):** This is the classic day for a public argument or a rebellion. Fortunately, the position of the Sun makes you look good. You could end up with egg on your face. Don't throw your weight around. Be patient and tolerant with others. Tonight: Relax at home.
- CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20):** Tread carefully, because this is an accident-prone day. Whatever happens will be swift and come right out of the blue. Pay attention to everything you say and do, especially related to your work. Travel will be interrupted. Tonight: Intense conversations.
- AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19):** Today is full of all kinds of unexpected events and little rebellions; this wild energy will likely impact your possessions and money. Social plans will suddenly change. Parents must be extra vigilant about their kids. Tonight: Check your belongings.
- PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20):** Today the Moon is in your sign at odds with the Sun, Mercury and Uranus. Today is the classic day for little rebellions and accidents. Equipment and cars might break down. Family arguments might take place. Tonight: You're in charge.



AMITY UNIVERSITY - LEADERSHIP FORUM

Amity International Business School, Amity University Noida, organized the CEO & CHRO Leadership Forum and Awards 2026 to strengthen academia-industry engagement on leadership, innovation, AI, talent, and employability. Dr. Gurinder Singh, Group Vice Chancellor, highlighted Amity's integration of technology, case-based learning, NEP 2020, and industry exposure. The CEO Forum featured leaders from Tata Consumer Products, Mahindra Finance, Volvo Cars India, Deloitte, and HDFC Bank, who discussed "The New Leadership Equation: Driving Growth through People, Purpose & AI," emphasizing the importance of human values, trust, wisdom, and responsible AI. The CHRO Forum explored "People, Purpose & Possibilities: Reimagining Human Capital in the Age of AI," with senior HR leaders sharing insights. Distinguished leaders were also felicitated for excellence in strategic leadership, human capital, consumer business, and industry contribution.



SARLA CHOPRA DAV PUBLIC SCHOOL - EVENT

Sarla Chopra DAV Public School, Noida hosted the 18th edition of VIBGYOR - A Colourful Fiesta, a vibrant inter-school extravaganza. The fiesta witnessed enthusiastic participation from nearly 300 students from around 20 schools across Delhi-NCR and Noida. The event featured competitions in sports, sustainable fashion, music, dance, fitness, art, poetry, literature and technology. It concluded with a prize distribution ceremony celebrating talent, creativity and stellar performances. Principal Mrs. Upasana Sharma motivated the students and expressed gratitude to the distinguished judges, their talents. She also expressed heartfelt gratitude to the distinguished judges.



NIET - EVENT

Noida Institute of Engineering and Technology, Greater Noida, participated in the QS I-GAUGE National Summit on AI in Indian Education, held on recently at The Leela, Gandhinagar, Gujarat, with support from MeitY Government of India. Dr. Neema Agarwal, Additional Managing Director, NIET, joined the Presidential Roundtable on "Crafting the Next-Generation Graduate: University Leadership for an AI-Driven Future." The summit brought together academic leaders and experts to discuss responsible AI adoption in higher education, focusing on access, equity, excellence and ethics. Dr. Agarwal's participation reflected NIET's commitment to future-ready education, responsible innovation, employability, and human-centric learning in an AI-driven landscape.

CORPORATE BRIEFS

EDUCATION



JIT NOIDA - INTERNATIONAL SYMPOSIUM

The 30th International Symposium on VLSI Design and Test (VDAT 2026) was inaugurated at Jaypee Institute of Information Technology (JIIT), Noida, from 20-22 August 2026, themed "Advancing Intelligent, Secure and Quantum-Ready Semiconductor Systems." Hosted by JIIT with leading Delhi-NCR institutions and supported by VLSI Society of India and IEEE Uttar Pradesh Section, the symposium brings together academia, industry and researchers. Chief Guest Ms. Sunita Verma, MeitY, and Guest of Honour Dr. Kamaljeet Singh, SCL Mohali, highlighted India's semiconductor ambitions. Discussions focused on AI, chiplets, hardware security, advanced packaging, silicon photonics and quantum technologies.



K.R. MANGALAM UNIVERSITY - ORIENTATION

The University organised "Aarambh 2026" Orientation Day to welcome new students. Chancellor Padma Shri Prof. Dinesh Singh highlighted the impact of Artificial Intelligence and urged students to contribute to Viksit Bharat @2047 through innovation. Chief Guest Mr. Ankur Waikoo encouraged creative thinking, adaptability and entrepreneurship. Vice-Chancellor Prof. (Dr.) Anil Kumar Saini emphasised values, responsibility and NEP 2020's vision of future-ready education. Startups from the University's Business Incubator received Letters of Intent, while the Student Council and clubs were recognised. Singer Akasa Singh's performance added vibrancy to celebrations.



HMIT UNIVERSITY - ORIENTATION

The University organised an Orientation Program for the Faculty of Pharmacy and Pharmaceutical Sciences. The event began with lamp lighting and Saraswati Vandana, followed by introductions to the University. Senior officials guided students on academics, attendance, skill development, placements, scholarships, examinations and discipline. Senior students shared experiences and entertained the gathering with musical performances. The highlight was the Pharmacist's Oath, administered to students, marking the beginning of their professional journey. The programme concluded with a vote of thanks by Shikha Parmar, reinforcing the University's commitment to holistic learning.



GALGOTIAS UNIVERSITY - EVENT

The University hosted a 200-member delegation from Yamaguchi Prefecture, Japan, led by Governor Kotaro Nagasaki, marking a significant step towards strengthening India-Japan academic, research and workforce collaboration. Dr. Dhruv Galgotia, CEO, Galgotias University, welcomed the delegation and highlighted opportunities for global careers and joint research in clean energy. The visit witnessed the signing of an MoU with the Yamaguchi Prefectural Government and a Letter of Intent with the University of Yamaguchi, focusing on talent mobility and clean-energy research. Delegates engaged in discussions on green hydrogen, healthcare education, student exchanges and skilling, and toured advanced facilities in AI, drones and semiconductors. Both sides reaffirmed their commitment to student and faculty exchanges, collaborative research, innovation and clean-energy initiatives.



KIET UNIVERSITY - INTERNATIONAL CONFERENCE

Hosted its 10th International Conference - ICRIPI 2K26 on "Redefining Innovative Practices in the Age of AI" recently. Organized with international partners including Southwestern Oklahoma State University, INTI International University & Colleges, and The George Washington University, the conference brought together academicians, researchers, and industry experts. Vinita Singh Sahay, Director, IMB Both Gaya, graced the event as Chief Guest. Discussions explored AI's impact on business, education, healthcare, sustainability, and society. With 12 technical tracks and over 100 research papers, the conference promoted knowledge exchange, global collaboration, and responsible AI innovation.



IMS DIA - ORIENTATION

IMS Design & Innovation Academy (IMS DIA), Noida, welcomed Batch of 2026 with Prarambh, its orientation held August 18, 2026. Dr. Nair and Dr. Nimisha welcomed attendees: Nehal and Apoorva presented on DIA, followed by a lamp-lighting ceremony with Ritu and Mr. Nair. VP Chirag Gupta spoke on nurturing creativity through observation and experimentation. Students joined Sasi Menors workshop, "Exploring Perception: The Magic of Imagination," while parents attended Yash's "DIA - Calendar of Opportunities." Performances by DIA's Dance, Music and Fashion Clubs, plus a closing DJ session, welcomed the new cohort into DIA's creative community.

SRI LANKA VS INDIA, SECOND TEST

Four wickets from a series sweep, India run into immovable obstacle Dinusha

Twin centuries and a stubborn lower order turned a probable 2-0 result into a hard-earned 1-0 series win

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, August 27

IN THE middle of the 104th over, Keshara Nuwantha needed medical attention from the physio. India had, by then, bowled 31 overs on the fifth morning in Colombo, and still couldn't prise apart the stubborn pairing of Sonal Dinusha and Nuwantha. The clock ticked, but the wickets refused to come.

It had reached the point where Rishabh Pant tried swapping the balls, before Dhruv Jurel went a step further and swapped the stumps, perhaps hoping a small alteration might somehow change India's fortunes. It was a small act, but telling one. India had become that desperate.

Nuwantha eventually fell soon after lunch, briefly offering India the opening they'd been waiting for.

The pitch remained stubbornly unresponsive, and Sri Lanka's lower order refused to give in. Shubman Gill's decision to enforce the follow-on had looked logical after India reduced Sri Lanka to 229 for 6.

Four wickets on the final morning appeared well within reach. The bowlers kept Sri Lanka under pressure, but couldn't finish the innings before the hosts had done enough to survive. India had hoped Sri Lanka might dangle a carrot and set a stiff target. It never came.

Those four wickets looked simple enough on paper, but proved incredibly hard to find in practice. The pitch offered only occasional help, Sri Lanka's lower order refused to budge, and Dinusha seemed determined to keep India waiting. The spinners toiled almost relentlessly. The most experienced of the trio, Ravindra Jadeja, bowled 38.3 overs and finished with 3 for 94. He found enough drift and occasional turn to remain a threat, but never the sustained assistance that would have made the pressure tell.

His dismissal of Lahiru Kumara was one of India's few late rewards. A ball spun sharply in, struck Kumara on the pad and lobbed up, and Yashasvi Jaiswal reacted quickly to hold a one-handed catch at short leg. Kumara had faced 90 balls for his 12, soaking up valuable time for Sri Lanka.

Manav Suthar, who bowled the most overs in the second innings, 41, was similarly industrious, varying his pace and flight and repeatedly asking questions. India could have been more attacking at times, though, particularly against the tall, fuller lengths, tighter fields, more pressure around the bat.

One missed opportunity summed it up. Kumara slog-swept Suthar towards Jurel at

Scorecard

SRI LANKA vs INDIA

COLOMBO

TOSS: India won, chose to bat

INDIA (503/9 DECLARED)

SRI LANKA 290 &

(FOLLOWING ON) O/N-229/6

Sonal Dinusha not out

133 (264b, 8x4, 2x6)

Keshara Nuwantha c Jurel b Suthar

46 (150b, 4x4)

Prabath Jayasuriya c Jurel b Jadeja

2 (28b)

Lahiru Kumara c Jaiswal b Jadeja

12 (90b, 1x4)

Ashith Fernando not out

0 (24b)

● **EXTRAS** (b 7, lb 8, nb 7, w 3) 25

● **TOTAL** (154 Overs) 429/9d

● **FoW**: 7-330 (Keshara Nuwantha, 104.4 ov), 8-355 (Prabath Jayasuriya, 116.3 ov), 9-402 (Lahiru Kumara, 144.4 ov)

● **BOWLING**: Pradeep Krishna 18.3-3-57.1; Mohammed Siraj 15-7-26.1; Manav Suthar 41-7-121.3; Saransh Jain 37-4-98.1; Ravindra Jadeja 38.3-4-94.3; Shubman Gill 2-0-8-0; Yashasvi Jaiswal 1-0-9-0; Dhruv Jurel 1-0-1-0

deep mid-wicket, who ran in and dived, but the ball landed just short.

There was an element of unfamiliarity too. Neither Suthar nor debutant Saransh Jain had previously faced the challenge of bowling a top side out in the third innings of a Test.

It was a very different examination from bowling in the first innings. The pitch was more tired, the batsmen knew their only task was survival, and every over carried greater significance. For Suthar and Jain, this was an experience being learnt in real time.

India's frustration was that Sri Lanka's resistance wasn't merely about blocking. Dinusha made them pay whenever they strayed

Jain bowled 37 overs and finished with 1 for 98. He was economical enough at times, and got the odd ball to turn, but Dinusha nullified his threat comfortably.

The seamers faced a different challenge. Mohammed Siraj, displaced throughout, finished with 1 for 26 from 15 overs. He probed the channel, made Dinusha play, and kept things tight, but the surface offered little consistent movement. Once the Sri Lankan batsmen settled, spin became India's principal weapon in trying to force a result.

India's frustration was that Sri Lanka's resistance wasn't merely about blocking. Dinusha made them pay whenever they strayed. He swept, reverse-swept and attacked when the opportunity presented itself, while knowing



Sonal Dinusha scored 133 runs from 264 balls, getting a century in both innings and earning a hard-fought draw for Sri Lanka. **PH**

when to shut the door and simply defend.

By the time he reached his hundred, Dinusha had faced 196 balls. It was his second century of the match, centuries in both innings, placing him in rare company. More importantly, it changed the complexion of the game. India knew the chance of a 2-0 win was diminishing with every passing over.

That was the cruelest part. Nuwantha's dismissal had briefly raised the possibility of a collapse, but Kumara and Dinusha made sure it didn't happen.

Every time India looked close to opening the door, another Sri Lankan batsman found a way to keep it shut.

By the final hour, the desperation had drained from India's body language. There was little chirping, little urgency, just bowlers going through the motions and batsmen eating into the overs before the game could be called off. Sri Lanka declared at 429 for 9, Dinusha unbeaten on 133. The draw had been secured.

For India, it was a missed opportunity of considerable magnitude. They had begun the final day knowing that bowling Sri Lanka out quickly and chasing the target down would have completed a 2-0 series sweep, and boosted their WTTC final qualification chances.

Instead, they left Colombo having won the series 1-0, their bowlers hanging put in the effort without finding the breakthroughs they needed on Day 5. Sri Lanka had dangled no carrot, offered no chase, and survived when India had hoped they would fall.

Why a draw in Colombo could end up costing India a World Test C'ship final spot

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, August 27

INDIA'S WORLD Test Championship (WTTC) final qualification chances took a small hit after the second Test against Sri Lanka in Colombo ended in a draw on Thursday. The result left the Shubman Gill-led side in fifth place in the 2025-27 WTTC standings.

The draw left India with a points percentage (PCT) of 51.52, with Australia, South Africa, New Zealand and Bangladesh occupying the four spots above them in the table. A win in Colombo would have taken their PCT to 63.33 and moved them up to fourth.

India now have seven Tests left in this WTTC cycle. They will play two Tests in New Zealand in November, before returning home for a five-Test series against Australia in January.

Winning six of those seven would give India 140 points and a PCT of 64.81; winning all seven would give them 152 points and a PCT of 70.37.

Even seven wins, though, wouldn't guarantee India a place in the final, since their position will also depend on how the teams above them perform. Despite the draw in Colombo, Gill remained optimistic about India's WTTC final qualification. "We are going to

World Test Championship standings

TEAM	M	W	L	D	PTS	%
Australia	10	8	2	0	96	80.00
South Africa	4	3	1	0	36	75.00
New Zealand	6	4	1	1	52	72.22
Bangladesh	6	3	2	1	40	55.56
India	11	5	4	2	68	51.52

New Zealand in November, so that's a good series for us, and then we've got a good home series coming, against Australia. So hopefully if we have a good New Zealand series, as long as we have a chance, we always keep believing, and hopefully we'll make it to the finals," he said at the post-match presentation.

India haven't won a Test in New Zealand after their last two tours, in 2014 and 2020. Their last Test win there came in 2009, when they beat New Zealand in Hamilton and went on to win the series 1-0. They have lost their last two home series too, against South Africa and New Zealand, by 2-0 and 3-0.

Australia continue to lead the WTTC table with a PCT of 80.00, after beating Bangladesh in the second Test at Mackay. Defending champions South Africa are second with 75.00, while New Zealand are third with 72.22.

Bangladesh are fourth with 55.56, leaving India just below them. The gap is a reminder of why the Colombo draw could prove costly later in the cycle.

Sri Lanka remain sixth, with a PCT of 33.33 after six Tests. They'll take plenty of confidence from the way they saved the Colombo Test, after being asked to follow on with a deficit of 213 runs.

England are seventh with 29.76, after playing 14 Tests, more than any other side. Their campaign has been hurt by eight defeats and points deductions for slow over-rates.

West Indies are eighth with 20.83, while Pakistan sit at the bottom with 19.05, after an innings-and-103-run defeat to England at Headingley.

For India, the WTTC race is still wide open. But after the missed chance in Colombo, the upcoming series against New Zealand and Australia carry even greater importance now.

'I won't say it backfired': Gill on follow-on that didn't pay dividends

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 27

INDIA CAPTAIN Shubman Gill defended his decision to enforce the follow-on against Sri Lanka despite the second Test ending in a draw, insisting it was the right call given the weather situation and the match scenario.

After taking a 213-run first-innings lead, India asked Sri Lanka to bat again but were unable to claim the 10 wickets as the hosts batted almost two days in their second innings to save the game. Gill said the decision was made with rain in mind and rejected suggestions that it had backfired.

"I won't say that the follow-on backfired. We fielded for about 250 overs. They bowled around 130 overs. Around 70 overs were lost because of rain," Gill told reporters after Day 5 on Thursday.

"We were also anticipating whether Days 4 and 5 would be possible or not. We wanted to take that chance. Either we bat one or one-and-a-half sessions on Day 4, make 200 runs, give them a target of around 400, or give them the follow-on and then score another 100 runs or whatever."

The team didn't want to take any chances with the weather, given that every Latch is crucial in the context of the World Test Championship (WTTC) final race.

"If we hadn't enforced the follow-on and it had rained, you would have asked why we didn't give the follow-on because everyone knew it was going to rain. You can always think about this decision in hindsight, but you have to make the best decision possible in the situation you are in. They (Sri Lanka) played really well. Something didn't go our way," the skipper said.

Gill, however, praised his players for maintaining their intensity throughout their match in the field.

"It gets very frustrating. You start questioning yourself - was the follow-on the best decision or not? But then you have to go back to that moment and ask yourself: Did I take the best decision at that moment? After that, you can't do anything about it. You just have to keep trying your best. I think we did that. We tried all that we could."

"From the players, you can

The team didn't want to take any chances with the weather, given that every match is crucial in the context of the WTTC final race

expect only one thing — giving 100 percent. I don't think there was any lack of intensity or effort. The spinners bowled 50-60 overs on the trot. Fielding for three days in these conditions, in this heat, is not easy. So in terms of effort, I would say 10 on 10 for the effort and the intent," he said.

Regaining rhythm

The captain dismissed concerns over Mohammed Siraj's fitness after the fast bowler sent down only 26 overs across the match, explaining that he was gaining rhythm after a lengthy break.

Siraj wasn't injured. He was playing after almost a couple of months. When someone comes back after one-and-a-half or two months, it takes time to get back into rhythm. Even in the first Test, we felt the pace was slow. But sometimes, once you play, you come back into rhythm," he said.

Gill reserved special praise for left-arm spinner Manav Suthar, who finished as the leading wicket-taker in the series with 16 scalps.

"He's been the pick of our bowlers. Even when things are not happening, he's been our go-to bowler. Especially this series, he's made gains happen for us. He's created chances, which is what I want as a captain. Wickets are never guaranteed, but you expect your bowlers to create chances."

"It should always feel like a wicket can come. I think he did that brilliantly," he opined.

A 2-0 series triumph would have boosted India's prospects of qualifying for the WTTC final but Gill felt his team remained in contention despite staying in fifth spot in the table.

"I still think we've got a pretty good chance to qualify for the WTTC. If we play the New Zealand series well, hopefully by the time the Australia series comes, if we're in a situation where we just have to win that series, we'll be in a good position," he felt.



Shubman Gill said the follow-on call was made with rain in mind. **PH**

NEXT GENERATION

Sehwag, Dravid to play for India U-19: 'Backfoot punch, cut just like Viru's'

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, August 27

SEHWAG AND Dravid will be batting together for India. Again.

Fans could be forgiven a jolt of déjà vu three weeks from now, when two iconic surames return to the blue jersey. India U-19's squad for next month's series against their Australian counterparts was announced on Thursday, featuring Aaryavir Sehwag and Anvay Dravid — sons of Virender Sehwag and Rahul Dravid, respectively.

While Anvay has represented India at this level before, it will be the debut series for the blue jersey. Anvay has been a consistent presence for Delhi U-19, most memorably scoring 297 against Meghalaya in the 2024 Cooch Behar Trophy. Had he scored 23 more, he would have surpassed his father's highest

Test score of 319 — and, per a pact with his father, earned himself a Ferrari before he became eligible to drive one.

Yogesh Nagar, Delhi U-19 coach, could sense the disappointment. Not at missing a Ferrari, but a triple hundred.

"Aaryavir was not satisfied after scoring 297. Anyone else would have been, but he has a hunger for runs that is rarely quenched. He lamented missing a triple century and we had to console him by saying it didn't matter. But moments like those tell you who is going to make it big and who is not," Nagar recalls in a conversation with *The Indian Express*.

For Nagar, Aaryavir's India U-19 selection completes a peculiar circle of life.

"I have had the unique opportunity of playing under Viru bhai's captaincy in the IPL, and am now coaching his son for Delhi U-19. I try to teach my boys what Viru bhai taught

me during our Delhi Dare-devils days. I have passed on his father's teachings to Aaryavir."

Having seen the two generations of Sehwags from close quarters, Nagar feels there are unmistakable similarities.

"Aaryavir's backfoot game is just like his father's. You could figure out that this is Virender Sehwag's son just by his batting technique."

Jaswant Rai, Nagar's predecessor with Delhi U-19, had only a handful of training sessions with Aaryavir. Yet, they were enough to stir memories of an old friend.

"Viru and I played a lot of matches together. When I first saw Aaryavir, my immediate reaction was: like father, like son. The same backfoot punch, the same cut shot," Rai, who is also Arshdeep Singh's childhood coach, tells this newspaper.

Aaryavir carries the sur-



Aaryavir Sehwag scored 297 for Delhi Under-19 in a Cooch Behar Trophy match against Meghalaya Under-19. **WEST DELHI LIONS**

name but not the ego that could easily have accompanied it.

"The most important thing is that he does not have the attitude of a star kid. There is no ego whatsoever. He knows that only runs will take him to the big stage," Nagar says.

Rai echoes: "He has always

had immense potential, but potential alone cannot take you to the top. It's very common for a kid who has come from a position of privilege to lack the determination needed to shine. But that has never been a problem with Aaryavir."

His temperament has been tested outside age-group

"The most important thing is that he does not have the attitude of a star kid. There is no ego whatsoever"

YOGESH NAGAR,
DELHI UNDER-19 COACH

cricket too. Aaryavir was part of West Delhi Lions' Delhi Premier League campaign this year, but did not always make the XI.

Ready to step up

Despite having to wait for almost the entire season to get a chance, Aaryavir would never lack enthusiasm, observed the team's mentor Uday Gupta.

"Ideally, Aaryavir should have got more chances, but we had experienced openers, so

opportunities were limited. That, though, didn't deter him from giving his best day in and day out in training," Gupta tells *The Indian Express*.

Gupte, a veteran of Delhi cricket who watched Virender Sehwag as a teenager, sees echoes beyond technique.

"I had seen Viru when he was 17, and now I have seen Aaryavir at 17. The mentality is similar. Like his father, Aaryavir likes to take down the bowler from the first ball. In only his first game this season, he hit two fours in his first five balls."

Aaryavir scored 22 off 14 in that DPL fixture. Gupta remembers his shots, but more than that, he remembers the conversation in the build-up to the game. "It was a must-win game for us. We lost three on the bounce. I told him before the game that he would be getting his chance. 'Are you ready?' I asked. He is just a kid.

But he replied: 'Sir, bas ek baar chance deke dekho ki main kya karu hu' (just give me one chance and see what I do)."

Sources have informed *The Indian Express* that the aggressive brand of batting is among the reasons why Aaryavir has been selected in the India U-19 team. With neither Vaibhav Sooryavanshi or Ayush Mhatre set to feature at the 2028 ICC U-19 World Cup, the selectors are looking at openers who can score quickly.

Not all facets, however, have been explored. "Not many know this, but he is a handy leg-spinner too. He has got a great googly. I have told him that if he hones his bowling skills, in addition to the technically astute batter that he is, he will go to the very top," says Gupta. The Indian cricket fans would hope for the same.

(With inputs from Venkata Krishna B)

After Brazil clash, India to face Uruguay on October 6

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 27

HOCKEY WORLD CUP

India show signs of life under Marijne with fifth-place finish

WITH MATCHES against Brazil and Panama confirmed, India will face another Latin American giant in 2-time FIFA World Cup winners Uruguay in Kolkata. The match which will be held in the Salt Lake Stadium on October 6, will take place just 3 days after India's historic fixture vs Brazil in the same venue on October 3.

"The Indian men's national team will welcome another heavyweight of world football to Kolkata, with two-time FIFA World Cup champions Uruguay set to face India in an international friendly match at the Vivekananda Yuba Bharati Krangan on October 6, 2026," the All India Football Federation said on Thursday.

Uruguay, who are currently ranked 20th in the world, had a disappointing World Cup this year, failing to cross the group stages. They are currently coached by the legendary Diego Simeone, who led them to a historic victory over Argentina in the 2022 World Cup final in Qatar.

This match was the latest fixture to be added to AIFF's calendar after India withdrew from the inaugural FIFA ASEAN Cup in order to prioritise their high-profile friendly against Brazil, thus avoiding a scheduling clash that had made their participation in both competitions untenable.

Meanwhile, Sree Kanteerava Stadium in Bengaluru has been chosen as the venue for the Indian senior men's team's international friendly against Panama on September 26, the AIFF said.

The fixture will mark the Blue Tigers' first appearance in Bengaluru since their SAFF Championship 2023 campaign, when India lifted the title on home soil after defeating Kuwait in the final at the same venue.

Beat Germany 3-1 to record best-ever finish at World Cup since 1974; dogged fights against top teams point to bright future for the women's team

British Raj
New Delhi, August 27

NAVNEET KAUR dodged past two German defenders, wrong footed goalkeeper Finja Starck, and dinked the ball over towards the goal to score third and decisive goal in the fifth-sixth classification match of the women's World Cup in Amsterdam on Thursday.

India defeated Germany 3-1 to finish fifth and register the best-ever finish after the inaugural 1974 World Cup where the team had finished fourth.

"We would have liked to play the semi-final but it is what it is. This fifth place finish gives us more confidence going into the Asian Games," player of the match Neha said after the game.

She is right about playing the semi-final. Ranked ninth in the world, the Indian women's team pushed above their weight holding Olympic silver medalist China, England, and Australia to draws and losing 0-2 to Netherlands creating a realistic chance to have a shot at the podium.

Finishing touch

However, the otherwise flawless finishing in the second half against Germany, was missing against the likes of the Netherlands, Australia, and England.

"I know things could have been different. Today, we were attacking but not getting anything in the first half. Then, we started going more aggressive in the second half and it resulted in goals," Neha added.

The match had a storyline of its own as Speed Marijne's team took on the team coached by India's former coach and Marijne's assistant during Tokyo Olympics, Janneke Schopmann.

While Germany had more shots and circle entries to show for, the Indian midfield controlled possession better which allowed the transition from defence to offence on multiple occasions.

The Indian team was playing on counter from the first game when Baljeet Kaur and Sakshi Rana combined on the right flank in the fifth minute. However, the German defence denied Indian skipper Salima Tete any chance to reach the ball.

Lalresiami created a great chance in the 13th minute when she found Navneet in the German circle but put too much weight on the pass as Navneet failed to reach it. In the 15th minute, India lost the video reviewing to overturn a penalty corner decision in favour of the Germans which was thwarted away by Bichu Devi.

In the second quarter, the Indian team tested Starck multiple times with the German goalkeeper making three consecutive saves to keep it 0-0 at the half-time. While India attacked more and registered four shots, it was not shown on the scoreboard.

Navneet shines

After the half-time, the Indian team not only amped up their attacks but also transitioned smoothly from defence

to attack. The first goal came in the 43rd minute when a calculated pass from Neha cut through the German defence and found Ishika whose determined run ended in 1-0 as she kept her composure to finish past Starck.

India doubled the advantage one minute later as ever-brilliant Navneet scored thundering hit from penalty corner variation to make it 2-0.

Later, Navneet turned a poacher in the 47th minute after Salima found her on the baseline and the experienced Indian forward produced one

of the most beautiful goals of the current World Cup.

One would think that had this finishing come against Australia or England, India could have been in position of podium. But as they say, hindsight in sport is nothing but wishful thinking.

After India took 3-0 lead, the German team attacked more aggressively and desperately in order to salvage something from the match. However, as good the Indian attack was, the defence also gave a testament to the skillset. India's defence handled ten circle entries of the German team and let inside just one goal in the 59th minute with Lynn Krings getting the consolation goal.

Positive show overall

Finishing just one place outside of World's top four is not something Indian fans had thought about the women's team. It was expected from the men's team but they faltered big time in both stages with a chance to finish seventh tomorrow against 2018 World Champions Belgium.

Coach Marijne, who seems to have become the lucky charm for the women's team, will have many positives to look forward to as the Asian Games close on. A gold medal at the Asian Games will give India direct Olympic qualification which the team missed in the 2024 edition. "Yes, the Asian Games is important for us and we will carry the confidence from this tournament," said Neha. India finished the tournament with two wins, three draws, and one defeat with the defeat coming against defending champions and host Netherlands.

If anything, the World Cup final hints at the potential of the Indian women's team where they can challenge reigning Asian Games champion China for a spot at the Olympics in Aichi Nagoya.

PLAYING TONIGHT: India vs Belgium (M), 9.45pm, Live on Star Sports Network & JioHotstar



Navneet Kaur scored a brace while Ishika added a third in India's 3-1 win. H

• Number Plate

52

• India's fifth-place finish at the World Cup is the best performance in 52 years. At the 1974 edition, the team finished fourth, which remains their best-ever show at the mega event.

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UEFA prepares criminal complaint against FIFA

Associated Press
Monaco, August 27

UEFA is preparing a criminal complaint against FIFA President Gianni Infantino in Swiss courts for possible financial mismanagement over his failed plan to set future World Cup host nations to private investors.

UEFA said Thursday it filed documents in a Manhattan court requesting discovery of potential evidence from the New York investment fund, Thrive Capital Management, founded by Joshua Kushner.

UEFA also filed a request in a southern Florida district for authorization of discovery "in a foreign proceeding" against FIFA itself, which has offices in the Miami suburb of Coral Gables. Thrive and Kushner were to be the anchor investors intending to pay FIFA \$4.2 billion for a 20% stake in a subsidiary that would run the soccer body's commercial events, including the World Cup.

"UEFA and its counsel are contemplating a Swiss criminal proceeding against Infantino and possibly other FIFA officials for criminal mismanagement under Article 158 of the Swiss Criminal Code," UEFA's lawyers state in a 56-page document. The document suggests the \$4.2 billion figure could be a "fraudulently off-market price promoted by Infantino for his own benefit."

UEFA first threatened to take legal action on Aug. 3 when it warned FIFA against destroying or hiding any "relevant materials." Infantino claimed that the plan would unless the commercial potential of the tournament and opportunity that FIFA has, "In truth, it is a vehicle for Infantino and that small circle to acquire a permanent stake in and otherwise profit from FIFA's most valuable assets to the detriment of FIFA, its members, and other parties within the football family."

Praggnanandhaa fights for 95 moves but Caruana holds firm in GCT final marathon

Mayank Chaudhary
New Delhi, August 27

FOR FIVE and a half hours and 95 gruelling moves, R Praggnanandhaa threw everything he had at Fabiano Caruana. There were moments when the Indian seemed poised to strike back, when the game tilted in his favour. But in the end, the American held firm, forcing Praggnanandhaa to walk away with only a draw, a result that leaves him with a six-point deficit heading into the final day of the Grand Chess Tour Finals.

With two Rapid and four Blitz games remaining on the final day, Caruana now leads the match 9-3.

After conceding a 6-0 lead in the first Classical game, Praggnanandhaa needed to respond. It wasn't quite a must-win situation, but heading into the shorter time controls with a six-point gap, far from ideal.

Determined to fight back,

Praggnanandhaa, playing White, came prepared with a sharp line in the Italian Game, hoping to land a counterpunch. Caruana responded with the Polerio Variation, offering a pawn sacrifice to gain a lead in development and open lines for his pieces.

After following the standard line, Caruana deviated with a second pawn sacrifice, a move that was neither necessary nor objectively good.

The engines slowly shifted in Praggnanandhaa's favour by the 14th move. By then, both players were out of their opening preparation. Caruana spent nearly an hour on just six moves in this phase, though Praggnanandhaa held no significant clock advantage either.

Praggnanandhaa's response after gaining a two-pawn edge wasn't his best. He avoided trading his light-squared bishop, letting Caruana manoeuvre his own



Praggnanandhaa 9-3, with 2 Rapid and 4 Blitz games left. FILE

bishop and win back a pawn, almost neutralising the position. The Indian chose to preserve his bishop pair at the cost of his second pawn.

He then went for a queen exchange, giving up his remaining pawn advantage. The game drifted into an endgame where White had a rook and bishop pair against Black's rook, bishop and knight. Caruana forced a trade of his knight for Praggnanandhaa's dark-squared bishop, entering

an opposite-coloured bishop endgame, but at the cost of a third pawn. Praggnanandhaa now had something worth fighting for, with an extra pawn.

The slow grind suddenly turned sharp as both players raced to reach time control. Praggnanandhaa traded off one pair of rooks and kept the position tense. Soon, there was more than just hope for the Indian, as Caruana began to lose his grip. Praggnanandhaa deflected Black's rook while his pawn started running down the flank. Then the American won the pawn back, a costly mistake that left Praggnanandhaa with an objectively winning position. But converting a winning position in a complex endgame is often the hardest thing in chess.

Praggnanandhaa's hope faded quickly when he let Caruana's king come to the defence, as the American gave up two more pawns to shut the game down.

Leaping over PCOD challenges, Ancy becomes India's best

Nihal Koshlie
New Delhi, August 27

PLAIN RICE was replaced by vegetables and meat, while biryani and maida-based Malabar parotta were junked by Ancy Sojan, the long jumper who broke Anju Bobby George's 22-year-old national record in June.

Before jumping 6.88 metres at the Inter-State Championships to better Anju's 6.38m, Ancy needed to manage weight gain caused by Polycystic Ovarian Disease (PCOD), diagnosed only last year.

Last week, after winning gold at the World Athletics Continental Tour Silver in Bhubaneswar, with a best jump of 6.71 metres, Ancy spoke about her struggle with PCOD.

"Now, I am 55 kilograms, but at the start of last year I was 63kg. My body fat percentage was 26 last year. I checked my fat percentage before coming to Bhubaneswar, it is just 13 now," Ancy told *The Indian Express*.

Regular periods led to weight gain and an uncontrollable craving for food, said the 25-year-old, who is bound for the Asian Games. Ancy got her first period in her late teens. "Initially, if I didn't get my period for one month, I will get it in the next month. At that time, I was very lean. But in 2025, it started to get worse. I started eating a larger quantity of food. Last year, I trained for 3 months, and all I lost was just a percent of fat."

ANCY SOJAN,
ON HER STRUGGLE WITH PCOD



Ancy Sojan jumped 6.88m at Inter-State Championships. H

Initially, if I didn't get my period for one month, I will get it in the next month. At that time, I was very lean. But in 2025, it started to get worse. I started eating a larger quantity of food. Last year, I trained for 3 months, and all I lost was just a percent of fat."

ANCY SOJAN,
ON HER STRUGGLE WITH PCOD

Anju's national record at the Inter-State Championships in June, her series of jumps read: 6.73m, foul, 6.67m, 6.72m, 6.88m and 6.69m. "Before, in India, 6.71 metres (Silver Tour) was a huge jump. Now it is average for me. 6.88 metres was a statement. From 2022 onwards, I started thinking of a 7-metre jump," Ancy said.

Focus on speed

Ancy's coach at the Jio Institute in Navi Mumbai, Anoop Joseph, said they began training for the 2026 season in September. "This year, the focus was on speed on the runway. Her strength has improved. Her clean lift is now 82kg plus. Previously, it was 75kg. She has a good technique, so that helps," Joseph said.

Speed comes naturally to her: 11.82 seconds, her best time in the 100 metres, from 2021, when she was an active sprinter.

The challenge for Ancy is to hold her peak form until the Asian Games. She broke the national record in June; the Games begin September 19. "She has to hold her peak. 6.88 metres is close to her maximum peak this season. So, we have not changed a single exercise. We don't want to add any new exercises. I know it is very boring for an athlete, but she understands. She has the potential to jump seven metres," Joseph said.

When she isn't chasing the seven-metre goal, Ancy relaxes by sketching. She started with Avengers characters printed on bags from the delivery app Blinkit, and has since graduated to a full sketchbook. "I have a second Instagram page, mis.picasso, where I post randomly. I have completed four sketchbooks. When my boyfriend said I was busy colouring, he called me 'hey Miss Picasso.' So I went with that name for Instagram."

PREMIER LEAGUE

At 41m pounds, Brentford's Sangare becomes the bargain buy of transfer season

Sandip G
New Delhi, August 27

BEFORE MAMADOU Sangare had to convince the world of his talents, he had to conquer the streets. Growing up in the Malian town of Bamako, the teenager had to beat the odds to get his age to get noticed in the streets.

"It was not 11 vs 11. There were times there were more than eleven players in a side, in grounds half the size of a normal football ground," the breakout star of Gameweek One in English Premier League top FC Lens said last year.

He shocked some of the elderly players with his courage and resistance. One of them handed him a pamphlet of Yvelin Olympique, one of the most prestigious academies in the nation, conducting a selection trials. He barely wasted time to impress the selectors.

He arrived in the stadium with a pair of battered boots. He left with a new pair of boots and a twinkle in the eye of the coaches.

His first step to a long journey that involved transits in Salzburg, Liefering, Graz, Wals, Hartberg, Vienna, and Paris, to the West London suburb of Brentford thus began. The first impressions with the Bees, in a 3-0 evisceration of Tottenham Hotspur, with the 185 million pounds midfield heart of Sandro Tonali and Matheus Fernandes, was so striking that Brentford looks like another stopover in his vault to grander stages of Europe.

It took him just six minutes to show that at 41 million pounds, he could be the bargain of the season where both Chelsea and Manchester City broke British transfer records to

purchase midfield reinforcements. He strung a supreme line-splitting pass for Keane Lewis-Potter to slap a lethal cross into the box. Six minutes later, he and Dango Ouattara tangoed in a thrilling one-two that produced the opening goal. The sequence summed up his virtues.

He gathered the ball in the inside right channel near the half-line, stroled upfield, passed to Ouattara with outside of his left foot, cut infield, burst past a pair of inattentive Spurs defenders and sewed a precise cutback to Lewis-Potter. The confidence and energy grew. At the stroke of half-time, he produced a gorgeous back-heel after a swift rictus to set-up Ouattara, who was not quite in his wavelength. He apologised and later paid compliments to the new midfield bulwark. "He is talented, confident and intelligent," he said. Lewis-Potter chimed in: "He is such a humble guy, hard-working, but he is absolutely unbelievable and he is a joy to play with every single day and all credit to him. He's someone who I can link with as well and try to build a relationship with him."

The blend of qualities is rare — rather a suit generis. His primary profile is to win the ball, which he performs with his strapping physicality and astute positioning. Midway through the first half, he redirected a Spurs counterattack by merely craning his left leg and intercepting the ball. He bullies his midfield counterparts with his raw strength and puts them under enormous pressure to concede the ball.



Mamadou Sangare joined Brentford from French club Lens. AP

He is a trickster when he wants to, sometimes feinting and dribbling, wriggling himself out of tight spaces

A marauding war machine, he has considerable elasticity too. He is a trickster when he wants to, sometimes feinting and dribbling, wriggling himself out of tight spaces with cunning. He has the qualities of a classic box-to-box midfielder with a vast repertoire of passes and vision, as well as a modern No.6 with speed and strength. "I was trained as an attacking midfielder, but I feel really comfortable in the double pivot too," he told FC Lens website.

"I'm a versatile player. I've had technical ability since I was

very young. I was lacking in physically when I first arrived in Austria, so I worked a lot on that aspect during my various loan spells. My style is really based on playing forward. It comes naturally to me. Finishing is something I'm really working on," he said. He filed a thunderous half-volley that the Spurs' goalkeeper Antonin Kinsky repelled only up to Michael Kayode to put Brentford 3-0 up. Goals would fly off his boots soon, too. His coach for the national team Tom Soaniet attests: "His multifunctional qualities are his strengths."

How he slipped through the radar of bigger clubs with a wider network of scouts is still a mystery, especially at a time when elite midfielders are the most prized asset in Europe, especially when he was pivotal to FC Lens finishing as runners-up last season. Perhaps, the

scouts overanalysed the nomadic nature of his club careers. He spent his Salzburg stint with loan spells at four different clubs. He impressed everywhere, but nowhere did he find a permanent home. Or perhaps the disciplinary record was a blot.

With Rapid Vienna, who he guided to Europa Conference League triumph in 2024, he picked up 16 yellow cards and two reds in 44 appearances across all competitions. "Sometimes I lose possession and lack concentration; those are things I need to work on," he gave a brutal self-assessment.

One summer might not make a summer. But the virtues shine in Sangare to become the next prized midfielder in the league. The boy who conquered the streets of men is ready to rule the most competitive league in the world.